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RNI No. UPENG/2022/86886

THIS IS A PUBLIC ANNOUNCEMENT FOR INFORMATION PURPOSES ONLY AND IS NOT A PROSPECTUS ANNOUNCEMENT AND DOES NOT CONSTITUTE AN INVITATION OR OFFER TO ACQUIRE, PURCHASE OR SUBSCRIBE TO SECURITIES. NOT FOR RELEASE, PUBLICATION OR DISTRIBUTION DIRECTLY OR INDIRECTLY OUTSIDE INDIA. INITIAL PUBLIC OFFER OF EQUITY SHARES OF JIO PLATFORMS LIMITED ON THE MAIN BOARD OF THE BSE LIMITED ("BSE") AND THE NATIONAL STOCK EXCHANGE OF INDIA LIMITED ("NSE" AND TOGETHER WITH BSE, THE "STOCK EXCHANGES") IN COMPLIANCE WITH CHAPTER II OF THE SECURITIES AND EXCHANGE BOARD OF INDIA (ISSUE OF CAPITAL AND DISCLOSURE REQUIREMENTS) REGULATIONS, 2018, AS AMENDED ("SEBI ICDR REGULATIONS").

JIO PLATFORMS LIMITED

(Please scan this QR code to view the Red Herring Prospectus, and the Abridged Prospectus)

(TO BE LISTED ON THE MAIN BOARD OF BSE AND NSE)

Jio Platforms Limited was incorporated on November 15, 2019, at Ahmedabad, Gujarat, as a public company limited by shares under the Companies Act, 2013, pursuant to a certificate of incorporation issued by the Registrar of Companies, Central Registration Centre. For further details, see "History and Certain Corporate Matters" on page 249 of the red herring prospectus dated October 14, 2026 (**"RHP"**).

Corporate Identity Number: U72900GJ2019PLC110816
Registered Office: Office-101, Saffron, Nr. Centre Point, Panchwati 5 Rasta, Ambawadi, Ahmedabad 380 006, Gujarat, India
Corporate Office: TC-22, 5th Floor, A Wing, Reliance Corporate Park, Thane Belapur Road, Ghansoli, Navi Mumbai 400 701, Maharashtra, India
Contact Person(s): Ms. Savithri Parekh, Company Secretary and Mr. Venkataraman Ramachandran, Compliance Officer
E-mail: jpl.investorrelations@jio.com; **Tel:** +91 22 7967 0000; **Website:** www.jio.com

OUR PROMOTER: RELIANCE INDUSTRIES LIMITED

INITIAL PUBLIC OFFER OF UP TO 270,000,000 EQUITY SHARES OF FACE VALUE OF ₹10 EACH ("EQUITY SHARES") OF JIO PLATFORMS LIMITED ("THE COMPANY" OR "ISSUER") FOR CASH AT A PRICE OF ₹ [●] PER EQUITY SHARE (INCLUDING A SECURITIES PREMIUM OF ₹ [●] PER EQUITY SHARE) ("ISSUE PRICE") AGGREGATING UP TO ₹ [●] MILLION (THE "ISSUE"). THE ISSUE INCLUDES A RESERVATION OF UP TO [●] EQUITY SHARES OF FACE VALUE OF ₹ 10 EACH FOR CASH AT A PRICE OF ₹ [●] EACH, AGGREGATING UP TO ₹ 5,000 MILLION (CONSTITUTING UP TO [●]% OF THE ISSUE), FOR SUBSCRIPTION BY ELIGIBLE EMPLOYEES ("EMPLOYEE RESERVATION PORTION") AND A RESERVATION OF UP TO [●] EQUITY SHARES OF FACE VALUE OF ₹ 10 EACH FOR CASH AT A PRICE OF ₹ [●] EACH, AGGREGATING UP TO ₹ 25,000 MILLION (CONSTITUTING UP TO [●]% OF THE ISSUE), FOR SUBSCRIPTION BY ELIGIBLE RIL SHAREHOLDERS ("RIL SHAREHOLDERS RESERVATION PORTION"). THE ISSUE LESS THE EMPLOYEE RESERVATION PORTION AND THE RIL SHAREHOLDERS RESERVATION PORTION IS HEREINAFTER REFERRED TO AS THE "NET ISSUE". THE ISSUE AND THE NET ISSUE SHALL CONSTITUTE [●]% AND [●]% OF THE POST-ISSUE PAID-UP EQUITY SHARE CAPITAL OF THE COMPANY, RESPECTIVELY. THE COMPANY, IN CONSULTATION WITH THE BRLMs, IS OFFERING A DISCOUNT OF ₹ 54 PER EQUITY SHARE OF FACE VALUE OF ₹ 10 EACH TO ELIGIBLE EMPLOYEES BIDDING IN THE EMPLOYEE RESERVATION PORTION ("EMPLOYEE DISCOUNT")

PRICE BAND: ₹ 1,065 TO ₹ 1,119 PER EQUITY SHARE OF FACE VALUE OF ₹ 10 EACH.

THE FLOOR PRICE IS 106.50 TIMES THE FACE VALUE OF THE EQUITY SHARES AND THE CAP PRICE IS 111.90 TIMES THE FACE VALUE OF THE EQUITY SHARES.

BIDS CAN BE MADE FOR A MINIMUM OF 12 EQUITY SHARES OF FACE VALUE OF ₹ 10 EACH AND IN MULTIPLES OF 12 EQUITY SHARES OF FACE VALUE OF ₹ 10 EACH THEREAFTER

THE PRICE TO EARNING RATIO ("P/E") BASED ON DILUTED EARNINGS PER SHARE ("EPS") FOR FISCAL 2026 FOR THE COMPANY AT THE LOWER END OF THE PRICE BAND IS 31.71 TIMES, AND AT THE UPPER END OF THE PRICE BAND IS 33.31 TIMES, AS COMPARED TO THE AVERAGE INDUSTRY PEER GROUP P/E RATIO OF 22.35 TIMES FOR FISCAL 2026.

A DISCOUNT OF ₹ 54 PER EQUITY SHARE IS BEING OFFERED TO ELIGIBLE EMPLOYEES BIDDING IN THE EMPLOYEE RESERVATION PORTION

BID/ISSUE PERIOD

BID/ISSUE OPENS TODAY

BID/ISSUE CLOSES ON(1): FRIDAY, OCTOBER 23, 2026

(1) UPI mandate end time and date shall be at 7:00 p.m. IST on the Bid/ Issue Closing Date.

Jio Platforms Limited, is a technology platform, built on proprietary digital technology and pan-India digital connectivity as its foundational layer, driving digital transformation in India. Our Material Subsidiary, Reliance Jio Infocomm Limited, served 533.3 million customers in India as of June 30, 2026.

THE ISSUE IS BEING MADE THROUGH THE BOOK BUILDING PROCESS IN ACCORDANCE WITH REGULATION 6(1) OF THE SEBI ICDR REGULATIONS.

THE EQUITY SHARES OF OUR COMPANY WILL BE LISTED ON THE MAIN BOARD OF THE STOCK EXCHANGES. NSE IS THE DESIGNATED STOCK EXCHANGE.

QIB PORTION: NOT MORE THAN 50% OF THE NET ISSUE | NON-INSTITUTIONAL PORTION: NOT LESS THAN 15% OF THE NET ISSUE | RETAIL PORTION: NOT LESS THAN 35% OF THE NET ISSUE

EMPLOYEE RESERVATION PORTION: UP TO [●] EQUITY SHARES OF FACE VALUE OF ₹ 10 EACH AT A PRICE OF ₹ [●] PER EQUITY SHARE AGGREGATING UP TO ₹ 5,000 MILLION
RIL SHAREHOLDERS RESERVATION PORTION: UP TO [●] EQUITY SHARES OF FACE VALUE OF ₹ 10 EACH AT A PRICE OF ₹ [●] PER EQUITY SHARE AGGREGATING UP TO ₹ 25,000 MILLION

The details of the Fresh Issue and the post Issue market capitalization of the Company, each at the Floor Price and the Cap Price, are given below:

ISSUE SIZE AND MARKET CAPITALIZATION

Particulars	At Floor Price of ₹ 1,065 per Equity Share		At Cap Price of ₹ 1,119 per Equity Share	
	Up to no. of Equity Shares of face value of ₹ 10 each	Up to Amount (In ₹ Million)	Up to no. of Equity Shares of face value of ₹ 10 each	Up to Amount (In ₹ Million)
Fresh Issue	270,000,000	287,282.94^	270,000,000	301,876.48^
Post Issue Market Capitalisation	**9,209,030,830**	**9,807,617.83**	**9,209,030,830**	**10,304,905.50**

^ Considers the impact of Employee Discount of ₹ 54 per Equity Share

IN MAKING AN INVESTMENT DECISION, POTENTIAL INVESTORS MUST RELY ONLY ON THE INFORMATION INCLUDED IN THE RED HERRING PROSPECTUS AND THE TERMS OF THE ISSUE, INCLUDING THE RISKS INVOLVED AND NOT RELY ON ANY OTHER EXTERNAL SOURCES OF INFORMATION ABOUT THE ISSUE AVAILABLE IN ANY MANNER. IN RELATION TO PRICE BAND, POTENTIAL INVESTORS SHOULD ONLY REFER TO THE PRE-ISSUE AND PRICE BAND ADVERTISEMENT DATED OCTOBER 14, 2026, AND SHOULD NOT RELY ON ANY MEDIA ARTICLES / REPORTS IN RELATION TO THE COMPANY AS THESE ARE NOT ENDORSED, PUBLISHED OR CONFIRMED EITHER BY THE COMPANY OR THE BOOK RUNNING LEAD MANAGERS TO THE ISSUE ("BRLMs").

In accordance with the recommendations of the Committee of Independent Directors of our Company, pursuant to their resolution dated October 14, 2026, the above Price Band is justified based on quantitative factors /KPIs disclosed in the 'Basis for Issue Price' section on page 126 of the RHP vis-à-vis the weighted average cost of acquisition ("WACA") of primary issuances / secondary transactions as disclosed in 'Basis for Issue Price' section on page 126 of the RHP and provided below in the advertisement and other relevant factors.

RISK TO INVESTORS

For details refer to the section titled "Risk Factors" section on page 30 of the RHP.

1. **Risk relating to telecommunication license and spectrum:** The unified licence for providing telecom services held by Reliance Jio Infocomm Limited ("RJIL") across circles in India is due for renewal in October 2033. Further, the spectrum held by RJIL is valid for a period of 20 years with the majority of the spectrum expiring between 2041 and 2042. Any inability to maintain or renew such licences or to successfully bid for any spectrum required for our operations, could have a material adverse impact on our business, financial condition and results of operations.

Continued on next page...

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2. **Dependence on Reliance Industries Limited, Reliance Retail Limited and other Reliance Group entities:** The Company and its subsidiaries have entered into various non-exclusive agreements with the Promoter, Reliance Retail Limited, a subsidiary of the Promoter and other Reliance Group entities for certain key aspects of the business. Disruption of these arrangements could significantly impact our business, financial condition and results of operations. The following table provides an overview of our significant transactions with the Promoter, Reliance Retail Limited and Sanmina-SCI India Private Limited, for the periods/Fiscals indicated.

Particulars	Parent[1]/ fellow subsidiary / joint venture of the Parent	Three months ended June 30,		Fiscal		
		2026	2025	2026	2025	2024
		(in ₹ million, unless otherwise indicated)				
Purchase of Property, Plant and Equipment and Other Intangible Assets	Parent[1] (A)	19,440	14,237	39,040	37,099	62,246
	As a percentage of Cash Capex (B = A/U)	46.46%	11.82%	11.42%	8.38%	11.63%
	Reliance Retail Limited (C)	750	2,352	5,867	14,720	9,458
	As a percentage of Cash Capex (D = C/ U)	1.79%	1.95%	1.72%	3.33%	1.77%
	Sanmina-SCI India Private Limited (E)	414	192	5,339	5,190	1,107
	As a percentage of Cash Capex (F = E/ U)	0.99%	0.16%	1.56%	1.17%	0.21%
Revenue from Operations	Parent[1] (G)	9,322	7,972	36,442	35,997	35,449
	As a percentage of Revenue from Operations (H = G/ V)	2.38%	2.28%	2.48%	2.81%	3.24%
	Reliance Retail Limited (I)	3,001	4,279	16,374	10,416	7,244
	As a percentage of Revenue from Operations (J = I/ V)	0.77%	1.22%	1.11%	0.81%	0.66%
Revenue Received in Advance[2]	Reliance Retail Limited	292,480	271,663	1,129,351	1,023,958	890,587
Professional Fees	Parent[1] (K)	5,797	7,520	26,254	29,614	23,364
	As a percentage of Total Expenses (L = K/ W)	1.95%	2.88%	2.40%	3.14%	2.87%
	Reliance Retail Limited (M)	1,082	3,232	7,671	6,730	4,601
	As a percentage of Total Expenses (N = M/ W)	0.36%	1.24%	0.70%	0.71%	0.57%
Network Operating Expenses	Parent[1] (O)	3,131	4,312	18,761	15,807	15,388
	As a percentage of Total Expenses (P = O/ W)	1.05%	1.65%	1.71%	1.68%	1.89%
Selling and Distribution Expenses	Parent[1] (Q)	-	-	-	6,299	9,449
	As a percentage of Total Expenses (R = Q/ W)	-	-	-	0.67%	1.16%
	Reliance Retail Limited (S)	10,527	11,858	43,551	35,158	30,008
	As a percentage of Total Expenses (T = S/ W)	3.54%	4.54%	3.98%	3.73%	3.69%
Cash Capex[3] (U)		41,838	120,481	341,843	442,680	535,096
Revenue from Operations (V)		391,729	350,323	1,468,853	1,282,184	1,095,581
Total Expenses (W)		297,708	261,350	1,094,060	942,057	813,674

Notes:

(1) *Parent, in this table, means the Promoter.*

(2) *Recharge vouchers sold to Reliance Retail Limited are accounted as 'Advance against services' which is disclosed as a related party transaction under the head 'Revenue received in advance'. When Reliance Retail Limited or its distributor/ sub-distributor further sells the vouchers to our customers by way of recharge to the digital connectivity services, RJIL recognises such transfer as 'Deferred revenue' and thereafter, based on the type of tariff plan, it is accounted as operating revenues in the profit & loss account. In light of the above, revenue received in advance has not been presented as a percentage of revenue from operations.*

(3) *Cash Capex refers to the cash outflow towards expenditure for property, plant and equipment, spectrum and other intangible assets less proceeds from disposal of property, plant and equipment and other intangible assets.*

3. **Dependency on Reliance Retail Limited for distribution of prepaid connectivity services:** RJIL has a master distribution agreement and a master collection agreement with RRL. RRL is the sole distributor of our pre-paid connectivity services. Our revenue from pre-paid connectivity services constituted 76.37%, 77.88%, 77.08%, 78.57% and 79.35% of our consolidated Revenue from Operations for the three months period ended June 30, 2026, June 30, 2025 and Fiscals 2026, 2025 and 2024, respectively. Any disruption in this relationship or distribution channel could adversely impact our business, financial condition and results of operations. The following table provides the details of the Revenue Received in Advance attributed to the above arrangement with RRL:

Particulars	Three months ended / As of June 30		Fiscal / As of March 31		
	2026	2025	2026	2025	2024
	(in ₹ millions)				
Revenue Received in Advance	292,480	271,663	1,129,351	1,023,958	890,587

4. **Dependency on RJIL that contributes significantly to our Revenue from Operations, EBITDA and PAT and KPIs relating to digital connectivity services:** RJIL contributed significantly to our Revenue from Operations, EBITDA and PAT in periods / Fiscals as indicated below:

Fiscals / period	RJIL's revenue from operations (in ₹ million)	% of our consolidated Revenue from Operations	RJIL's EBITDA (in ₹ million)	% of our consolidated EBITDA	RJIL's profit after tax (in ₹ million)	% of our consolidated PAT
Three months ended June 30, 2026	342,121	87.34%	195,904	93.89%	71,669	92.31%
Three months ended June 30, 2025	308,821	88.15%	173,013	95.40%	67,110	94.39%
Fiscal 2026	1,288,714	87.74%	723,544	94.88%	281,732	93.76%
Fiscal 2025	1,141,413	89.02%	612,334	95.42%	247,948	94.97%
Fiscal 2024	1,001,194	91.38%	528,784	96.21%	204,656	95.53%

Note: The financial information of RJIL provided above is on a standalone basis.

Any material adverse impact on the business, financial conditions or results of operations of RJIL would have a corresponding material adverse impact on our consolidated business, financial condition and results of operations. Further, while we operate as a technology platform, our key operational indicators ("KPIs") are primarily pertaining to our digital connectivity services provided by RJIL and do not reflect the technology platform specific metrics. Our competitors may perform more favourably on certain operational or financial KPIs, which could affect our competitive position. For details of comparison of the KPIs of our Company with listed peers, see *"Basis for Issue Price - Comparison of KPIs with Listed Industry Peers"* on page 135 of the RHP.

5. **Network, Infrastructure and Service Disruption Risk:** The uninterrupted performance, reliability and availability of our network, passive infrastructure, technology, products and services are critical to our operations and our ability to consistently deliver our digital services. Any disruption to our network, passive infrastructure and technology could impair our ability to ensure consistent performance and deliver uninterrupted customer experience, which could have a material adverse impact on our business, financial condition and results of operations, and could lead to increased churn in our customer base.
6. **Risk related to Technology change:** The connectivity industry is subject to rapid and continuous technological change, and our connectivity infrastructure faces the risk of technological obsolescence. If we are unable to respond to changes in technologies, including for instance, more competitive satellite-based broadband services and the evolving demands of our customers, we may face technological obsolescence, which would have a material adverse impact on our business, financial condition and results of operations.
7. **Risk relating to negative publicity of 'Jio' Brand:** The "Jio" trademark is owned by the Promoter, and we do not control the use of this trademark by other companies in the Reliance Group. Negative publicity arising from actions outside its control, inability to protect intellectual property or infringement claims could have a material adverse impact on our reputation, business, financial condition and results of operations.
8. **Dependency on a limited group of passive infrastructure service providers:** We rely on a limited set of passive infrastructure service providers for our operations. For instance, of the 360,537 Network Towers used by us for our operations, 174,451 Network Towers are owned by Summit Digitel Infrastructure Limited, as of June 30, 2026. Additionally, as of June 30, 2026, we rely on Jio Digital Fibre Private Limited, for substantially all our optic fibre network requirements (approximately 98%), aside from the last mile fibre network which is owned by RJIL. Any disruption in the availability of these passive infrastructure assets could have an adverse impact on our business, financial condition and results of operations.
9. **Cybersecurity, Data Privacy and Information Security Risk:** Our systems, platforms, network infrastructure, and the services provided by our Promoter and third-party technology partners are exposed to cybersecurity threats, security breaches, operational disruptions, and other technology-related risks. Any such incident or disruption could impair our operations, compromise data security, increase costs, expose us to regulatory and legal liabilities, and adversely affect our business, results of operations, financial condition, and reputation.
10. **Artificial Intelligence ("AI") and Machine Learning ("ML") Technologies Related Risk:** We rely on AI and ML technologies across our operations, including for network automation through our proprietary JioBrain platform, customer engagement and service delivery. The deployment of AI and ML technologies across our operations may not yield the desired results. Further, reliance on AI/ML technologies may expose us to inherent risks pertaining to algorithmic bias and model errors leading to inaccurate or biased outputs, which may cause reputational harm and adversely impact our business, financial condition and results of operations.
11. Our Price/Earning (P/E) ratio based on diluted EPS for Financial Year 2026 at the upper end of the price band is 33.31 as compared to the average industry peer group P/E ratio of 22.35, as of October 13, 2026.
12. Weighted Average Return on Average Net Worth for Financial Year ended 2026, 2025 and 2024 is 9.04%. Return on Average Net Worth for the three months ended June 30, 2026, and June 30, 2025 is 2.30% and 2.31% respectively (unannualized).
13. Weighted average cost of acquisition of all Equity Shares transacted in one year, 18 months and three years preceding the date of the RHP:

Period	Weighted average cost of Acquisition (in ₹)	Cap Price is 'X' times the weighted average cost of acquisition#	Range of acquisition price per Equity Shares: lowest price - highest price (in ₹)
Last one year / 18 months/ 3 years	N.A.	N.A.	N.A.

#As certified by D T S & Associates LLP, Chartered Accountants (FRN 142412W/W100595), by way of their certificate dated October 14, 2026, (UDIN 26136433YFEPPE7981).

Note: No Equity Shares were transacted in the last one year, 18 months and three years preceding the date of the Red Herring Prospectus.

14. The 19 BRLMs associated with the Issue have handled 160 public issues in the past three years, out of which 46 issues have closed below the issue price on the listing date

Book Running Lead Managers	Total public issues	Issues closed below issue price listing date
Kotak Mahindra Capital Company Limited*	-	-
Morgan Stanley India Company Private Limited*	-	-
BofA Securities India Limited*	-	-
Axis Capital Limited*	2	-
BNP Paribas*	-	-
Citigroup Global Markets India Private Limited*	-	-
CLSA India Private Limited*	-	-
DAM Capital Advisors Limited*	8	2
Goldman Sachs (India) Securities Private Limited*	-	-
HDFC Bank Limited*	-	-
HSBC Securities and Capital Markets (India) Private Limited*	-	-
ICICI Securities Limited*	5	2
IIFL Capital Services Limited *(formerly known as IIFL Securities Limited)* *	5	1
Jefferies India Private Limited*	-	-
JM Financial Limited*	3	-
J.P. Morgan India Private Limited*	-	-
SBI Capital Markets Limited*	6	4
UBS Securities India Private Limited*	-	-
360 ONE WAM Limited*	-	-
Common issues handled by the BRLMs	131	37
TOTAL	**160**	**46**

** Issues handled where there were no common BRLMs*

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ADDITIONAL INFORMATION FOR INVESTORS

1. The Company has not undertaken any pre-IPO placement from the date of filing the DRHP till date.
2. The Promoter and the Promoter Group have not undertaken any transaction of Equity Shares aggregating up to 1% or more of the paid-up equity share capital of the Company from the date of filing the DRHP till date.
3. For the pre-Issue and post-Issue equity shareholding of the Promoter, Promoter Group and top 10 public Shareholders, refer to the section titled 'Capital Structure' on page 99 of the RHP.

BASIS FOR ISSUE PRICE

(You may scan the QR code for accessing the website of Kotak Mahindra Capital Company)

*(The **"Basis for Issue Price"** section on page no. 126 of the RHP has been updated with the above price band. Please refer to the websites of the BRLMs: https://investmentbank.kotak.com, https://www.morganstanley.com/india, https://business.bofa.com/bofasindia, www.axiscapital.co.in, www.bnpparibas.co.in, www.citigroup.com/global/about-us/global-presence/india/regulatory-disclosures-investment-banking, www.india.clsa.com, www.damcapital.in, www.goldmansachs.com, www.hdfc.bank.in, www.business.hsbc.co.in, www.icicisecurities.com, www.iiflcapital.com, www.jefferies.com, www.jmfl.com, www.jpmipl.com, www.sbicaps.com, www.ubs.com/indiaoffers and www.360.one for the "Basis for Issue Price" section updated with the above price band)*

AN INDICATIVE TIMETABLE IN RESPECT OF THE ISSUE IS SET OUT BELOW:

Submission of Bids (other than Bids from Anchor Investors)

Particulars	Time
Bid/ Issue Period (except the Bid/ Issue Closing Date)	
Submission and revision in Bids	Only between 9:00 a.m. and 7:00 p.m. (Indian Standard Time ("IST"))
Bid/ Issue Closing Date*^	
Submission of electronic applications (Online ASBA through 3-in-1 accounts) – For RIIs, other than QIBs and Non-Institutional Investors, Eligible Employees Bidding in Employee Reservation Portion and Eligible RIL Shareholders Bidding in RIL Shareholders Reservation Portion	Only between 9:00 a.m. and up to 7:00 p.m. IST
Submission of electronic applications (Bank ASBA through online channels like internet banking, mobile banking and Syndicate UPI ASBA applications where Bid Amount is up to ₹ 500,000)	Only between 9:00 a.m. and up to 7:00 p.m. IST
Submission of electronic applications (Syndicate Non-Retail, Non-Individual applications for bids beyond ₹ 500,000)	Only between 9:00 a.m. and up to 7:00 p.m. IST
Submission of physical applications (Bank ASBA)	Only between 9:00 a.m. and up to 1:00 p.m. IST
Submission of physical applications (Syndicate Non-Retail, Non-Individual applications of QIBs and Non-Institutional Investors where Bid Amount is more than ₹ 500,000)	Only between 9:00 a.m. and up to 1:00 p.m. IST
Modification/ Revision/ cancellation of Bids	
Upward revision of Bids by QIBs and Non-Institutional Investors categories#	Only between 9:00 a.m. and up to 7:00 p.m. IST on Bid/ Issue Closing Date
Upward or downward revision of Bids or cancellation of Bids by RIIs, Eligible Employees Bidding in the Employee Reservation Portion and Eligible RIL Shareholders Bidding in RIL Shareholders Reservation Portion	Only between 9:00 a.m. and up to 7:00 p.m. IST on Bid/ Issue Closing Date

** UPI mandate end time and date shall be at 7:00 p.m. IST on the Bid/ Issue Closing Date.*

QIBs and Non-Institutional Investors can neither revise their bids downwards nor cancel/ withdraw their Bids.

BID/ISSUE PERIOD

Event	Indicative Date
Anchor Investor Bidding	Monday, October 19, 2026
Bid/Issue Opens on	Wednesday, October 21, 2026
Bid/Issue Closes on	Friday, October 23, 2026
Finalization of Basis of Allotment with the Designated Stock Exchange	On or about Monday, October 26, 2026
Initiation of refunds (if any, for Anchor Investors) / unblocking of funds from ASBA Account*	On or about Tuesday, October 27, 2026
Credit of Equity Shares to dematerialized accounts of Allottees	On or about Tuesday, October 27, 2026
Commencement of trading of the Equity Shares on the Stock Exchanges	On or about Wednesday, October 28, 2026

**In case of (i) any delay in unblocking of amounts in the ASBA Accounts (including amounts blocked through the UPI Mechanism) for cancelled / withdrawn / deleted ASBA Forms, the Bidder shall be compensated at a uniform rate of ₹ 100 per day or 15% per annum of the Bid Amount, whichever is higher from the date on which the request for cancellation/ withdrawal/ deletion is placed in the Stock Exchanges bidding platform until the date on which the amounts are unblocked; (ii) any blocking of multiple amounts for the same ASBA Form (for amounts blocked through the UPI Mechanism), the Bidder shall be compensated at a uniform rate ₹ 100 per day or 15% per annum of the total cumulative blocked amount except the original application amount, whichever is higher from the date on which such multiple amounts were blocked till the date of actual unblock; (iii) any blocking of amounts more than the Bid Amount, the Bidder shall be compensated at a uniform rate of ₹ 100 per day or 15% per annum of the difference in amount, whichever is higher from the date on which such excess amounts were blocked till the date of actual unblock; (iv) any delay in unblocking of non-allotted/ partially allotted Bids, exceeding two Working Days from the Bid/ Issue Closing Date, the Bidder shall be compensated at a uniform rate of ₹ 100 per day or 15% per annum of the Bid Amount, whichever is higher for the entire duration of delay exceeding two Working Days from the Bid/ Issue Closing Date by the SCSB responsible for causing such delay in unblocking. The BRLMs shall, in their sole discretion, identify and fix the liability on such intermediary or entity responsible for such delay in unblocking. The post Issue BRLMs shall be liable for compensating the Bidder at a uniform rate of ₹100 per day or 15% per annum of the Bid Amount, whichever is higher from the date of receipt of the investor grievance until the date on which the blocked amounts are unblocked. The Bidder shall be compensated in the manner specified in the ICDR Master Circular, and the SEBI RTA Master Circular, which for the avoidance of doubt, shall be deemed to be incorporated in the deemed agreement of the Company with the SCSBs, to the extent applicable.*

THE EQUITY SHARES OF OUR COMPANY WILL BE LISTED ON THE MAIN BOARD PLATFORMS OF BSE AND NSE

In case of any revision in the Price Band, the Bid/ Issue Period will be extended by at least three additional Working Days after such revision in the Price Band, subject to the Bid/ Issue Period not exceeding 10 Working Days. In cases of force majeure, banking strike or similar unforeseen circumstances, our Company in consultation with the BRLMs, may, for reasons to be recorded in writing, extend the Bid/ Issue Period for a minimum of one Working Day, subject to the Bid/ Issue Period not exceeding 10 Working Days in compliance with the SEBI ICDR Regulations. Any revision in the Price Band and the revised Bid/ Issue Period, if applicable, shall be widely disseminated by notification to the Stock Exchanges, by issuing a public notice, and also by indicating the change on the respective websites of the BRLMs and at the terminals of the Syndicate Members and by intimation to the Self-Certified Syndicate Banks ("**SCSBs**"), other Designated Intermediaries and the Sponsor Bank(s), as applicable. However, in case of revision in the Price Band, the Bid Lot shall remain the same.

The Issue is being made through the Book Building Process, in terms of Rule 19(2)(b) of the SCRR read with Regulation 31 of the SEBI ICDR Regulations and in compliance with Regulation 6(1) of the SEBI ICDR Regulations, wherein not more than 50% of the Net Issue shall be allocated on a proportionate basis to Qualified Institutional Buyers ("**QIBs**") ("**QIB Portion**"), provided that our Company, in consultation with the Book Running Lead Managers may allocate up to 60% of the QIB Portion to Anchor Investors on a discretionary basis in accordance with the SEBI ICDR Regulations ("**Anchor Investor Portion**"), and 40% of such Anchor Investor Portion shall be reserved as under: (i) 33.33% for domestic Mutual Funds, and (ii) 6.67% for Life Insurance Companies and Pension Funds, subject to valid Bids being received from domestic Mutual Funds, Life Insurance Companies and Pension Funds at or above the Anchor Investor Allocation Price. In the event of under-subscription, or non-allocation in the Anchor Investor Portion, the balance Equity Shares shall be added to the QIB Portion ("**Net QIB Portion**"). Further, 5% of the Net QIB Portion shall be available for allocation on a proportionate basis only to Mutual Funds, subject to valid Bids being received at or above the Issue Price, and the remainder of the Net QIB Portion shall be available for allocation on a proportionate basis to all QIBs, including Mutual Funds subject to valid Bids being received at or above the Issue Price. However, if the aggregate demand from Mutual Funds is less than 5% of the Net QIB Portion, the balance Equity Shares available for allocation in the Mutual Fund Portion will be added to the remaining Net QIB Portion for proportionate allocation to all QIBs. Further, not less than 15% of the Net Issue shall be available for allocation to Non- Institutional Bidders and not less than 35% of the Net Issue shall be available for allocation to Retail Individual Bidders ("**RIBs**") in accordance with the SEBI ICDR Regulations, subject to valid Bids being received at or above the Issue Price. One-third of the Non-Institutional Portion shall be available for allocation to Non-Institutional Bidders with a Bid size of more than ₹ 200,000 and up to ₹ 1,000,000 and two-thirds of the Non-Institutional Portion shall be available for allocation to Non-Institutional Bidders with a Bid size of more than ₹ 1,000,000 provided that under-subscription in either of these two sub-categories of the Non-Institutional Portion may be allocated to Non-Institutional Bidders in the other sub-category of Non-Institutional Portion in accordance with the SEBI ICDR Regulations, subject to valid Bids being received at or above the Issue Price. Further, Equity Shares will be allocated on a proportionate basis to Eligible Employees Bidding in the Employee Reservation Portion, and Eligible Shareholders Bidding in the RIL Shareholders Reservation Portion subject to valid Bids received from them at or above the Issue Price. All potential Bidders (except Anchor Investors) are mandatorily required to participate in the Issue through the Application Supported by Blocked Amount ("**ASBA**") process by providing details of their respective ASBA accounts and UPI ID in case of UPI Bidders, as applicable, pursuant to which their corresponding Bid Amount will be blocked by the Self Certified Syndicate Banks ("**SCSBs**") or by the Sponsor Bank(s) under the UPI Mechanism, as the case may be, to the extent of the respective Bid Amounts. Anchor Investors are not permitted to participate in the Issue through the ASBA process. For details, see *"Issue Procedure"* beginning on page 534 of the RHP.

Bidders/ Applicants should ensure that DP ID, PAN, Client ID and UPI ID (for UPI Bidders bidding through the UPI Mechanism) are correctly filled in the Bid cum Application Form. The DP ID, PAN and Client ID provided in the Bid cum Application Form should match with the DP ID, PAN, Client ID available in the Depository database, otherwise, the Bid cum Application Form is liable to be rejected. Bidders/ Applicants should ensure that the beneficiary account provided in the Bid cum Application Form is active. Bidders/Applicants should note that on the basis of the PAN, DP ID, Client ID and UPI ID (for UPI Bidders bidding through the UPI Mechanism) as provided in the Bid cum Application Form, the Bidder/Applicant may be deemed to have authorised the Depositories to provide to the Registrar to the Issue, any requested Demographic Details of the Bidder/Applicant as available on the records of the depositories. These Demographic Details may be used, among other things, for giving Allotment Advice or unblocking of ASBA Account or for other correspondence(s) related to the Issue. Bidders/Applicants are advised to update any changes to their Demographic Details as available in the records of the Depository Participant to ensure accuracy of records. Any delay resulting from failure to update the Demographic Details would be at the Bidders'/Applicants' sole risk. Investors must ensure that their PAN is linked with Aadhaar and are in compliance with the CBDT notification dated February 13, 2020 and press release dated June 25, 2021, read with press release dated September 17, 2021 and CBDT circular no.7 of 2022, dated March 30, 2022 read with press release dated March 28, 2023 and any subsequent press releases in this regard.

Contents of the Memorandum of Association of our Company as regards its objects: For information on the main objects of our Company, please see the section "*History and Certain Corporate Matters*" on page 249 of the RHP. The Memorandum of Association of our Company is a material document for inspection in relation to the Issue. For further details, please see the section titled "*Material Contracts and Documents for Inspection*" on page 577 of the RHP.

Liability of the members of our Company: Limited by shares.

Amount of share capital of our Company and capital structure: As on the date of the RHP, the authorised share capital of our Company is ₹1,900,000,000,000 divided into 10,000,000,000 Equity Shares of face value of ₹10 each and 180,000,000,000 preference shares of face value of ₹10 each. The issued, subscribed and paid-up Equity share capital of our Company is ₹89,390,308,300 divided into 8,939,030,830 Equity Shares of face value of ₹10 each. For more details of the capital structure of the Company, see "Capital Structure" beginning on page 99 of the RHP.

Names of the initial signatories to the Memorandum of Association of the Company and the Number of Equity Shares Subscribed by them: The initial signatories to the Memorandum of Association of the Company is Reliance Industries Limited (including one Equity Share each allotted to six individuals as nominees of RIL) (10,000 Equity Shares of face value of ₹10 each). For more details of the share capital history of our Company please see "Capital Structure" beginning on page 99 of the RHP.

Listing: The Equity Shares offered through the RHP are proposed to be listed on the Stock Exchanges. Our Company has received 'in-principle' approvals from BSE and NSE for the listing of the Equity Shares pursuant to their letters each dated July 7, 2026. For the purposes of the Issue, the Designated Stock Exchange shall be NSE. A signed copy of the RHP and the Prospectus has been and shall be delivered to the RoC as applicable, in accordance with Sections 26(4) and 32 of the Companies Act, 2013. For details of the material contracts and documents available for inspection from the date of the Red Herring Prospectus up to the Bid/ Issue Closing Date, see "Material Contracts and Documents for Inspection" beginning on page 577 of the RHP.

Disclaimer clause of the SEBI: SEBI only gives its observations on the Issue documents and this does not constitute approval of either the Issue or the specified securities stated in the Issue document. The investors are advised to refer to page 488 of the RHP for the full text of the disclaimer clause of SEBI.

Disclaimer clause of NSE (Designated Stock Exchange): It is to be distinctly understood that the permission given by NSE should not in any way be deemed or construed that the RHP has been cleared or approved by NSE nor does it certify the correctness or completeness of any of the contents of the RHP. The investors are advised to refer to page 493 of the RHP for the full text of the Disclaimer Clause of NSE.

Disclaimer clause of BSE: It is to be distinctly understood that the permission given by BSE should not in any way be deemed or construed that the RHP has been cleared or approved by BSE nor does it certify the correctness or completeness of any of the contents of the RHP. The investors are advised to refer to page 493 of the RHP for the full text of the Disclaimer Clause of BSE.

General risk: Investments in equity and equity-related securities involve a degree of risk and investors should not invest any funds in the Issue unless they can afford to take the risk of losing their entire investment. Investors are advised to read the risk factors carefully before taking an investment decision in the Issue. For taking an investment decision, investors must rely on their own examination of our Company and the Issue, including the risks involved. The Equity Shares in the Issue have not been recommended or approved by SEBI, nor does SEBI guarantee the accuracy or adequacy of the contents of the RHP. Specific attention of the investors is invited to "**Risk Factors**" beginning on page 30 of the RHP

BOOK RUNNING LEAD MANAGERS

Kotak Mahindra Capital Company Limited
1st Floor, 27 BKC, Plot No. C27, 'G' Block
Bandra Kurla Complex, Bandra (East) , Mumbai - 400 051
Maharashtra, India
Tel: +91 22 4336 0000
E-mail: jio.ipo@kotak.com
Investor Grievance E-mail: kmccredressal@kotak.com
Website: https://investmentbank.kotak.com
Contact Person: Ganesh Rane
SEBI Registration No.: INM000008704

Morgan Stanley India Company Private Limited
Altimus, Level 39 & 40
Pandurang Budhkar Marg, Worli, Mumbai - 400 018
Maharashtra, India
Tel: +91 22 6118 1000
E-mail: jpl_ipo@morganstanley.com
Investor Grievance E-mail:
investors_india@morganstanley.com
Website: https://www.morganstanley.com/india
Contact Person: Keyur Thakar/ Hrithik Khanna
SEBI Registration No.: INM000011203

BofA Securities India Limited
Ground Floor, "A" Wing, One BKC, "G" Block
Bandra Kurla Complex, Bandra (East), Mumbai - 400 025
Maharashtra, India
Tel: +91 22 6632 8000
E-mail: dg.jpl_ipo@bofa.com
Investor Grievance E-mail:
dg.india_merchantbanking@bofa.com
Website: https://business.bofa.com/bofasindia
Contact Person: Sahil H. Jain
SEBI Registration No.: INM000011625

Axis Capital Limited
1st Floor, Axis House
P.B. Marg, Worli, Mumbai - 400 025, Maharashtra, India
Tel: +91 22 4325 2183
E-mail: jio.ipo@axiscap.in
Investor Grievance E-mail: complaints@axiscap.in
Website: www.axiscapital.co.in
Contact Person: Sanaea Sumondy/ Simran Gadh
SEBI Registration No: INM000012029

BNP Paribas
1, North Avenue Maker Maxity
Bandra-Kurla Complex, Bandra (E), Mumbai - 400 051
Maharashtra, India
Tel: +91 22 3370 4000
E-mail: LIST.CIB.JioIPO@asia.bnpparibas.com
Investor Grievance E-mail:
indiainvestors.care@asia.bnpparibas.com
Website: www.bnpparibas.co.in
Contact Person: Ankur Thacker
SEBI Registration No.: INM000011534

Citigroup Global Markets India Private Limited
1202, 12th Floor, First International Financial Center, G Block
Bandra Kurla Complex, Bandra (East), Mumbai - 400 098
Maharashtra, India
Tel: +91 22 6175 9999
E-mail: jio.ipo@citi.com
Investor Grievance E-mail: investors.cgmib@citi.com
Website: www.citigroup.com/global/about-us/global-presence/india/regulatory-disclosures-investment-banking
Contact Person: Naman Kulshreshtha
SEBI Registration No.: INM000010718

CLSA India Private Limited
8/F Dalamal House
Nariman Point, Mumbai - 400 021, Maharashtra, India
Tel: +91 22 6650 5050
E-mail: jio.ipo@clsa.com
Investor Grievance E-mail: investor.helpdesk@clsa.com
Website: www.india.clsa.com
Contact Person: Prachi Chandgothia
SEBI Registration No.: INM000010619

DAM Capital Advisors Limited
Altimus 2202, Level 22
Pandurang Budhkar Marg, Worli, Mumbai - 400 018
Maharashtra, India
Tel: +91 22 4202 2500
E-mail: jio.ipo@damcapital.in
Investor Grievance E-mail: complaint@damcapital.in
Website: www.damcapital.in
Contact Person: Aanchal Wagle/ Jay Shah
SEBI Registration No.: MB/INM000011336

Goldman Sachs (India) Securities Private Limited
9th and 10th Floor, Ascent-Worli
Sudam Kalu Ahire Marg, Worli, Mumbai - 400 025
Maharashtra, India
Tel: +91 22 6616 9000
E-mail: jioipo@gs.com
Investor Grievance E-mail: india-client-support@gs.com
Website: www.goldmansachs.com
Contact Person: Saurav S
SEBI Registration No.: INM000011054

HDFC Bank Limited
Investment Banking Group
Unit no. 701, 702 and 702-A, 7th Floor, Tower 2 and 3
One International Centre, Senapati Bapat Marg, Prabhadevi
Mumbai - 400 013, Maharashtra, India
Tel: +91 22 3395 8233
E-mail: jioplatforms.ipo@hdfc.bank.in
Investor Grievance E-mail: investor.redressal@hdfcbank.com
Website: www.hdfc.bank.in
Contact Person: Bharti Ranga/ Souradeep Ghosh
SEBI Registration No.: INM000011252

HSBC Securities and Capital Markets (India) Private Limited
52/60, Mahatma Gandhi Road, Fort, Mumbai - 400 001
Maharashtra, India
Tel: +91 22 6864 1289
E-mail: jplipo@hsbc.co.in
Investor Grievance E-mail: investorgrievance@hsbc.co.in
Website: www.business.hsbc.co.in
Contact Person: Harsh Thakkar/ Harshit Tayal
SEBI Registration No.: INM000010353

ICICI Securities Limited
Appasaheb Marathe Marg, Prabhadevi, Mumbai - 400 025
Maharashtra, India
Tel: +91 22 6807 7100
E-mail: jioplatforms.ipo@icicisecurities.com
Investor Grievance E-mail: customercare@icicisecurities.com
Website: www.icicisecurities.com
Contact Person: Ramesh Vaswana / Soumavo Sarkar
SEBI Registration No.: INM000011179

IIFL Capital Services Limited
(formerly known as IIFL Securities Limited)
24th Floor, One Lodha Place
Senapati Bapat Marg, Lower Parel (West), Mumbai - 400 013
Maharashtra, India
Tel: +91 22 4646 4728
E-mail: jio.ipo@iiflcap.com
Investor Grievance E-mail: ig.ib@iiflcap.com
Website: www.iiflcapital.com
Contact Person: Gaurav Mittal/ Pawan Kumar Jain
SEBI Registration No.: INM000010940

Jefferies India Private Limited
Level 16, Express Towers
Nariman Point, Mumbai - 400 021, Maharashtra, India
Tel: +91 22 4356 6000
E-mail: Jio.Platforms.IPO@jefferies.com
Investor Grievance E-mail: jipl.grievance@jefferies.com
Website: www.jefferies.com
Contact Person: Akshat Shah/ Meghna Biju
SEBI Registration No.: INM000011443

JM Financial Limited
7th Floor, Cnergy, Appasaheb Marathe Marg
Prabhadevi, Mumbai - 400 025, Maharashtra, India
Tel: +91 22 6630 3030
E-mail: jpl.ipo@jmfl.com
Investor Grievance E-mail: grievance.ibd@jmfl.com
Website: www.jmfl.com
Contact Person: Prachee Dhuri
SEBI Registration No.: INM000010361

J.P. Morgan India Private Limited
J.P. Morgan Towers
Off C.S.T Road, Kalina, Santacruz (East),
Mumbai - 400 098 Maharashtra, India
Tel: +91 22 6157 3000
E-mail: JIO_IPO@jpmorgan.com
Investor Grievance E-mail:
investorsmb.jpmipl@jpmorgan.com
Website: www.jpmipl.com
Contact Person: Shivam Goel/ Rishank Chheda
SEBI Registration No.: INM000002970

SBI Capital Markets Limited
1501, 15th Floor, A & B Wing, G Block,
Parinee Crescenzo, Bandra Kurla Complex,
Bandra (East), Mumbai - 400 051 Maharashtra, India
Tel: +91 22 4006 9807
E-mail: jio.ipo@sbicaps.com
Website: www.sbicaps.com
Investor Grievance E-mail:
investor.relations@sbicaps.com
Contact Person: Krithika Shetty/ Prashant Patankar
SEBI Registration No.: INM000003531

UBS Securities India Private Limited
Unit 2901, Level 29, Altimus,
Dr. GM Gokhale Marg /
Pandurang Budhkar Road,
Worli, Mumbai - 400 018, Maharashtra, India
Tel: +91 22 6155 6000
E-mail: OL-jioipo@ubs.com
Website: www.ubs.com/indiaoffers
Investor Grievance E-mail: igbmindia@ubs.com
Contact Person: Vidhit Patni
SEBI Registration No.: INM000013101

360 ONE WAM Limited
360 ONE Centre, Kamala City
Senapati Bapat Marg, Lower Parel (West),
Mumbai - 400 013 Maharashtra, India
Tel: +91 22 4031 7000
Email: jioplatforms.ipo@360.one
Investor Grievance E-mail:
mbinvestorcomplaints@360.one
Website: www.360.one
Contact Person: Devesh Patkar
SEBI Registration No.: INM000012801

REGISTRAR TO THE ISSUE

KFin Technologies Limited
Selenium Tower-B, Plot No. 31 & 32, Gachibowli,
Financial District, Nanakramguda, Serilingampally
Hyderabad - 500 032, Telangana, India
Tel: + 91 40 6716 2222/ 1800 309 4001
E-mail: jioplatforms.ipo@kfintech.com
Investor Grievance E-mail:
einward.ris@kfintech.com
Website: www.kfintech.com
Contact Person: Williams R
SEBI Registration No.: INR000000221

Company Secretary
Ms. Savithri Parekh

Compliance Officer
Mr. Venkataraman Ramachandran

TC-22, 5th Floor, A Wing, Reliance Corporate Park,
Thane Belapur Road, Ghansoli,
Navi Mumbai 400 701Maharashtra, India
Tel: +91 22 7967 0000
E-mail: jpl.investorrelations@jio.com

Investors may contact the Company Secretary or Compliance Officer or the Registrar to the Issue in case of any pre-Issue or post-Issue related grievances including non-receipt of letters of Allotment, non-credit of Allotted Equity Shares in the respective beneficiary account, non-receipt of refund orders or non-receipt of funds by electronic mode, etc. For all Issue related queries and for redressal of complaints, investors may also write to the BRLMs.

Continued on next page...

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AVAILABILITY OF THE RHP:

Investors are advised to refer to the RHP and the section titled **"Risk Factors"** on page 30 of the RHP, before applying in the Issue. A copy of the RHP is made available on website of SEBI at **www.sebi.gov.in**, websites of the Stock Exchanges i.e. BSE Limited and National Stock Exchange of India Limited at **www.bseindia.com** and **www.nseindia.com**, respectively, and on the website of the Company at **https://www.jio.com**; and on the websites of the BRLMs, i.e. **Kotak Mahindra Capital Company Limited** – https://investmentbank.kotak.com; **Morgan Stanley India Company Private Limited** – https://www.morganstanley.com/india; **BofA Securities India Limited** – https://business.bofa.com/bofasindia; **Axis Capital Limited** – www.axiscapital.co.in; **BNP Paribas** – www.bnpparibas.co.in; **Citigroup Global Markets India Private Limited** – www.citigroup.com/global/about-us/global-presence/india/regulatory-disclosures-investment-banking; **CLSA India Private Limited** – www.india.clsa.com; **DAM Capital Advisors Limited** – www.damcapital.in; **Goldman Sachs (India) Securities Private Limited** – www.goldmansachs.com; **HDFC Bank Limited** – www.hdfc.bank.in; **HSBC Securities and Capital Markets (India) Private Limited** – www.business.hsbc.co.in; **ICICI Securities Limited** – www.icicisecurities.com; **IIFL Capital Services Limited** – www.iiflcapital.com; **Jefferies India Private Limited** – www.jefferies.com; **JM Financial Limited** – www.jmfl.com; **J.P. Morgan India Private Limited** – www.jpmipl.com; **SBI Capital Markets Limited** – www.sbicaps.com; **UBS Securities India Private Limited** – www.ubs.com/indiaoffers; **360 ONE WAM Limited** – www.360.one;.

AVAILABILITY OF THE ABRIDGED PROSPECTUS:

A copy of the abridged prospectus is made available on the website of the Company, the BRLMs and the Registrar to the Issue at **https://www.jio.com/platforms/** ; **Kotak Mahindra Capital Company Limited** – https://investmentbank.kotak.com; **Morgan Stanley India Company Private Limited** – https://www.morganstanley.com/india; **BofA Securities India Limited** – https://business.bofa.com/bofasindia; **Axis Capital Limited** – www.axiscapital.co.in; **BNP Paribas** – www.bnpparibas.co.in; **Citigroup Global Markets India Private Limited** – www.citigroup.com/global/about-us/global-presence/india/regulatory-disclosures-investment-banking; **CLSA India Private Limited** – www.india.clsa.com; **DAM Capital Advisors Limited** – www.damcapital.in; **Goldman Sachs (India) Securities Private Limited** – www.goldmansachs.com; **HDFC Bank Limited** – www.hdfc.bank.in; **HSBC Securities and Capital Markets (India) Private Limited** – www.business.hsbc.co.in; **ICICI Securities Limited** – www.icicisecurities.com; **IIFL Capital Services Limited** – www.iiflcapital.com; **Jefferies India Private Limited** – www.jefferies.com; **JM Financial Limited** – www.jmfl.com; **J.P. Morgan India Private Limited** – www.jpmipl.com; **SBI Capital Markets Limited** – www.sbicaps.com; **UBS Securities India Private Limited** – www.ubs.com/indiaoffers; **360 ONE WAM Limited** – www.360.one; Registrar to the Issue, **KFin Technologies Limited** – www.kfintech.com., respectively.

AVAILABILITY OF BID CUM APPLICATION FORMS:

Bid cum Application Forms can be obtained from the Registered and Corporate Office of **JIO PLATFORMS LIMITED**, **Tel**: +91 22 7967 0000; BRLMs: **Kotak Mahindra Capital Company Limited,** Telephone: +91 22 4336 0000**; Morgan Stanley India Company Private Limited,** Telephone: +91 22 6118 1000**; BofA Securities India Limited,** Telephone: +91 22 6632 8000**; Axis Capital Limited,** Telephone: +91 22 4325 2183**; BNP Paribas,** Telephone: +91 22 3370 4000**; Citigroup Global Markets India Private Limited,** Telephone: +91 22 6175 9999**; CLSA India Private Limited,** Telephone: +91 22 6650 5050**; DAM Capital Advisors Limited,** Telephone: +91 22 4202 2500**; Goldman Sachs (India) Securities Private Limited,** Telephone: +91 22 6616 9000**; HDFC Bank Limited,** Telephone: +91 22 3395 8233**; HSBC Securities and Capital Markets (India) Private Limited,** Telephone: +91 22 6864 1289**; ICICI Securities Limited,** Telephone: +91 22 6807 7100**; IIFL Capital Services Limited,** Telephone: +91 22 4646 4728**; Jefferies India Private Limited,** Telephone: +91 22 4356 6000**; JM Financial Limited,** Telephone: +91 22 6630 3030**; J.P. Morgan India Private Limited,** Telephone: +91 22 6157 3000**; SBI Capital Markets Limited,** Telephone: +91 22 4006 9807**; UBS Securities India Private Limited,** Telephone: +91 22 6155 6000**; and 360 ONE WAM Limited,** Telephone: +91 22 4031 7000**; Syndicate Members: HDFC Securities Limited** Tel: +91 2230753400, **Investec Capital Services (India) Private Limited** Tel: + 91 2268497400, **JM Financial Services Limited** Tel: +91 22 6136 3400, **Kotak Securities Limited** Tel: +91 2242858484, **SBICAP Securities Limited** Tel: +91 22 6943 2521, **Sharekhan Limited** Tel: +91 22 6750 2000, **360 ONE Capital Market Private Limited** ***(Formerly known as Batlivala & Karani Securities India Private Limited)*** Tel: + 91 022 40317000 / +91 022 40076000 **and 360 ONE Distribution Services Limited** Tel: 9321332882 and at the select locations of the Sub-syndicate Members (as given below), SCSBs, Registered Brokers, RTAs and CDPs participating in the Issue. Bid cum Application Forms will also be available on the websites of BSE and NSE and the Designated Branches of SCSBs, the list of which is available at websites of the Stock Exchanges and SEBI.

Sub-Syndicate Members:

Almondz Global Securities Ltd, Ambit Capital Limited, Ambit Private Limited, Amrapali Capital & Finance Services Limited, Anand Rathi Share & Stock Brokers Limited, Anand Share Consultancy, ANS Pvt Limited, Asit C Mehta Financial Services Limited, Asit C Mehta Investment Intermediates Limited, Axis Securities Limited, Bajaj Financial Securities Limited, Bob Capital Markets Limited, Centrum Broking Limited, Centrum Capital Advisors Limited, Centrum Finverse limited, Centrum Wealth Management Ltd, Choice Equity Broking Private Limited, Dalal & Broacha Stock Broking Pvt Limited, DB(International) Stock Brokers Ltd, Eureka Stock & Share Broking Services Ltd, G Raj & Co. (Consultants) Limited, Globe Capital Market Limited, IDBI Capital Market Services Limited, Inga Ventures Pvt Ltd, Innovate Securities Pvt Limited, Intensive Fiscal Services Private Limited, Jhaveri Securities, Jobanputra Fiscal Services Private Limited, Kalpataru Multiplier Limited, Kantilal Chhaganlal Securities Pvt.Ltd, Keynote Capitals Limited, KJMC Capital Market Services Limited, Lakshmishree Investment & Securities Pvt Limited, LKP Securities Limited, Marwadi Shares & Finance Ltd, Mehta Equities Limited, Monarch Networth Capital Limited, Motilal Oswal Financial Services Limited, Motilal Oswal Securities Limited, Nextbillion Technology Private Limited, Nirmal Bang Securities Pvt Limited, Nuvama Wealth and Investment Limited (Edelweiss Broking Limited), Nuvama Wealth Management Limited, Pantomath Financial Services Limited, Patel Wealth Advisors Pvt Limited, Paytm, Prabhudas Lilladher Pvt Limited, Pravin Ratilal Share & Stock Brokers Limited, Religare Broking Limited, Religare Securities Limited, Rikhav Securities Ltd, RR Equity Brokers Private Limited, SMC Global Securities Limited, Standard Chartered Securities, Sundae Capital, Sunidhi Securities & Finance Ltd, Sushil Financial Services Pvt. Ltd., Systematix Shares & Stocks (India) Limited, Tanna Financial Services, Tradebulls Securities Private Limited, Trust Securities Limited, Viren M Shah, YES Securities (India) Limited, Zerodha

Escrow Collection Banks: Axis Bank Limited and ICICI Bank Limited

Refund Banks: Axis Bank Limited and ICICI Bank Limited

Public Issue Account Banks: Kotak Mahindra Bank Limited and State Bank of India

Sponsor Banks: Axis Bank Limited, ICICI Bank Limited, Kotak Mahindra Bank Limited and State Bank of India

UPI: UPI Bidders can also bid through UPI mechanism

Jio Platforms Limited has provided a toll free number to address any queries related to the Issue.

Toll free number: 1800 309 4001

You may also address your queries related to the Issue by typing **'Hi'** or **'Hello'** on

WhatsApp to 7977222222

For JIO PLATFORMS LIMITED
On behalf of the Board of Directors

Sd/-
Ms. Savithri Parekh
Company Secretary

Place : Mumbai, Maharashtra
Date : October 21, 2026

All capitalised terms used herein and not specifically defined shall have the same meaning as ascribed to them In the RHP.

Jio Platforms Limited is proposing, subject to receipt of requisite approvals, market conditions and other considerations, to make an initial public offering of its Equity Shares and has filed the RHP with RoC on October 14, 2026. The RHP is made available on the website of SEBI at www.sebi.gov.in, on the websites of the Stock Exchanges, i.e. BSE at www.bseindia.com and NSE at www.nseindia.com, on the website of the Company at www.jio.com and on the respective websites of the BRLMs. Any potential investors should note that investment in equity shares involves a high degree of risk, and for details relating to such risk, please see the section titled "**Risk Factors**" on page 30 of the RHP. Potential investors should not rely on the DRHP filed with SEBI and the Stock Exchanges for making any investment decision and should instead rely on the RHP, as filed with the RoC, for making investment decisions.

This announcement is not an offer of securities for sale in the United States or elsewhere. This announcement has been prepared for publication in India only and is not for publication or distribution, directly or indirectly, in or into the United States. The Equity Shares offered in the Issue have not been and will not be registered under the U.S. Securities Act of 1933, as amended (**"U.S. Securities Act"**) or any state securities laws in the United States, and unless so registered, may not be offered or sold within the United States, except pursuant to an exemption from, or in a transaction not subject to, the registration requirements of the U.S. Securities Act and applicable state securities laws in the United States. Accordingly, the Equity Shares are being offered and sold (i) in the United States solely to "qualified institutional buyers" (as defined in Rule 144A under the U.S. Securities Act) in transactions exempt from, or not subject to, the registration requirements of the U.S. Securities Act, or (ii) outside the United States in "offshore transactions," as defined in, and in reliance on Regulation S under the U.S. Securities Act and the applicable laws of the jurisdictions where such offers and sales occur. There will be no public offering of Equity Shares in the United States.

'We want to be a global tech provider, moving beyond equipment vendor role'

AIMING HIGH. Akash Ambani outlines Jio Platforms' growth strategy ahead of IPO on Wednesday and its plans across the telecom and satellite communications space

bl.interview

Vallari Sanzgiri
Mumbai

Bullish on global ambitions for its indigenous 5G technology, Jio Platforms Managing Director Akash Ambani told *businessline* in an e-mail interview that the company aspires to be more an equipment vendor, serving offerings from cloud-native radio access network (RAN) to business software systems, as a managed service. Ambani also outlined Jio's growth strategy ahead of India's largest IPO and its plans across the telecom and satcom space. *Edited excerpts:*

What led to the decision to take Jio's technology stack overseas?
We designed our stack for India's scale, with cost and quality beating global benchmarks at scale, and that is our proof point. Our team built and runs an end-to-end technology stack at scale in India. We believe that experience has global relevance, particularly for operators looking to upgrade networks, expand 5G, and extend broadband access. Our approach is to work with local operators as a managed-services partner, rather than simply sell licences. Operators in many markets face the jobs we faced: upgrading networks, rolling out 5G and taking broadband into homes. We want to take on those jobs alongside local operators, running our technology under managed-services arrangements instead of simply selling hardware or software licences. We will be selective, and back only partnerships where both sides gain.

Jio has said it wants to take its indigenous 5G technology global. How much of your own RAN equipment are you actually using in Jio's network today and do you believe Jio can realistically become a global competitor to Ericsson and Nokia in telecom equipment?
At heart, we are a technology company. Our team designed, built and deployed the Jio network primarily on proprietary technology, from the radio access network to the core. We developed our own end-to-end 5G SA stack, deployed more than one million 5G cells within a year of launch, and have filed 7,220 patent applications across 4G, 5G and 6G. Abroad, we are not setting out to be one more equipment vendor: we want to offer operators that stack, from cloud-native RAN to OSS/BSS (operating support systems/business support systems), as a managed service.

Do you believe India needs at least three strong private telecom operators for a healthy competitive market? Or are concerns around a duopoly in the telecom market misplaced?
A healthy digital ecosystem depends on sustained investment, innovation, service quality and inclusivity. Competition has an important role in encouraging operators to improve their networks and offerings, simultaneously ensuring that customers continue to receive best-in-class services at affordable prices. Our responsibility is to keep investing in technology and connectivity, as well as create value for the customers and businesses we serve. We will continue to focus on execution and on contributing to India's digital ambitions.



> A healthy digital ecosystem depends on sustained investment, innovation, service quality and inclusivity
>
> **AKASH AMBANI**
> Managing Director, Jio Platforms

Jio has repeatedly positioned itself as a company that democratised digital access by bringing down prices. Do you think that phase of aggressive price competition is over?

Affordability is how we built Jio, and it remains central to what we do. It is also why our engineers built JioBharat, a 4G phone priced at ₹799 with our own operating system, to help India's 2G users move to data. The larger opportunity is to deliver more useful services, from home broadband to AI, over the network we have built. Pricing is not the only way to create value – it is one of the several business levers. We will remain focused on consumer experience, innovation, and sustainable investment.

You have mentioned that future revenue will be driven by services rather than just tariff hikes. With ARPU currently hovering around ₹215, which specific digital apps or enterprise solutions do you expect to cross the tipping point to meaningfully lift ARPU over the next two to three years?
We see opportunities across entertainment, cloud and productivity services, AI-enabled offerings, home broadband, and managed digital solutions for businesses. ARPU in our definition, which has been consistent over the last 10 years, it includes only connectivity revenue and not the digital services revenue. Our digital gateway model, which is being trusted by the customers to consume digital services whether through a first-party group company or third-party services, is scaling well. We distribute 333 million digital service subscriptions every month. Our job is to make each of these genuinely useful to customers.

Will there be a tariff revision by this year-end?
We do not comment on speculative timelines for future tariff decisions. Our focus is on delivering high-quality, affordable connectivity and expanding the range of services available to customers. When we take pricing decisions, we weigh them against the value and quality of service we deliver to customers. Meanwhile, we keep adding value through plans that bundle connectivity with entertainment, cloud and AI services.

5G monetisation has been largely riding on high-speed internet access. Do you see any other significant use cases coming up that will hasten 5G returns on investment?
The 5G opportunity extends beyond faster mobile internet. We see scope to deliver a differentiated mobile experience, deepen enterprise relationships, and develop managed digital solutions spanning connectivity, cloud, digital services, and cybersecurity. AI-enabled network operations can also support more efficient service delivery. These are the areas of opportunity, although adoption and returns will depend on customer requirements and execution.

Satellite broadband is now becoming a new competitive frontier, with Starlink and other players seeking access to the Indian market. How seriously does Jio view satellite connectivity as a competitive threat, given that new technology allows direct mobile connectivity?
Jio Vision is to enable Digital Life for every Indian by connecting everything everywhere at the highest quality and most affordable price. While telecom connectivity is ubiquitous in India with 99 per cent population coverage, there are some use cases for satellite for maritime, aviation and some of the remotest regions. We are evaluating the possibility of developing a sovereign Low Earth Orbit satellite constellation for India. At the same time, we are building ground station infrastructure in the country. We are also evaluating partnerships with leading global constellation providers to bring services there sooner. Over the long term, the opportunity is to create an indigenous satellite connectivity capability for India. This is also closely aligned with Jio's larger mission.

What is your biggest worry that could disrupt your future plans?
In technology, the moment you stop reinventing, you start falling behind. So, I watch three things closely: keeping pace as technology and customer needs change; making sure the technology we deploy is reliable, because models can make errors; and keeping our network and our customers' data secure and resilient. No one can eliminate these risks, so we keep building for them, and more than 12,000 of our people in digital products and tech development do exactly that.

Air Chief AP Singh takes a final sortie in a Kiran, the trainer he started flying on 42 years ago

Dalip Singh
New Delhi

For Chief of the Air Staff Air Chief Marshal Amar Preet Singh, it was a full-circle moment in more than one way on Tuesday. Living his dream days before he retires, Air Chief Marshal Singh took to the skies one last time in the same aircraft type, next to the very instructor who first taught him to fly over four decades ago at the Air Force Academy (AFA), Dundigal, Telangana.

The IAF chief chose for his last sortie the Kiran basic trainer aircraft — the same platform he was offered for his maiden flight on January 28, 1984. Seated in the cockpit alongside him was Wing Commander (retd) VS Kochar his instructor, now 73 years old.

Landing after his 55-minute sortie, Air Chief Marshal Singh told reporters, "It was really a dream come true. I started my journey with the same aircraft. I think I must be the only chief who is retiring while the basic aircraft he flew is still serving. I am very grateful to my instructor, Wing Commander Kochar, who taught me flying in the beginning at this very place. I just wanted the circle to be complete."



ONE LAST TIME. IAF chief Air Chief Marshal Amar Preet Singh with his first flying instructor, Wing Commander (retd) VS Kochar, in front of the HJT-16 Kiran Mk-1 trainer aircraft after his final sortie in Medchal-Malkajgiri on Tuesday @IAF_MCC X

NOSTALGIC MOMENT
The occasion was no less nostalgic for Wing Commander Kochar. It filled him with a sense of pride as his one-time student had risen to become the Chief of the Air Staff.

"He was the brightest pupil ever," Wing Commander Kochar recalled. "My dream has also come true to get one more trip. I am 73 now, so getting another trip with him is special. He is the best person ever in this world."

A qualified flying instructor and an experimental test pilot with an experience of several thousand flying hours on a variety of fixed and rotary wing aircraft, Air Chief Marshal Singh will demit office on October 31.

He has been chasing flying in his last few weeks in office. During the recently-held multilateral air exercise 'Tarang Shakti', hosted at Jodhpur Air Force Station, he flew his last fighter jet sortie aboard the indigenous LCA Tejas. The IAF capped that sortie captured in a video released on October 12 as the "spirit of a fighter pilot who has always believed in leading from the front".

OUTSPOKEN
His liking for speaking his mind was no less than his passion for taking to flight.

The IAF chief's repeated public remarks over Hindustan Aeronautics Ltd's failure to deliver LCA Tejas Mk-1A made headlines across television and newspapers.

His first of the openly-expressed frustration was when he said he was "not confident" of HAL's production timelines in February 2025.

He later clarified that the exchange between him and HAL test crew members was a "friendly talk" that was inappropriately leaked.

Air Chief Marshal Singh was unlike a stiff-necked military leader. A workout devotee, he loved occasionally partying and dancing.

Suez Canal recovery raises hopes for exporters as freight rates, transit times ease

T E Raja Simhan
Chennai

After three years of sailing around the Cape of Good Hope, the Suez Canal route is fast returning to normal, with traffic recovering to more than half the pre-disruption level, raising hopes for trade.

Container-ship tonnage transiting the Suez Canal during January–August 2026 was 54.2 per cent higher than a year earlier, according to the Suez Canal Authority.

During the first two weeks of October, weekly container ship capacity transiting the the key waterway averaged 753,000 TEU (twenty-foot equivalent units) against 1.457 million TEUs in the corresponding period in 2023, according to Clarksons Research. This is the first time since the Houthi attacks that transits have exceeded 50 per cent of the pre-disruption level, said Niels Rasmussen, Chief Shipping Analyst at BIMCO.



TIME SAVER. The revival of the key shipping corridor is crucial for Indian businesses trading with Europe, the UK, the Mediterranean region and the US REUTERS

GATHERING PACE
The recovery gathered pace since the Gemini Alliance, comprising Maersk and Hapag-Lloyd, announced in July its services via the Canal. Similarly, Ocean Alliance and Premier Alliance and MSC also announced routing changes.

This also comes at a time when there is increased movement of goods to the US and Europe for key Christmas/New Year season.

The disruption started in November 2023 when the Houthis targeted Israeli ships in the Red Sea in response to Israeli attacks in Gaza. This was extended to commercial ships, leading to diversion via the Cape of Good Hope. By the last week of 2023, weekly container ship capacity transiting the Suez Canal had fallen to 3,30,000 TEU, compared with the year-to-date average of 1,290k TEU, said BIMCO.

The revival of the key corridor is significant for Indian businesses trading with Europe, the UK, the Mediterranean region and the US. The reduced time and freight rates are key for textile exporters, engineering goods manufacturers and chemical producers.

Ramu Shanmugam, CEO of Clothing Connections and Chairman of the IT Wing Subcommittee of the Tiruppur Exporters' Association, said ocean freight rates from Tuticorin to Antwerp and Rotterdam are currently quoting at $2,350–2,450 per 40-foot container, down from $6,100–7,000 during the July peak. Chennai–Rotterdam transit times have also improved to 23–24 days, against 34-36 days via the Cape of Good Hope, he said.

Indian exporters to Europe and the UK have seen freight rates fall by $400–600 per container over the past three weeks, with further softening expected through November, Shanmugam said. Shipments to the East and West Coasts of the US, however, are yet to see comparable benefits, he added.

TRANSIT EDGE
Sean Fang, China–Europe Rail & Multimodal Specialist, said research firm Drewry's analysis showed that a round voyage through the Suez Canal covers approximately 21,878 nautical miles and takes 97 days as against 29,711 nautical miles and 124 days via the Cape of Good Hope. The shorter route saves about 7,833 nautical miles and 27 days per round trip. "Container operators selectively using the Suez route offer relief to the export trade from high freight costs and longer transit times," said J Krishnan of Natesa Iyer, a Chennai-based freight forwarder.

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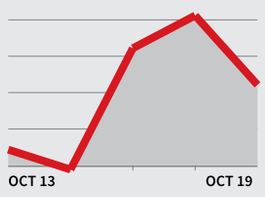
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IN FOCUS

	Week's close	Week's change
Nifty 50	22888.95	+525.60
P/E Ratio (Sensex)	19.30	+0.23
US Dollar (in ₹)	94.92	-0.85
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	145360.00	-2108
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	208750.00	-11545



INFLATIONARY PRESSURE. **Fresh market borrowings** are getting pricier as government bond yields spike amid a tightening cycle **p6**

WEATHER WATCH. **IMD forecasts isolated** very heavy rain in TN, Puducherry for two more days, triggered by a 'low' in Bay of Bengal **p8**

QUICKLY.

NEW HORIZONS

India-New Zealand free trade pact is live



New Delhi: The India-New Zealand Free Trade Agreement (FTA) came into force on Tuesday, giving all Indian goods duty-free access to the New Zealand market and opening new opportunities for exporters in labour-intensive sectors such as textiles, garments, leather and footwear, as well as for those dealing in engineering goods, ceramics and automotive components. **p3**

TARIFF IMPACT

Voice-only plans may hit Vi, BSNL revenues harder

Mumbai: As the deadline to offer voice-only mobile plans ends on Wednesday, analysts expect industry underdogs Vodafone Idea and BSNL to face a greater impact on ARPU and revenue. Comments and analysis notes in the past have suggested that the Telecom Regulatory Authority of India's mandate to offer multiple voice-only plans is likely to benefit 2G users and feature phone users in India. **p2**

Marco Rubio seeks to step up energy trade with India

HIGH ENERGY VISIT. US Secretary of State says India can refine more Venezuelan crude

Our Bureau
Mumbai

US Secretary of State Marco Rubio on Tuesday pitched for expanded energy trade with India and greater cooperation in refining Venezuelan crude oil as Washington and Delhi move closer to finalising a trade deal.

Rubio, on a two-day visit to India, met External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar in Mumbai. The leaders also held a trilateral meeting with UAE Foreign Minister Sheikh Abdullah bin Zayed Al Nahyan to discuss energy, connectivity and other current developments.

HIGH FUEL PRICES IN US

Rubio's visit, his second to India this year, comes against the backdrop of President Donald Trump waiving key provisions of a US law that authorises punitive tariffs on countries purchasing Russian oil.

The visit also comes as the US grapples with record high fuel prices ahead of the November midterm elections and amid simmering tensions in West Asia. In a statement, the US State Department said Rubio and Jaishankar discussed regional and global issues, including developments in West Asia.



FOSTERING TIES. External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar with US Secretary of State Marco Rubio at a meeting in Mumbai PTI

"The Secretary reiterated that increased energy trade with the US can play a transformative role in diversifying India's supply chains while meeting its sizeable consumer demand. He also commended recent progress in bilateral defence and civil nuclear cooperation, and advocated increased purchases of US technologies and systems, which can enhance the security and prosperity of both our countries," the statement said.

"We shared views on further advancement of our ties, focusing on trade, energy, technology, defence and people-to-people ties. We also exchanged views on regional developments," Jaishankar said in an X post.

REFINING SUPERPOWER

On Wednesday, Rubio will visit Reliance Industries' facilities in Jamnagar and meet the company's senior management.

Describing India as a "refining superpower", Rubio said he would discuss opportunities related to refining crude oil from Venezuela. "They (Indian companies) have the capability to refine heavy crude. They have done so in the past, and as more Venezuelan oil comes online, it is something they can do," Rubio told reporters earlier.

He added that Indian companies already hold oil concessions in Venezuela and can increase production independently.

TRADE DEAL 'NEAR'

Rubio also said the two countries are close to finalising a trade agreement and expressed optimism that an announcement could be made soon.

In a television interview, Rubio said the India-US trade agreement was "incredibly close" to completion. "We are down to a few technical details, but we anticipate seeing it finalised in a matter of weeks, not months. The goal is to build a trade relationship that is sustainable and beneficial for both countries," he said.

Later in the day, Rubio and Jaishankar attended a reception in Mumbai, where US Ambassador to India Sergio Gor highlighted the growing economic relationship between the two countries.

"Today, our bilateral trade has shattered records, reaching over $240 billion. We have an ambitious goal: we are laser-focused on driving that number past $500 billion over the next three years," Gor said.

Also read **p3**

Loan portfolio of NBFCs takes on a golden sheen

Ashokamithran T
Mumbai

Gold loans have become the fastest-growing segment for NBFCs, with their share of overall loan book reaching double digits as lenders increasingly pivot towards secured credit amid stress in unsecured lending and microfinance.

Gold loans accounted for nearly 10 per cent of the combined loan book of Bajaj Finance, HDB Financial Services, L&T Finance and IIFL Finance in the September quarter, up from 9.3 per cent in the preceding quarter and 6.23 per cent a year earlier, highlighting the segment's rapid expansion. The combined gold loan book of the four NBFCs stood at nearly ₹1 lakh crore during the quarter ended September 2026 compared with ₹48,831 crore in the year-ago period, reflecting a 98.6 per cent year-on-year growth.

Among the four lenders, IIFL Finance remained the largest player in the segment, with a gold loan book of ₹65,729 crore, accounting for nearly 53 per cent of its total assets under management (AUM) of ₹1.24 lakh crore during the quarter. The share has risen steadily from about 50 per cent in the previous quarter and 38.4 per cent a year ago. Gold loans at the company grew 90 per cent year-on-year from ₹34,577 crore in the second quarter of FY26.

Gold loan growth

Q2FY27	y-o-y (%)	q-o-q (%)
Bajaj Finance	105	14
HDB Financial Services	103	7
IIFL Finance	90	13
L&T Finance	242	32

Source: Company results

LARGER LOAN SIZE

Nirmal Jain, Chairperson, IIFL Finance, said, "Higher gold prices have increased the borrowing capacity of households and small businesses with gold as collateral. At the same time, tighter conditions in unsecured lending and microfinance have prompted many borrowers to shift towards gold loans. Despite geopolitical uncertainties, economic activity remains resilient, with improving business sentiment driving demand for credit among small enterprises."

Other lenders also scaled up their businesses aggressively. Bajaj Finance, L&T Finance and HDB Financial Services more than doubled their gold loan book over the past year. Notably, gold loan portfolios of Bajaj Finance and HDB Financial Services doubled year-on-year, while L&T Finance reported a three-fold increase, albeit on a smaller base.

LT Finance said the sharp rise was aided by a low base and reiterated its intention to continue expanding in the segment. "Growth in our gold loan business is driven primarily by rapid branch expansion. We added more than 200 branches this quarter and plan to add another 300 by year-end, taking the total to around 800," said MD and CEO Sudipta Roy.

EMERGING RISKS

Some lenders are beginning to flag emerging risks in the segment. Piramal Finance, in its analyst call, noted that 15-23 per cent of disbursements over the past year were reportedly extended to customers who were already more than 90 days past due on another live loan. The company also highlighted rising gold loan penetration, with the share of customers holding an active loan elsewhere increasing to more than 35 per cent, from 20-25 per cent two years ago.

Govt not to regulate airfares; caps only in exceptional cases

Rohit Vaid
New Delhi

The Centre may impose caps on unjustified airfares on individual routes in exceptional circumstances under the new airfare rules, sources told *businessline*.

However, airlines will be mandated to provide information on fares, along with a break-up of operating costs and taxes, to the regulator DGCA. These disclosures would help assess whether high ticket prices are justified and could provide a basis for intervention, where necessary, in public interest.

The framework does not envisage a general airfare cap.



Airlines will be mandated to provide information on fares, along with a break-up of operating costs and taxes VELANKANNI RAJ B

DOMESTIC ROUTES

These rules come in the midst of festival season airfare spikes on several domestic routes. Fares have gone up steeply on key domestic routes for the Durga Puja, Chhath Puja and year-end holiday periods.

However, airlines would retain the freedom to determine ticket prices without seeking government approval. The rules seek to formalise the basis for airfare assessment while preserving the deregulated character of the industry.

The operating cost information submitted by carriers would provide a clearer basis for examining fares on individual routes and considering intervention in exceptional circumstances. But furnishing the fare and cost information would not amount to seeking government clearance for pricing decisions.

Any intervention to impose an airfare cap would be exceptional and undertaken where deemed necessary in public interest.

Such instances would be rare, sources said, adding that individual airlines will continue to exercise pricing autonomy in the normal course of business.

PRICE PRESSURE

Special care has been taken while framing the rules to account for the financial pressures faced by the industry.

Additional pressure on pricing could weaken the commercial rationale for continuing in the airline business, given the financial constraints under which carriers operate.

The framework seeks to provide a basis for assessing whether fares are justified while retaining airlines' commercial freedom.

Several aspects of the existing system have so far involved *ad hoc* measures and differing interpretations regarding airfare intervention. Last week, the Centre informed the Supreme Court that the rules had been finalised, received administrative approval and would be published within two weeks. The court directed the government to place the published rules before it by November 16, when the matter will be taken up next.

Rising airfares steer travellers to buses

Aishwarya Kumar
Bengaluru

A holiday that invariably began with a flight search is increasingly starting with looking for a bus connection. With airfares rising, travellers are opting for road trips to destinations closer home rather than dropping their plans. For the travel and hospitality industry, the shift is creating opportunities in places accessible by road. **p10**

AUSPICIOUS START



LEARNING RITUAL. Teachers help children write during 'Vidyarambham', the ritual to initiate them into formal education and learning, on the occasion of Vijayadashami at a school in Chennai on Tuesday. The day is also dedicated to Goddess Saraswati, the deity of knowledge and wisdom ANI

Why the Riyadh-Keralam travel time has doubled

With the Saudi capital under attack, people are travelling to other cities, Bahrain to catch flights

Aneesh Phadnis
Mumbai

A routine four-hour journey between Riyadh and Keralam has turned into a travel ordeal lasting over 10 hours for some passengers as they are forced to travel by road to Dammam or Bahrain to catch flights home.

The Riyadh airport has come under repeated attacks by Houthi rebels, resulting in casualties and damage to facilities. As a precautionary measure, Air India, Air India Express, Akasa Air and IndiGo suspended flights to and from Riyadh till October 24. Saudi carriers, however, continue to operate services to India from Dammam, Jeddah and Medina.

The flight suspensions and resulting capacity cuts have significantly reduced seat availability, pushing up airfares. As a result, passengers needing to return to India urgently are travelling by bus or hiring cars to reach Buraydah, Dammam or even Bahrain to board onward flights.



EXPLORING OPTIONS. Passengers are travelling by bus or are hiring cars to reach Dammam or even Bahrain to board onward flights REUTERS

"Similarly, those who need to return to Riyadh before their visa entry deadlines expire are also travelling via Bahrain and the UAE," a local said.

ROAD JOURNEY

The road journey from Riyadh to Dammam or Bahrain takes four-six hours, with both destinations located around 400-460 km from the Saudi capital. However, travel to Jeddah is considerably longer as the city is nearly 1,000 km away.

The Indian Embassy in Riyadh and the Consulate General of India in Jeddah have activated 24x7 control rooms and are assisting passengers seeking guidance.

"The Consulate continues to engage with local authorities, airlines, travel operators and Indian community volunteers to address difficulties faced by affected Indian nationals, including facilitating access to essential medicines, food and other assistance," it said in a post on X on Sunday.

CHARTER FLIGHTS

Airlines are attempting to ease the disruption for stranded passengers. While Saudia and flyadeal have rerouted some flights originally scheduled for Riyadh to Jeddah and Dammam, Air India Express is allowing passengers to rebook Saudi Arabia tickets free of charge to any other Gulf destination. Charter flights are also being arranged to help affected travellers.

"We are chartering flights from Jeddah to Kochi. Bus services between Riyadh and Jeddah are operating normally. The charter flights will also support passengers stranded in Riyadh," said Biju Varughese, Director (Holidays) at Alhind Tours and Travels.

W. Asia tensions: Fast tracking strategic petro reserves is 'crucial to India's energy security'

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

Even as the recent West Asia conflict has impressed upon India to immediately double the capacity of domestic strategic petroleum reserves (SPRs) and scout for storage locations overseas, analysts and officials emphasise on fast tracking the current projects in Odisha and Karnataka.

India is setting up two facilities for commercial-cum-strategic storage of 6.5 million tonnes (mt) at Chandikhol (4 mt) in Odisha and Padur (2.5 mt) in Karnataka under Phase-2.

Sources said the SPR at Chandikhol is now "gradually inching ahead" with "certain commercial terms" being finalised with the Abu Dhabi National Oil Company (ADNOC). Around 400 acres have been handed over for the project, which had been languishing for nearly 8 years.

◉ STORAGE FACILITIES

India is setting up two facilities for commercial-cum-strategic storage of 6.5 mt at Chandikhol in Odisha and Padur in Karnataka under Phase-2

NEW LOCATIONS

State-run ONGC is also developing a 1.75 mt SPR at Mangaluru. That apart, new locations in Bina (Madhya Pradesh) and Bikaner (Rajasthan) have been identified for crude oil, LNG and LPG storage, with feasibility studies going on, said one of the sources.

"Besides, for stockpiling crude oil in foreign locations, India has tied up with the UAE through an MoU (May 2026). It is also in talks with Japan for deepening cooperation in strategic fuel reserves (July 2026)," the source added.

Manas Majumdar, Partner and Leader, Oil & Gas, Fuels & Resources at PwC India, said the Phase-2 expansion is being done in public private partnership (PPP) mode at a capex of around ₹15,000 crore, with the involvement of Megha Engineering, ADNOC and the Centre with a viability gap funding (VGF) of close to 60 per cent.

"Even with government support, the expansion is going slow and needs to be expedited, given the increased geopolitical turmoil over recent years," he told *businessline*.

RISING CRUDE BILL

There is a material impact of having an enhanced petroleum buffer, Majumdar stressed, adding that India's crude import bill was around $150 billion last year, and the crude basket had jumped from around $90 per barrel to over $110.

This is more than a 20 per cent increase, which would mean a jump of $20-30 billion in the import bill (depending on how much India actually imports).

CRUDE AVAILABILITY

Having storage would have ensured crude availability at a lower price than the current high rates, he said.

Clearly, there is an incentive to expedite the SPR Phase-2, sort out land acquisition issues, explore salt caverns in Madhya Pradesh and Rajasthan and also commercial lease and sale models to bring in more private players to develop SPRs, Majumdar added.

DELHI
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QUICKLY.

UltraTech expands AP facility at ₹2,650 crore



Hyderabad: UltraTech Cement has expanded its capacity in Andhra Pradesh with its Petnikota Cement Works, a state-of-the-art integrated cement plant built at an investment of around ₹2,650 crore. The plant will provide direct employment to 650 people and indirect jobs to 2,000 more. OUR BUREAU

Otter.ai raises $320 m to expand enterprise biz

AI meeting-transcription company Otter.ai said on Tuesday it had closed $320 million in growth financing from General Catalyst's Customer Value Fund to expand its enterprise business and international reach. CEO Sam Liang said Otter plans to double or triple its sales and marketing budget, grow its small sales team and market heavily abroad. REUTERS

Voice-only plans may hit Vi and BSNL's ARPU, revenue harder

BIG IMPACT. 2G users account for 34% of Vi's subscribers and about 85% of BSNL's

Vallari Sanzgiri
Mumbai

As the deadline to offer voice-only mobile plans ends on Wednesday, analysts expect industry underdogs Vodafone Idea (Vi) and Bharat Sanchar Nigam Ltd (BSNL) to face a greater impact on ARPU and revenue.

Comments and analysis notes in the past have suggested that the Telecom Regulatory Authority of India's (TRAI) mandate to offer multiple voice-only plans is likely to benefit 2G users and feature phone users in India. As Vi and BSNL have a larger share of such users in their subscriber bases, experts expect the two to see more noticeable, though not severe, changes in their ARPU and revenue figures.



2G DOMINANCE. According to the latest results, 2G users account for 85 per cent of BSNL's total subscriber base REUTERS

LIMITED DILUTION
Taking Bharti Airtel as an example, which recently announced three new voice-only plans, Morgan Stanley noted that the offerings were only 7-16 per cent cheaper than its existing entry-level plans.

"Even if we assume 25-30 per cent of this cohort of subscribers (under 110 million subscribers) migrate to these lower-priced plans, it would still mean less than 1 per cent revenue dilution for the wireless business," the analyst note said.

The telco introduced plans priced between ₹185 and ₹206, with validity periods of 28-30 days. Noting that the prices were based on TRAI data that valued 1 GB of data around ₹7, telecom expert Parag Kar explained how the pricing could affect Vodafone Idea (Vi) and BSNL.

REVENUE IMPACT
"BSNL and Vi have the largest 2G subscriber bases. Airtel may have around 20 per cent of its total subscribers, or about 80 million, in this segment. If Vi structures its voice-only plans along the same lines as Airtel, the impact on its overall revenue will be greater," Kar said, pointing out that Airtel had recently increased its postpaid prices.

According to the latest results, 2G users account for 34 per cent of Vi's subscriber base, while they make up about 85 per cent of BSNL's total subscriber base.

However, the introduction of more voice-only plans is unlikely to significantly affect revenues, as the TRAI has not prescribed prices for such plans, said Mahesh Uppal, Director at Com First (India).

Moreover, 2G users have arguably grown accustomed to having some data bundled with their plans.

"Voice-only plans may not be attractive enough, even to 2G users, to trigger any major shift in usage patterns. However, consumers should have the option to choose voice-only plans," Uppal said.

Assets of AIFs continue to grow, hit ₹7.59 lakh cr in first quarter

Sourashis Banerjee
Chennai

Assets under management (AUM) of alternative investment funds (AIFs) continued to expand in the first quarter of FY27, reaching ₹7.59 lakh crore at the end of June, up 28.3 per cent over the past year. Category II funds accounted for nearly 63 per cent of AUM, while Category III funds recorded the fastest growth.

DATA FOCUS.

Domestic investors remained the largest source of funding, whereas foreign portfolio investors (FPIs) reduced their cumulative AIF holdings by 41.7 per cent. Investments in unlisted and equity-linked securities continued to dominate.

CAT II FUNDS DOMINATE
AIF funds increased to ₹7.59 lakh crore (₹5.91 lakh crore) as of June 30, FY27. This follows year-on-year growth of 24.7 per cent on June 30, FY26, and 26.7 per cent in June 30, FY25.

Category II AIFs, which include private equity and debt funds, accounted for ₹4.78 lakh crore, or about 63 per cent of cumulative AUM, growing 26 per cent. These funds typically invest in unlisted companies, private equity and debt instruments, and generally do not undertake leverage except for permitted operational requirements.

Category III AIFs, recorded the fastest growth at 35.2 per cent, with AUM reaching ₹2.17 lakh crore at the end of Q1 of FY27. Their share stood at about 28.6 per cent.

Category I AIFs, which include venture capital, infrastructure and other funds targeting specific sectors, grew 24.5 per cent to ₹63,487 crore towards the end of first quarter of FY27, accounting for only 8.4 per cent of cumulative AUM.

DOMESTIC INVESTORS
Gross cumulative funds raised from domestic investors reached ₹6.06 lakh crore as of June 30 in FY27, increasing 38.5 per cent. However, AUM of FPIs fell 41.7 per cent to ₹1,247 crore.

According to Madan Sabnavis, Chief Economist, Bank of Baroda, "FPI behaviour is in sync with what they are doing in capital market. The quantum of investible resources is lower from the West and being spread across more markets, hurting AIFs."

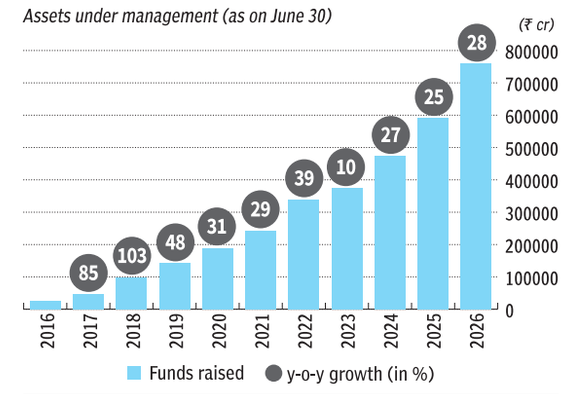
AUM of AIFs in unlisted securities rose 21.8 per cent to ₹4.28 lakh crore, while investments in listed securities grew 28.1 per cent to ₹2.35 lakh crore, as of June 30, 2026. Similarly, equity and equity-linked instruments increased 30.2 per cent to ₹4.73 lakh crore, while debt investments grew 18.1 per cent to ₹1.56 lakh crore.

Source: SEBI

Growing assets

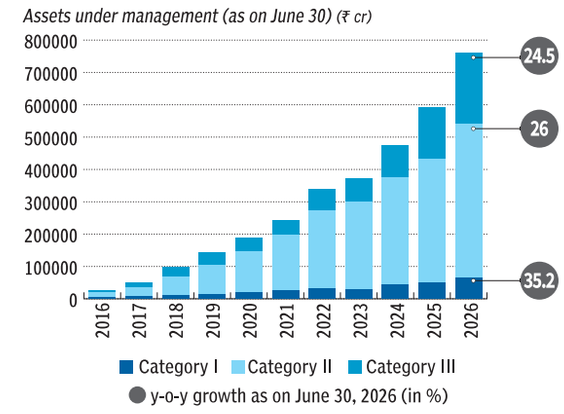
AIF assets cross ₹7.6 lakh crore

Assets under management (as on June 30)



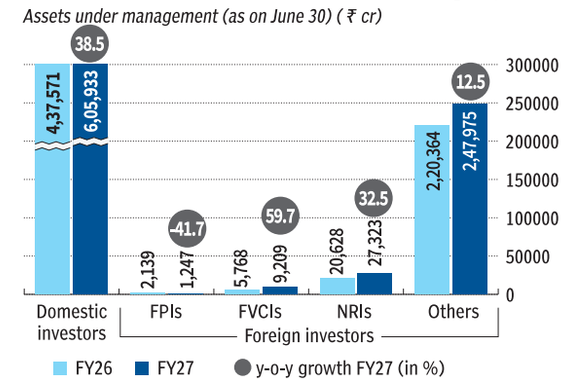
More than half of AIF assets in Category II

Assets under management (as on June 30) (₹ cr)



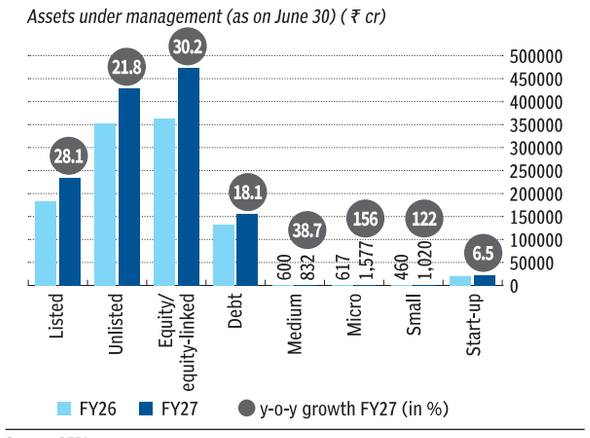
FPIs reduced their cumulative AIF holdings by 42%

Assets under management (as on June 30) (₹ cr)



Unlisted and equity/equity linked securities attract more AIF funds

Assets under management (as on June 30) (₹ cr)



Motorcycle makers offer up to ₹11,000 in discounts amid price hikes

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

TVS Motors' top-end Raider motorcycle, launched a year ago at ₹95,600, now lists at ₹1,03,170, nearly 8 per cent higher. This festival season, the company is advertising savings of up to ₹11,000, potentially offsetting more than a year's price increase for eligible buyers.

The same contest is unfolding across India's 125-250cc motorcycle market. Hero MotoCorp's Xtreme 160R carries a listed cash bonus of up to ₹10,000, while Bajaj Auto is offering combined benefits of ₹6,000-8,900 on several Pulsar models. Manufacturers are using temporary incentives to protect festival demand after repeated price increases driven by rising input costs.

The discounts follow a reduction in GST on motorcycles up to 350cc from 28 per cent to 18 per cent in September 2025. Subsequent manufacturer-led increases have partly eroded that benefit.

Two-wheeler retail sales rose 33.1 per cent to 17.90 lakh units in September 2026, according to the Federation of Automobile Dealers' Associations, raising the stakes for manufacturers seeking to sustain momentum beyond the festive season.



Two-wheeler retail sales rose 33.1 per cent to 17.9 lakh units in September 2026

RISING COSTS
Bajaj Auto indicated earlier this year that steel costs had increased about 15 per cent and copper about 20 per cent, with its April price revisions recovering only around 40 per cent of the additional burden.

TVS Motor Company said pricing had offset roughly a third of commodity inflation. It raised prices across much of its portfolio in August and revised Raider prices again in October by up to ₹2,600. Hero MotoCorp also implemented increases averaging around ₹2,000 per vehicle.

Bajaj has structured its festival campaign around cash discounts, processing-fee waivers and free servicing. The Pulsar 125 receives benefits worth ₹6,000, the NS125 - ₹6,200 and the Pulsar 150 - ₹7,200. Packages increase to ₹7,500 on the N160 and NS160, ₹7,900 on the N250, ₹8,000 on the NS200 and ₹8,900 on the RS200.

TVS' advertised Raider savings are conditional, incorporating financing offers that vary by location and eligibility. TVS Credit is separately promoting interest rates starting at 5.99 per cent on eligible models. Hero's smaller Xtreme 125R carries a listed bonus of up to ₹3,000, with roadside assistance offered on eligible online bookings.

Several promotional offers expire on October 31, while the underlying price increases remain.

Hindustan Zinc plans 10-mtpa tailings recycling plant

Suresh P Iyengar
Mumbai

Hindustan Zinc plans to set up a 10 million tonne per annum (mtpa) tailings recycling plant to extract zinc and critical minerals, including germanium, from mining waste, with the project expected to become operational in about two years, said Amarendu Prakash, CEO. The company has completed conceptual designs and engineering work and is in the implementation phase. However, the investment outlay has not been finalised, as Hindustan Zinc is evaluating technologies for processing mining waste and extracting metals through metallurgical and chemical processes.



Prakash told *businessline* that the project involved two components: Handling and processing the tailings, including through hydro-mining, and recovering metals from the mineral-rich material. The company expects the project to become operational in about two years.

Prakash described it as a new technology with limited applications globally, adding that the company was assessing the potential costs as it moves ahead with implementation. "Yesterday's waste is becoming today's ore," he said, explaining that higher metal prices and advances in extraction technology were making previously discarded material economically viable.

COST REDUCTION
Amit Gupta, Chief Financial Officer, said the company expects its cost of production (CoP) for zinc to average $825-850 per tonne for the full year, against an earlier target of about $1,000 or slightly lower. Hindustan Zinc is retaining its production-volume guidance and expects to achieve the targeted volumes in the second half of the financial year.

For silver, the company is targeting production of 680 tonnes for the full year. It produced more than 320 tonne in the first half, apart from around 20 tonnes sold in concentrate, and remains confident of meeting its annual guidance.

Prakash said persistent global silver supply shortages and rising demand offered opportunities to expand capacity and sustain margins.

Hindustan Zinc is exploring plans to increase its silver production capacity to capitalise on the market outlook.

MINING CAPACITY
Hindustan Zinc plans to increase its mining capacity from 18 mt to 35 mt over the next two-five years.

Prakash said ageing mines and declining ore grades could constrain global zinc mine supply even as demand increases.

The company is developing value-added zinc alloys and other products to absorb additional output. It has promoted a zinc park in Rajasthan to encourage downstream players to establish facilities near its operations.

Prakash said the company was progressing with exploration across four critical mineral blocks in India.

On the global zinc market, Prakash cited projected 2026 refined zinc demand of 13.87 million tonnes against supply of 13.69 mt, indicating a deficit of about 180,000 tonnes.

He said the Vedanta Group's investment in a South African zinc mine reflected expectations of sustained demand growth.

Stellantis aims to halve vehicle development time

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

Stellantis India is targeting to halve vehicle development time and ramp up localisation for certain models as it prepares to launch 12 products across the Citroen and Jeep brands under its FaSTLAne 2030 roadmap, MD and CEO Shailesh Hazela said.

"Globally, we announced that our ambition is to cut down our development time for bringing new products from 48 months to close to two years. That is what we are working on for our products, which we are going to launch," Hazela told *PTI*.

Stellantis India has a long-standing partnership with Tata Motors Passenger Vehicle for manufacturing through a joint venture. Recently, it signed a definitive agreement to expand the scope of the partnership into advanced technology and product collaboration.

We are betting on multiple powertrains to drive India's growth: Renault CEO

bl.interview

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

French automaker Renault, which launched its Duster Strong Hybrid E-Tech 160 at a starting price of ₹16.99 lakh, is betting on wider powertrain options, including strong hybrids and CNG, in its plan to enhance presence in India.

Stephane Deblaise, CEO, Renault Group India, explains how CNG variants, strong hybrids, faster product development, greater localisation and seven models planned through 2030 could help Renault sustain demand, improve dealership economics and rebuild its position.

Edited excerpts:

Renault's market share remains below 1 per cent despite the Duster launch. How will you sustain growth and eventually reach 5 per cent?
First, we have not given a concrete timeline for achieving 5 per cent market share.

We have a very comprehensive product roadmap, and you must look at the developments already underway.

We have introduced a more powerful engine for the Triber, addressing customer concerns about performance, particularly when carrying seven passengers. We are introducing CNG options, making significant improvements to the Kiger and planning further developments for the Duster.

There will also be new vehicles, including a larger seven-seat model and the Bridger.

We have never had so many product developments and upgrades planned for India.

This will have a significant impact on our market presence.

What is Renault's CNG strategy, and can it become a meaningful contributor to sales?
CNG represents approximately 25 per cent of the relevant market, and until now we have not participated adequately in this opportunity. We are bringing CNG to the Triber and Kiger, expanding the number of customers we can address.

If CNG accounts for 25 per cent of the segment, why should we not aim for a similar proportion of sales in our models?

This is an opportunity to increase volumes without depending entirely on new vehicle launches.

> My priorities are straightforward — deliver good products for Indian customers, offer the right powertrains for this market and remain cost-competitive
>
> **STEPHANE DEBLAISE**
> CEO, Renault Group India



Why prioritise strong hybrids when electric vehicles are gaining ground and hybrids face a GST disadvantage?
Hybrid is the new diesel. It offers excellent fuel economy and total cost of ownership.

Our Duster strong hybrid delivers a claimed 29 km per litre, compared with around 21 km per litre for comparable diesel vehicles.

Electrification remains our priority, but customers cannot switch overnight from internal-combustion vehicles to electric cars. Hybrid and electric vehicles address different customer requirements.

Hybrids offer electric driving benefits without dependence on charging infrastructure, making them particularly relevant for India.

How will Renault's Indian engineering capabilities accelerate vehicle development?
We now have engineering, manufacturing, product planning and marketing working together much more closely.

This changes how quickly we can develop vehicles and respond to customer requirements.

Take the Bridger, scheduled for the end of 2027. Its development programme is approximately 88 weeks. We can achieve this because India has strong engineering capabilities, and the different functions work together in a short decision-making loop.

How does Renault plan to support its €2 billion annual export ambition for India 2030?
Our strategy has three elements: exporting vehicles manufactured in India, supplying components and subassemblies to Renault's global manufacturing operations, and expanding engineering services.

Indian engineers already support projects for markets including Brazil and France. Our capabilities allow India to contribute beyond domestic vehicle sales.

With CAFE III, E20 and the proposed BS7 norms increasing compliance costs, how will Renault remain affordable and competitive?
That is the responsibility of engineering. We have considerable experience managing demanding regulations in Europe.

Engineering must respond to two requirements: regulatory constraints and customer expectations, while remaining competitive on costs.

My priorities are straightforward: deliver good products for customers, offer the right powertrains for this market, and remain cost-competitive. If we achieve these three objectives, we can strengthen our business and increase exports.

Switch Mobility, Purple Bus launch e-bus service

Our Bureau
Chennai

Switch Mobility, an electric bus and light commercial vehicle manufacturer that is part of the Hinduja Group, and Purple Bus, an intercity mobility operator, have launched an electric bus service on the Nagpur-Chandrapur route, extending the operator's intercity network further into Vidarbha.

The occasion was marked by a flag-off of the first batch of six units of the 50 EiV12m intercity electric bus order for the Vidarbha region deployments by Purple Bus, in the presence of Union Road Transport & Highways Minister Nitin Gadkari.

This marks Switch Mobility's third intercity deployment with Purple Bus this year, following the flag-off of electric coaches on the Mumbai-Pune and Dombivli-Pune routes in April and October respectively.

businessline.
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QUICKLY.

Government to review 2019 mineral policy

New Delhi: The Centre is set to review the National Mineral Policy, 2019, to align it with evolving sector demands, focusing on key priorities such as critical minerals, recycling and deep-sea resources, according to sources. The Mines Ministry has decided to constitute a nine-member panel to undertake a comprehensive review of the policy in the light of recent developments and emerging requirements, the sources said. The panel, to be chaired by the Additional Secretary in the Ministry, has been asked to submit its recommendations within two months of its constitution, sources said. The National Mineral Policy, 2019, was aimed at ensuring more effective regulation and sustainable development of the sector, and addressing the concerns of project-affected persons, particularly those living in tribal areas. It also included provisions to boost the sector, attract private investment, promote ease of doing business and ensure sustainable mining. PTI

Rubio defends Russia oil waiver, calls Iran's attacks as 'Nazi U-boat tactics'

POWER PLAY. Cites strategic interests, shipping security and strong US support for Indian-Americans

Our Bureau
Mumbai

US Secretary of State Marco Rubio defended President Donald Trump administration's decision to ease the implementation of Russia-related sanctions and argued that Washington must continue engaging with Pakistan despite New Delhi's longstanding concerns over terrorism.

In a *CNBC-Network18* interview, Rubio acknowledged the tensions created by sanctions targeting Moscow and countries continuing to do business with Russia, saying policymakers must weigh their broader consequences.

"People don't realise that sanctions come at a consequence because sanctions aren't just on Russia; they are on anyone who does business with Russia," he said, noting that there is a constant balancing act between pressuring parties involved in the Ukraine conflict and limiting unintended consequences for other countries.



FIRST STOP. Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis (centre) with US Secretary of State Marco Rubio (left) and US Ambassador to India Sergio Gor in Mumbai ANI

IMPACT OF SANCTIONS
Defending President Trump's decision to use a national security waiver on legislation proposing tougher tariffs and sanctions linked to Russia, Rubio said such measures must be viewed in their entirety, taking into account their impact on the global economy and partner nations.

Responding to a question on Pakistan and his previous calls as a senator for action against countries sponsoring terrorism against India, Rubio reiterated that the US opposes terrorism anywhere in the world and anyone who supports it. However, he said Washington's broader foreign policy considerations require maintaining relations with Islamabad.

"In the case of Pakistan, it's a country that we have to have a relationship with," he said, citing its possession of nuclear weapons and its geographic importance. He added that maintaining channels of communication with Islamabad could help the US discourage actions that are a source of concern for India.

SHIPPING SECURITY
On tensions in West Asia, Rubio accused Iran of targeting commercial shipping while insisting that traffic through the Strait of Hormuz remains largely unchanged from pre-conflict levels. "We have a nation-State that is openly saying we are targeting commercial vessels," he said, adding that Tehran was employing "Nazi U-boat tactics" by attempting to strike merchant ships. Rubio said Indian sailors had been among those affected by the attacks and pledged continued US efforts to protect shipping routes.

He also rejected the notion that anti-India sentiment is widespread in the US, even as he acknowledged incidents of hatred and hostility directed at communities. Rubio said such behaviour reflected the actions of a small minority and pointed to strong support from local communities whenever such incidents occurred.

"I do not believe, nor have I ever perceived, that anti-Indian sentiment in the US is widespread or deep," he said, describing the Indian-American community as an important part of American society.

Govt revises rules for return of goods from domestic tariff area to SEZ units

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

SEZ units may now return unsold DTA goods within 30 days of clearance, with strict identity, non-benefit proof and inventory requirements

Goods supplied by a unit in a Special Economic Zone (SEZ) and rejected by the domestic buyer on account of change in fashion can now be brought back post fulfilment of certain conditions, as the government has expanded the conditions for return of goods supplied by a unit in SEZs to the Domestic Tariff Area (DTA).

"Goods supplied by a Unit into Domestic Tariff Area on payment of duty may be brought back to the Unit where a Domestic Tariff Area buyer fails to take delivery of the goods due to change in fashion, change in market conditions, or default in conditions of agreement relating to the sale," a notification amending SEZ rules 2006 stated.

The goods need to be brought back by the unit within 30 days from the date of clearance from the SEZ unit.

CONDITIONS APPLY
However, some conditions need to be fulfilled. First, the identity of the goods need to be established to the satisfaction of the specified officer.

Second, the SEZ unit should provide evidence that no benefits — including input tax credit — have been availed by the DTA buyer who has failed to take delivery of the goods, and third, a separate inventory need to be maintained. Further, the SEZ unit can re-sell the same goods without any alteration of the original condition of the goods, in the DTA either to the same buyer or to a different buyer.

If there is fresh sale, then duty will be required to be paid. "The refund of duty paid at the time of original clearance shall be made," the notification said, while adding that the refund of duties on goods received back will also be possible.

In cases where repairs are to be carried out on the goods supplied by a unit to the DTA on payment of applicable duties, they can be brought back within a period of six months from the date of clearance or permitted period or within the warranty period, whichever is later.

Duty will be required to be paid on the value of repairs, the notification said.

RELIEF MEASURE
Earlier on April 1, the Finance Ministry notified a relief measure allowing SEZ units to sell goods in DTA under specific conditions, effective for one year starting Wednesday.

However, the notification excludes several categories from this exemption, including petroleum products like petrol and diesel, as well as various food products.

This follows a Budget announcement by Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman regarding a special one-time measure to facilitate sales by eligible SEZ manufacturing units to the DTA at concessional duty rates.

The move aims to address capacity utilisation concerns triggered by global trade disruptions. According to the notification dated March 31, a lower duty ranging from 5 per cent to 12.5 per cent will apply.

Resident Indians, FIIs to get IT exemption on NDB's Maharaja Bonds

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

The Income Tax Department has notified tax exemption on interest earned from 'Maharaja Bond', issued by New Development Bank (NDB).

Meanwhile, the department has also introduced a new form for exemption on government securities for Foreign Institutional Investors (FIIs).

In a notification, the department said that "no deduction of tax shall be made under section 393(1) of the Income Tax Act on payment in the nature of interest, made by the New Development Bank to such person being holder of the Maharaja INR Bonds issued by the New Development Bank during the tax year 2026-27 and subsequent tax years." Here, holder means a resident or an FII. The New Development Bank will be required to furnish information.

"This notification shall come into force on the date of its publication in the Official Gazette," the department said, which is October 19, 2026. Maharaja Bond is a rupee-denominated bond just like Masala Bond. However, both are different. While a Maharaja Bond is an onshore rupee-denominated debt instrument, Masala Bond is a debt instrument issued by Indian entities in the international market but denominated in Indian rupees (INR), as opposed to the local currency of the foreign market. They are named "masala" to reflect the Indian origin and cultural identity of the bond.



FINANCING PLANS
The current one by NDB is not the first Maharaja Bond. In 2014, IFC, a member of the World Bank Group, issued its first onshore rupee bond, better known as 'the IFC Maharaja bonds.'

Earlier, the NDB's annual report emphasised that to achieve its operational priorities, it will mobilise resources at scale through a diversified suite of instruments, with a strong presence across international and local capital markets.

Further, it said the bank will continue to expand local-currency financing, which will help mitigate foreign exchange risks while supporting the development of domestic capital markets in member countries. In 2026, the bank plans to expand into new markets, including issuing INR-denominated Maharaja bonds in India.

It will work vigorously to sustain its 30 per cent local currency financing goal, the report added.

SUPPORT FOR INDIA
Later, in a social media post, Dilma Rousseff, President, NDB, said that the bank plans to channel $7.5 billion into India over five years, stepping up local-currency financing to give emerging economies more options beyond dollar-denominated funding. The proposed support includes $5 billion in sovereign lending and a planned $2.5 billion-equivalent rupee bond programme (around ₹25,000 crore). The bond will be issued with support from the Government of India and RBI. This initiative will further solidify the bank's local currency financing franchise and support India's financial sovereignty.

NEW FORM 173A
Meanwhile, the Income Tax Department has notified a new form 173A for FIIs, overseas investors and the Bank for International Settlements (BIS) to claim exemption from capital gains tax on interest and trading gains from government bonds.

SAFA pushes for govt-backed price stabilisation fund, seeks floor price for certified used cooking oil

Richa Mishra
Hyderabad

The Sustainable Aviation Fuel (SAF) Association has reached out to key Ministries like Environment, Petroleum & Natural Gas and Civil Aviation to create a well-designed extended producer responsibility (EPR) framework for used cooking oil (UCO).

The UCO-EPR framework can strengthen domestic feedstock supply, improve food safety and support India's emerging SAF industry, it has said in a recent letter to key stakeholders.

"We have taken it up with the ministries," Rohit Kumar, Secretary General of the SAF Association, told *businessline*.

Asked if the Petroleum & Natural Gas Ministry accepts the EPR framework, would it subsidise the gap through a dedicated green fund or mandate that airlines absorb the costs under the threat of penalties, he said, "The framework should distribute responsibilities fairly across the value chain, rather than place the entire burden on airlines."



FUND PROPOSAL
SAFA has proposed a government-backed UCO Price Stabilisation Fund, potentially supported through a cess on edible oil imports. Such support could help de-risk investments, strengthen collection networks and enable the industry to grow, Kumar said.

Asked if the Petroleum Ministry will demand a "price ceiling" on tradable EPR certificates to prevent speculative trading and hyper-inflation of UCO feedstock prices and, if so, will that ceiling remain high enough to incentivise collectors, he said, "SAFA has proposed a minimum price (floor price) for certified UCO to make collection commercially viable, rather than a price ceiling on EPR certificates."

"Transparent pricing, digital traceability and safeguards against market manipulation will be important to protect collectors and fuel producers while promoting circularity," he said.

UCO FRAMEWORK
The Ministry's long-term roadmap heavily weights on multi-feedstock pathways, including agricultural residues, bagasse and municipal waste. Asked what would happen if the Ministry rejects a standalone UCO-EPR policy in favour of a unified, multi-feedstock credit system that covers all domestic waste streams simultaneously he said, "We see UCO-EPR as an immediate first step, not an alternative to India's wider multi-feedstock strategy."

"A dedicated UCO framework can help secure near-term domestic feedstock supplies while supporting India's ability to meet emerging global aviation de-carbonisation requirements."

SAFA has recommended the immediate formation of a stakeholder working group with industry participation to evaluate the proposal and develop an implementation roadmap. The larger objective is to move India from a SAF mandate to a functioning market, he added.

India-New Zealand FTA kicks in; duty-free access for Indian goods; gains hinge on competitiveness

Our Bureau
New Delhi

The India-New Zealand Free Trade Agreement (FTA) came into force on Tuesday, giving all Indian goods duty-free access to the New Zealand market and opening new opportunities for exporters in labour-intensive sectors such as textiles, garments, leather and footwear, as well as engineering goods, ceramics and automotive components. The pact eliminates 100 per cent tariffs on Indian exports to New Zealand, while 95 per cent of New Zealand's exports to India will be either allowed tariff-free or at sharply reduced levies.

However, the incremental gains from tariff elimination may be more limited than the headline benefit suggests, as 58.3 per cent of New Zealand's tariff lines were already duty-free, according to an analysis by Ajay Srivastava of the Global Trade Research Initiative.



The pact boosts export opportunities but may heighten competition for domestic producers

EXPORT BOOST
"The FTA includes two Temporary Employment Entry visa categories, expanded post-study work rights for some Indian graduates, commitments around in-study work rights for Indian students and a new working holiday scheme," the Immigration department said.

For Indian exporters, the removal of tariffs across all New Zealand tariff lines provides an opportunity to improve price competitiveness in a market where duties on some products were as high as 10 per cent. Textiles, apparel, leather goods, footwear, carpets, ceramics, machinery and automotive components are some sectors that stand to benefit. The gains could be particularly relevant for labour-intensive industries and MSMEs seeking to diversify export markets.

However, strict food-safety standards, costly certification, high freight charges and lengthy shipping times remain obstacles for Indian exporters.

MARKET ACCESS
The agreement also provides New Zealand with preferential access to the Indian market. India will open about 70 per cent of its tariff lines, covering nearly 95 per cent of New Zealand's exports,. Dairy, sugar and edible oils have been excluded from tariff concessions, thus protecting sensitive domestic sectors.

Some agricultural products, including apples, kiwifruit and Manuka honey, will receive concessions through tariff-rate quotas, which limit the quantities eligible for preferential duties. The treatment of apples is particularly significant for domestic growers — import duties will fall from 50 per cent to 25 per cent within a quota initially set at 32,500 tonnes, rising to 45,000 tonnes from the sixth year. The concessional window will be restricted to April-August, and imports will be subject to a minimum price of $1.25 per kg.

The concessions could increase competitive pressure on apple growers in Kashmir and Himachal Pradesh. Wine will receive price-based tariff reductions rather than quota-based access.

Newsprint makers seek PM's intervention over coal shortages, seek 75:25 allocation ratio

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

The Indian Newsprint Manufacturers' Association (INMA) has sought Prime Minister Narendra Modi's direct intervention to resolve persistent coal supply disruptions, warning that irregular dispatches and inadequate allocations are constraining domestic production and threatening supplies to the print media industry.

In an urgent representation to the Prime Minister, the association, which represents manufacturers supplying newsprint to leading publications, including *The Times of India*, *Hindustan Times*, *The Hindu*, *Navbharat Times* and *Punjab Kesari*, sought timely coal dispatches under existing fuel supply agreements with Coal India Ltd (CIL) subsidiaries.

SUPPLY DISRUPTIONS
Despite valid long-term agreements with subsidiaries, including Northern Coalfields Ltd (NCL), Central Coalfields Ltd (CCL), South Eastern Coalfields Ltd (SECL) and Western Coalfields Ltd (WCL), manufacturers are not receiving allocated coal rakes according to agreed schedules, INMA said.

The shortages have forced mills to procure coal from the open market at exorbitant prices and rely on grid electricity at significantly higher costs to keep their plants operational, the association said.

Prolonged delays followed by the sudden bunching of multiple coal rakes had added to financial and logistical pressures, creating challenges involving working capital, coal handling, storage capacity and transportation.

OPERATIONAL HURDLES
The INMA warned that the supply constraints were preventing manufacturers from operating at optimal capacity, raising the risk of production cuts, domestic market disruptions and financial stress across the print media supply chain.

The association also urged the government to enforce the coal allocation ratio of 75:25, recommended by the Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs, between the power and non-power sectors.

Gem, jewellery exporters heave a sigh of relief as US puts punitive 100% import duty on the back burner

Suresh P Iyengar
Mumbai

Gems and jewellery exporters expect fresh orders from the US to revive, with fears of a punitive 100 per cent import duty on India now on the back burner.

On September 18, the US Congress enacted the Lindsey O Graham Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act of 2026 (SRIA), which authorised tariffs of up to 100 per cent on goods from the top five buyers of Russian crude oil or natural gas. However, late last week, US President Donald Trump exercised his waiver authority, putting the proposal on hold in the national interest of the US.

With soaring diesel prices affecting US farmers and mid-term elections around the corner, Trump announced an agreement with Russian President Vladimir Putin to supply Russian diesel to the US and global markets, starting with an initial shipment of more than 300,000 tonnes (about 2.25 million barrels). Colin Shah, Managing Director of leading exporter Kama Jewelry, said the latest waiver provides much-needed clarity for exporters during this crucial shipping season.

The tariff uncertainty witnessed last year accelerated the Indian gems and jewellery industry's efforts to diversify into newer markets. However, the US continues to be its largest export market, and demand for the coming Christmas season has been encouraging, he said.



GLITTERING GAINS. India's gems and jewellery exports rose 13% to $14.30 billion in the first half of this fiscal, despite global uncertainties REUTERS

EXPORT SURGE
India's gems and jewellery exports rose 13 per cent to $14.30 billion (₹1.36 lakh crore) in the first half of this fiscal year, despite global uncertainties. Meanwhile, despite a weak rupee, domestic gold prices fell 5 per cent in the past month to ₹145,944 per 10 gram on Monday, from ₹153,337 on September 21, according to data from the India Bullion and Jewellers Association.

Kavita Chacko, Research Head - India, World Gold Council, said the recent decline in gold prices provided support to demand. Manufacturers were reporting healthy order-flows as retailers replenished inventories to meet seasonal demand, while industry feedback pointed to improving in-store footfall, she said.

Rajeev Sharan, Head of Research at Brickwork Ratings, said families were keeping their festive spending budgets steady, even if it meant buying lighter jewellery, while a growing share of their money was flowing into gold coins, bars and exchange-traded funds.

The shift is significant as festive buying is moving towards a more disciplined approach to wealth protection, he said.

the hindu businessline.
WEDNESDAY - OCTOBER 21, 2026

Plugging loopholes

Concerted moves to curb Mauritius tax avoidance route

The Centre is clearly not in a mood to humour tax avoidance agreements. The recent amendments made to the double taxation avoidance agreement (DTAA) between India and Mauritius bear this out. Two important amendments have been made to the treaty. One, the preamble of the treaty, which was rather ambivalent, has been replaced to send a stern message to tax-evaders. Two, Article 27B has been introduced, which inserts the principal purpose test to help tax authorities reject transactions where the main intent is to avoid tax.



The amendment has dropped mild terms such as 'prevention of fiscal evasion' and 'encouraging mutual trade and investment' in the preamble. The preamble now states that the intent of the DTAA is to remove opportunities for non-taxation, or reduced taxation through tax evasion or avoidance. These include treaty shopping arrangements, which provide indirect benefits to residents of a third jurisdiction. The treaty is now more closely aligned with the OECD's convention against Base Erosion and Profit Shifting. With innovative tax arrangements and treaty shopping resulting in a loss of 4-10 per cent of global corporate income tax revenue annually, it is well that India and other signatories of the BEPS convention are sending a warning to MNCs.

The amendment also reflects India's growing frustration with the misuse of the Mauritius route. Following the India-Mauritius DTAA, signed in 1982, Mauritius emerged as the largest source of all foreign portfolio and foreign direct investments into India. It facilitated round-tripping — funds moving out of India and returning — through shell entities to disguise the source of funds or claim tax breaks. While the treaty was amended in 2016, giving India the right to tax capital gains on investments from Mauritius, made after April 1, 2017, investors continued to misuse this route. The recent Tiger Global judgment by the Supreme Court is a case in point; the investment company tried to evade capital gains tax on its sale of Flipkart's shares to Walmart by routing the investment through entities based in Mauritius. Despite the tightening, Mauritius was the third highest source of foreign direct investment in 2025-26 and the fifth highest source of foreign portfolio investments. Clearly, the opaque structures created in the island nation to aid tax evasion are still operational.

The principal purpose test, introduced through the recent amendment, tries to address the gaps in the treaty. It lays down that the benefit of the treaty will be denied if the main objective of the tax arrangement is to derive gains from the DTAA. While it is good to deny benefits to dubious transactions, tax authorities should not use the test to reopen past cases or slap taxes on transactions made prior to April 1, 2017. The Central Board of Direct Taxes, through its circular issued in January 2025, had allayed these fears, stating that the principal purpose test will be used only prospectively. It is hoped that the CBDT sticks to its word.

OTHER VOICES.

South China Morning Post

Ensure engineering standards remain sky high

Hong Kong's civil engineering work is reputedly among the world's best, as evidenced by the awe-inspiring infrastructure marvels and skyscrapers that have been built with exceptional efficiency and high standards across the city. These hard-earned credentials are not accidental but rooted in generations of professional practice and robust institutional safeguards and monitoring. Yet public confidence has been shaken by a series of scandals involving shoddy construction and maintenance work. From steel-reinforcement shortfalls at a luxury property development in Stanley to the forced demolition of three substandard towers at a starter home project in Kwun Tong, the incidents paint a disturbing picture of slipping standards in a city that once set benchmarks for civil engineering excellence. (HONG KONG, OCT 20)

The Jakarta Post

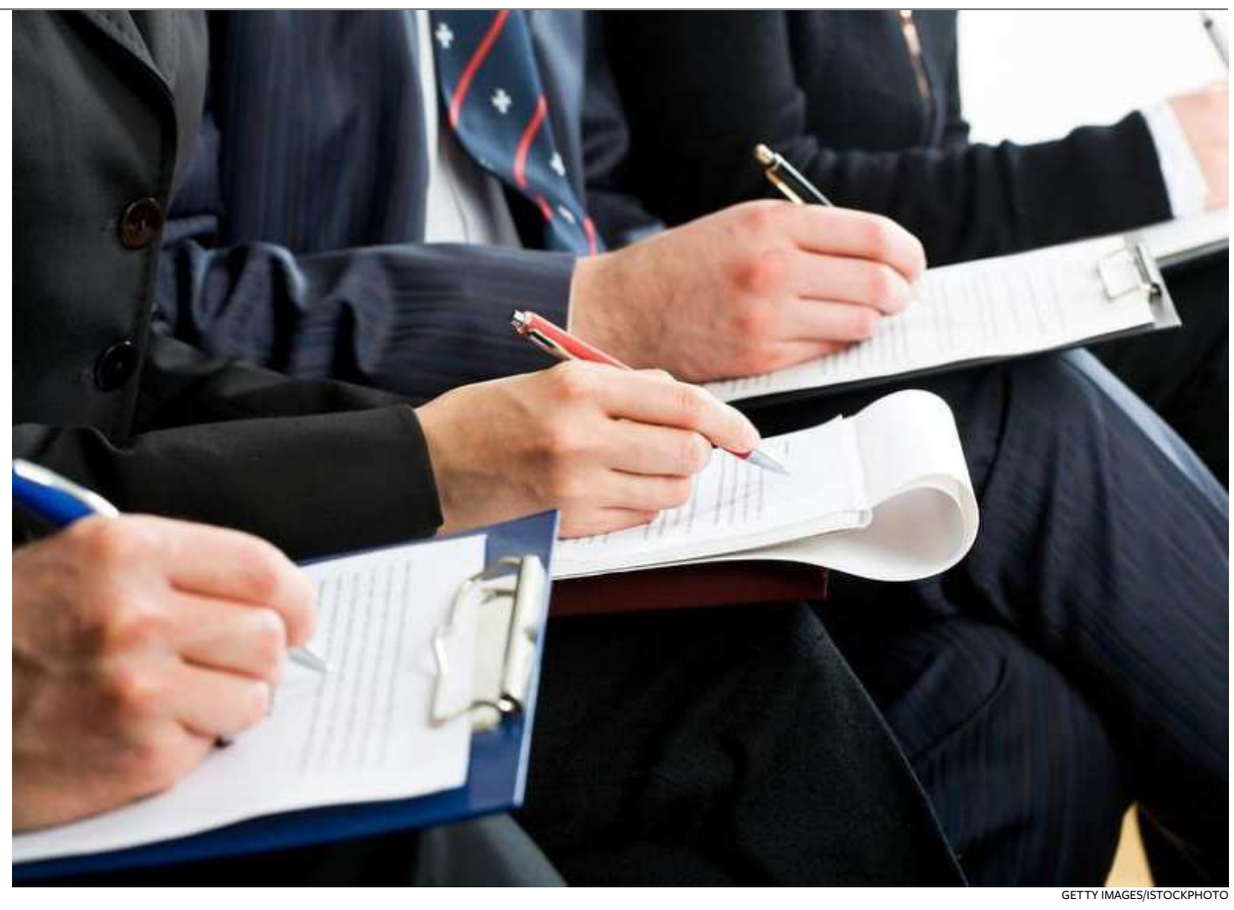
Power for the people

As President Prabowo Subianto marks the second year of his administration today, there is actually very little for him to celebrate in terms of progress or achievements. Everywhere you look, natural disasters, public service disruptions and economic setbacks have made the country appear to be teetering on the brink, and whether he likes it or not President Prabowo is seen by many as being slow to respond to the problems, if not causing the problems themselves through his unconventional policies. In parts of Sumatra, Kalimantan and Papua monstrous fires have been burning peatland forests for four months, sending hazardous haze that has blanketed not only the areas where hot spots are detected but also neighboring countries like Singapore, Malaysia and the Philippines. (JAKARTA, OCT 20)

LINE & LENGTH.



TCA SRINIVASA RAGHAVAN



GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCKPHOTO

A political crib sheet for foreign diplomats in India

BLEAK DAYS. India faces a politically uncertain period and effects of global economic woes

What would a foreign diplomat, when asked to file a quick report on the political situation in India, say? This is how the report might be framed.

Is there any threat to the survival of the government?

There isn't now, but it's hard to say what the general election in 2029 will throw up. The constant confrontation by the Opposition since 2014 will go up several notches and be visible on the streets. But mobilising a movement is easier than sustaining it.

How successful will the government be in defusing the anger?

There is anger for a variety of economic reasons, such as unemployment, wage stagnation and inflation. The government will be successful for now, but the anger could manifest itself in the 16 Assembly elections between now and the general election in April 2029. In the seven elections to be held next year, the BJP is in power in five States.

Will the BJP be able to form the government in 2029?

This is a very difficult question, but the probability that it will form the government is at present higher than 0.5. Much would depend on if it emerges as the single-largest party. It's highly likely to.

Will Rahul Gandhi be acceptable to other political parties as their leader?

Before this question comes up, he must clarify that he will accept the responsibility. He has not done that in the past. Nevertheless, he has age on his side, but that could be offset by the Congress not having enough seats in the Hindi States, even though the party won about 20 per cent of the vote in 2024.

Back to large coalitions. How many seats will the BJP lose from its current 240?

This is impossible to predict in the Indian system. However, assuming that it is the single-largest party, it will be able to form a government in a coalition that is as large as the UPA between 2004-2014. That coalition had 20 parties in it.

In a large coalition, what role will the RSS play?

A large coalition means the RSS has failed to help the BJP secure a majority. This happened in 1999, 2004 and 2024. In a large coalition, relations between it and the BJP will be very strained. This relationship is worth watching.

What internal power tussles can be expected?

Basically, this question is who the RSS supports to succeed Narendra Modi, whenever that decision comes up. This is not an immediate issue, but has to be confronted at some point. It's another pain point for the BJP.

Does increasing the number of seats in the Lok Sabha from 543 to 850 help the BJP or hinder it?

This requires a granular analysis that only political parties with constituency level data can carry out to make an informed assessment. We can only wait and watch.

Will the current protests — which make vote chori (theft of Opposition votes by the BJP) the central theme — shift voters away from the BJP?

After a long period of political stability, India has entered a very uncertain period because of intensified political contestation

The BJP received over 37 per cent of the votes polled. So, the required shift of votes away from it is massive and unlikely.

There will surely be a shift downward from 37 per cent, but probably not enough for the Opposition to form a government.

How will the BJP and the government convince the voter that the Opposition is wrong and that it is a victim of lies?

Government clarifications and protests won't cut much ice with uncommitted voters, because after 12 years in power, its credibility is not very strong.

Ironically, it has been cornered by an allegation that makes it a victim of its own success; for instance, in three Assembly elections in 2025.

How will the government handle the unemployment problem?

For a long time now, the government has not been in a position to provide direct employment because it doesn't have the resources. Its best bet is to remove all constraints on private sector investment, Indian and foreign, and make the labour market flexible. Taxes are now low and infrastructure is generally available. The constraints now involve massive bureaucratic and political corruption. The Modi government has not been able to tackle the former, but the latter appears less now than under the UPA.

Conclusion

The next 30 months will be very difficult, both politically and economically.

What's worse, one will reinforce the other. The main point to note is that after a long period of political stability, India has entered a very uncertain period because of intensified political contestation.

This comes on top of all the global economic uncertainties, which will slow down aggregate investments in India. This is the main problem the Modi government faces.

Rupee, and the price of dodging a century

Improving ease of doing business and speedy decision-making by the govt will help the rupee find its right level

NS Vageesh

The Indian rupee, currently trading at 94.81 to the dollar, was Asia's worst-performing currency till a week ago, declining 7 per cent over the past nine months (following a 5 per cent decline over calendar 2025), before a spate of RBI measures helped the currency recover a bit. In May this year, the rupee had touched 96.71 to the dollar, flirting dangerously close to the psychological 100 to a dollar mark.

JUST ANOTHER NUMBER?

The sceptical reader would be right to wonder: what is the worst that would have happened if the currency had crossed 100? Nothing terrible, really. 101 or 103 is just another number. But it would have been a bit embarrassing for a country claiming to be the fastest-growing large economy and wanting to flex muscles in the global arena. A currency number that's substantially market determined has the uncomfortable ring of final diagnosis of an economy's performance and its relative standing vis-a-vis other peer economies.

THE SACROSANCT 100

Fearing a breach of that sacred level, an uneasy government got the RBI to invite more dollars to India through the FCNR(B) deposits scheme in June this year and defray the currency depreciation risks faced by banks. The RBI duly mopped up $133 billion, and that temporarily stemmed the decline of the rupee.

The pressure on the rupee has come from a variety of factors, including global uncertainty, crude oil price hikes and fast-exiting foreign institutional investors (FIIs). In the 10 months of the calendar year so far, net FII outflows have been at $32.8 billion. In 2025, net FII outflows were at $16 billion.

The RBI has certainly tried all usual measures to defend the rupee. It sold plenty of dollars in the market over the past two years. Net dollars sold (sales of dollars less purchases of dollars) in the spot market was $53 billion last fiscal (FY26) after net sales of $35 billion in FY25.

In the first two months of this fiscal, the RBI sold $15 billion. Last week, the RBI raised interest rates (repo rates) by 0.25 percentage points to 5.50 per cent after nearly two years. They have tightened controls on importers' payments and forex derivative contracts, and opened a special window for oil-importing companies, which create the bulk of demand for dollars on a daily basis, given that India imports 90 per cent of its fuel requirements. Last week, RBI Governor Sanjay Malhotra also suggested that the rupee was undervalued.



PRESSURE. Comes from a variety of factors for the currency

The list of measures, while necessary, are insufficient and palliative at best. The real issues that need to be addressed are attracting FII inflows again and retaining them. FII money is exiting India as capital gets reallocated to newer sectors (AI/ semiconductors/data centres), as well as due to higher interest rates in the US. Some are leaving after encashing handsome gains.

STABLE CURRENCY

A more stable currency in the immediate future is, however, contingent on sorting out some issues. Most critical would be taxation of FIIs. They pay both capital gains tax and securities transaction tax in India, which eat into their gains when compared to investments in other peer economies where the rates are zero.

In addition, FIIs also have to factor an average annual decline of 4 per cent in the Indian currency value over the long term, which makes us relatively uncompetitive. The Finance Minister has hinted at a possible re-look at the rates for long-term capital gains for FIIs and that would be a welcome move.

Improving ease of doing business, along with speedy decision-making by the government in tandem with an attractive tax regime, will help the rupee find the right level when the sentiment turns positive once again.

The writer is a former journalist

LETTERS TO EDITOR

Send your letters by email to bleditor@thehindu.co.in or by post to 'Letters to the Editor', The Hindu Business Line, Kasturi Buildings, 859-860, Anna Salai, Chennai 600002.

India goes places

This refers to the news report 'Jio Platforms IPO draws record ₹2.50 lakh crore institutional demand' (Oct 20). It is heartening to see investors placing strong trust in an Indian company despite competition from powerful international players. The overwhelming institutional response to Jio Platforms reflects the confidence in India's digital growth and the ability of domestic enterprises to compete on an international scale. The participation of Indian mutual funds, insurance companies and international investors is encouraging. However, strong demand alone should not determine an investment decision. Retail investors must examine the company's valuation, financial performance and future prospects before subscribing. Transparent disclosures and fair pricing are essential to protect their interests. India needs more home-grown companies that attract global capital, generate employment and promote innovation. This will strengthen our economy and enhance India's position in the global marketplace.

A Myilsami
Coimbatore

Trump does it again

This refers to 'Is Trump's diesel deal another poll gimmick?' (Oct19). Yes, of course. Mind you, his Republican senators seeking re-election even in the safe seats, are highly likely to find it extremely hard to make a comeback. But then, credit for such a worrisome scenario goes to Trump for he is known for taking U turns, much to the discomfiture of others as well as his fellow citizens. The biggest fallout of Trump's tariff-driven salvos is that he may end up scoring a self goal in the process. The case in example could be the full-fledged retaliation by Canada in response to his tariff-centric tactics.

A Gupta
New Delhi

Gains from grains

With reference to 'Ecosystem services and role of farmers' (Oct19), the writers' concern on vital areas connected to agriculture on issues such as groundwater recharge, carbon storage and pollination are very valid. Free power for agriculture has resulted in the overexploitation of of ground water. The lack of contiguous agricultural fields and fast urbanisation affect cross-pollination, which will have an impact on the quality and quantity of the produce.

The PM Programme for Restoration, Awareness Generation, Nourishment and Amelioration of Mother Earth, aimed at reducing the use of chemical fertilizers and promoting balanced, sustainable agriculture, is losing sheen. The government could launch a 'gains from grains' campaign with all incentives, subsidies and other promotional schemes under one roof.

RV Baskaran
Pune

Reel vs real charm

A film star's charm can open doors, but only a government's work keeps them open (Reel charm of Vijay, Oct19). When a CEO jokes about blockbusters, it shows that Tamil Nadu has won attention. Attention, however, does not mean employment. Every major investment should come with a public 'jobs promise sheet,' listing how many local people will be hired and what skills will be taught. Popularity is a gift that should be used with care. A leader can bring investors, but investors stay for stable rules and skilled workers. Fans, in turn, can show their affection by asking questions, not just cheering.

K Chidanand Kumar
Bengaluru

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Farming, the natural way

The way ahead for Gujarat's natural farming

C Shambu Prasad
PVS Suryakumar

Over two decades, Gujarat's agriculture has grown at around 9 per cent a year, more than double the national average, making the State a leader in groundnut, castor, cumin, fennel and cotton, and in dairy through Amul.

Yet, this rests on increasingly stressed natural resources. Water use exceeds irrigation plan limits by 21 per cent, northern districts face groundwater over-extraction, and about half the State's land is undergoing desertification.

Recognising this, Gujarat adopted an Organic Farming Policy in 2015 and set up India's first organic agriculture university in 2017, since renamed the Gujarat Natural Farming Science University.

Gujarat now pursues Natural Farming (NF) through mass-mobilisation rather than certification alone, backed by a ₹392-crore budget for 2026-27, and policy instruments like Gujarat Prakrutik Krushi Vikas Board (GPKVB) and the Desi Gau Sahay Yojana to promote indigenous cows. Under the National Mission on Natural Farming 1.51 lakh farmers have been enrolled on 61,919 hectares in 1,376 clusters by August 2026.

The spread of NF is estimated at 5.64 lakh farmers across 2 lakh hectares. But the count measure reach, not outcomes. There is no working definition of a 'natural farming farmer' and to measure the depth of practice. There are a few independent assessments on NF adoption, but small and dated: a 2022 survey of 288 farmers in 102 villages found 47 per cent buy bio-fertilizers and 29 per cent are still using chemical pesticides, but most of them are counted as adopters. Have all farmers completely transited and how inclusive is the transition? Tenants, who cultivate close to half the State's cultivated area, remain outside most schemes, as do landless livestock keepers. The Desi Gau Sahay Yojana, which depends on cow ownership and a land record, leaves them out.

In Dang, India's first declared chemical-free district, the all-women Dang Adiwasi Khedut Producer Company now has over 2,000 shareholders across 130 villages.



TWEAKING. Gujarat's natural farming policy VIJAY SONEJI

SOME SUGGESTIONS

The question is how Gujarat can build on this pioneering legacy. Drawing from insights from a recent policy brief by the National Coalition for Natural Farming, we suggest the following.

First, treat the transition as a five-to-eight-year journey. It cannot rest on one scheme; it needs sustained government financial commitment and season-long, repeated handholding rather than one-off training.

Second, institutionalise women's extension cadres (Krishi Sakhis and women master farmers), by giving them defined roles within ATMA.

Third, consider positioning Bio-Input Resource Centres and FPOs as frontline extension hubs.

Fourth, adopt SHG-backed models to include tenant farmers.

Fifth, connect fields to market by channelling NF produce into anganwadis and mid-day meals.

Sixth, institutionalise paired-plot trials on farmers' fields to track soil carbon, water use and income and also incentivise farmers with carbon credits and extra income.

Seventh, treat enrolment as an input and five seasons of sustained practice as the outcome. Training numbers matter less than maturity of practice.

Eighth, while going wide, Gujarat must go deep. It could build a few reference landscapes, small enough to manage and large enough to show a whole system working. These would let government perfect the administrative mechanisms for transition and serve as lighthouses where farmers can see, feel and believe, and learn NF.

Finally, finance has a role in the transition. These landscapes require the usual agriculture credit for individual farmers and also patient capital for the transition namely: extension, community institutions, aggregation, market systems and data. With GIFT City in its midst, the State must scout for green capital which would enable this transition.

Prasad is Professor at IRMA-TSU, Anand; Suryakumar is former Deputy Managing Director, Nabard

A world of multiple crises

Conflict in the Middle East is stoking protests over living costs from Paris to Portugal

THE WIDER ANGLE.



PARAN BALAKRISHNAN

Talk about a world in upheaval. From Europe's streets to battlefields of the Middle East, turmoil seems everywhere. Governments are struggling to contain public anger, demonstrators are taking over city centres and wars are sending shockwaves through the global economy.

India is hardly alone in witnessing public unrest. Even normally peaceful Portugal has been shaken by demonstrations against unaffordable housing with protesters pitching tents in the streets of Lisbon and Porto.

The anger is understandable. Portugal's house prices have more than doubled in a decade. But Portugal's only one flashpoint in a much wider wave of European unrest.

In Paris, one of the most extraordinary images of the disturbances shows a couple in a café, sipping their coffee unperturbed as flames burn outside. It's a surreal picture of everyday life continuing amid chaos.

In Italy, protesters battled police outside Milan's landmark cathedral. Nearby, disturbances emptied the elegant shopping district around the historic Galleria Vittorio Emanuele II. There have been demonstrations in Belgium, Spain and Albania too. Grievances vary from housing shortages and inadequate schools to low wages, corruption and living costs. But the common thread is frustration among people who feel living standards are eroding and governments aren't doing enough to help.

MIDDLE EAST CATALYST

And while Europe's streets are erupting in anger, the Middle East is being convulsed by something far more deadly with missiles and drones flying and US President Donald Trump threatening to drop the 'Mother of All Bombs' on Iran.



ANGER BREWING. Masked protesters during a demonstration against the cost of living and rising fuel prices in Paris (file photo) REUTERS

Meanwhile, Tehran's threatened a "scorched-earth" war against Israel.

Across the Gulf, Saudi Arabia is battling Yemen's Iran-backed Houthi rebels, who have seized territory near the key Bab el-Mandeb Strait. Together with the Strait of Hormuz, it's one of the world's most important maritime chokepoints.

The Saudis possess one of the region's most sophisticated air forces. But this week, Houthi missiles reportedly killed 53 Yemeni government military recruits, underlining their ability to inflict heavy casualties despite inferior weaponry.

There are reports Pakistani pilots are helping fly Saudi aircraft, although Islamabad insists its role is defensive. Pakistan's in an uncomfortable position with close Saudi military and financial ties but a long border with Iran. Islamabad has little desire to become deeply embroiled in a war.

The fuel price hikes have stoked public anger and frustration across the world, particularly sparking long simmering discontent over education and housing in Europe

Houthi missile and drone attacks on Riyadh's King Khalid International Airport, meanwhile, have badly disrupted flight operations and caused at least 12 deaths, including of one Indian.

Behind much of the Mideast turmoil lies the confrontation between Israel and Iran. Israel's military actions have also become entangled with conflicts across Lebanon, Syria and Iraq. The result is a region where one war threatens to ignite another.

LINKED CONFLICTS

That's where the seemingly separate stories of European street protests and Mideast wars combine. The disruption to shipping has sent fuel prices soaring and added enormously to the fuel and goods transport costs. For crude import-dependent India, the conflicts have ballooned our energy bill.

In the US, diesel prices have climbed from $3.76 a gallon to as much as $10. Diesel is key because it fuels the trucks delivering food and manufactured goods. Europe has been hit hard, too.

France provides a striking example. The French have a long tradition of taking their grievances onto the streets. The latest disturbance began with an education protest but it's morphed into anger across society over rising prices, stagnant incomes and declining living standards. The fuel price surge has only stoked frustration.

It would be wrong to suggest the Mideast conflicts caused all Europe's problems. Housing shortages, low wages, overstretched public services and disillusionment with established political parties were already creating deep resentment. But the war has fuelled the smouldering fire.

There's another political dimension to the unrest. Trump and Elon Musk are supporting Europe's nationalist right, which hopes to profit from dissatisfaction with mainstream governments. They've backed France's far-right leader Marine Le Pen and Germany's far-right Alternative für Deutschland.

Trump's attempts to end the conflicts as he struggles to reduce domestic energy prices before the crucial mid-terms have highlighted his unconventional foreign policy approach. Rather than relying on veteran diplomats, Trump has entrusted negotiating the most complex conflicts to son-in-law Jared Kushner and longtime pal, property developer Steve Witkoff, despite neither having foreign policy experience.

Secretary of State Marco Rubio. Rubio, who's visiting India, would ordinarily be at the forefront of peace negotiations. An ex-senator, he's spent years immersed in foreign affairs. Yet Rubio's been sidelined.

What's clear is that the consequences of these wars are no longer confined to the countries fighting them. The world may not be facing one single crisis. But its many crises are becoming increasingly interconnected, and people everywhere are paying the price.

STATISTALK.

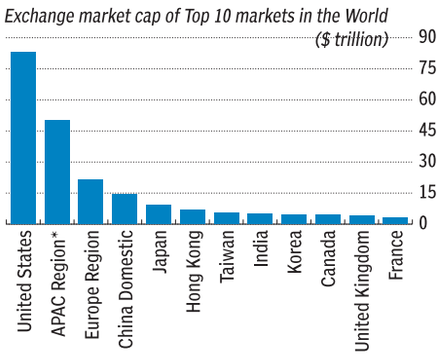
Compiled by **Dhuraivel Gunasekaran** | Graphic **KS Gunasekar**

How technology is reshaping Asia's investment landscape

Investing in Asia is no longer a one-size-fits-all proposition, with opportunities increasingly diverging across markets, sectors and themes, Goldman Sachs says in its latest report. Regional market capitalisation has climbed to nearly $50 trillion, making Asia the world's second-largest equity bloc. Technology is driving this shift, with Taiwan and Korea emerging as dominant markets and information technology accounting for about 44% of index capitalisation and earnings. Goldman Sachs expects a powerful earnings cycle, forecasting 34% annual earnings growth during 2026-28, fuelled by AI-driven semiconductor demand and massive hyperscaler spending. It sees further upside as investors recognise Asia's evolving, tech-centric growth story.

Asia emerges as the world's second largest equity superpower

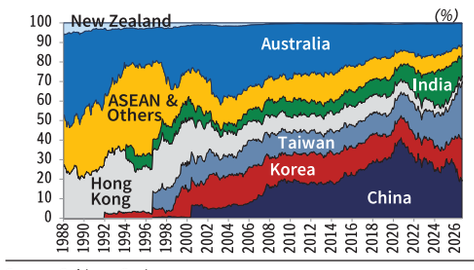
Exchange market cap of Top 10 markets in the World ($ trillion)



*aggregate market capitalization of Asian equity markets

Taiwan and Korea take the driver's seat**

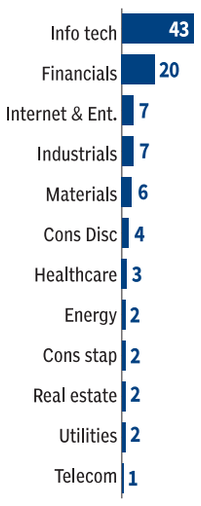
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Technology overtakes financials as Asia's growth engine

*Index cap weight by sector** (%)*

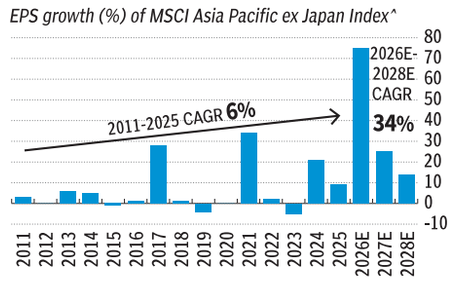
Latest weight as of Sep-2026



**Break-up of MSCI AC Asia Pacific ex Japan Index

Asia's earnings engine to shift into higher gear

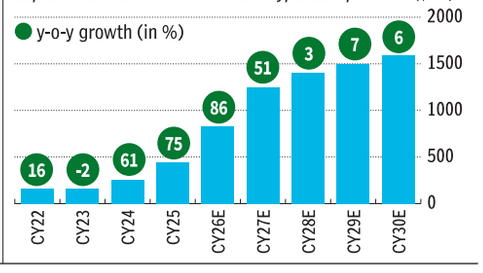
*EPS growth (%) of MSCI Asia Pacific ex Japan Index^*



^in local currency

The AI spending wave behind Asia's tech boom

Capital investments for US cloud and hyperscale providers ($ bn)



Source: Goldman Sachs

Short take

China warning on global turmoil

Bloomberg News

China's finance minister opened a key gathering of APEC officials in Hong Kong by delivering a warning about global economic uncertainty and tumult, calling for a joint effort to prevent spillovers from policy shifts.

"The international landscape is increasingly turbulent and complex, with geopolitical conflicts spilling across borders and posing multiple challenges to global economic growth," Lan Fo'an said at the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation finance ministers' meeting on Tuesday. While short on detail, Lan's brief remarks struck a note of caution at a time when the world economy is becoming more protectionist and coming under increasing pressure from the shockwaves of the war in the Middle East. In the backdrop are elevated bond yields that are raising financing costs while oil prices add to inflation concerns.

"It is essential to strengthen macroeconomic policy dialogue and safeguard regional economic and financial stability," said Lan. "Member economies should strengthen the stability and health of their macro economic policies. In the meantime, we must strengthen policy communications, to prevent the negative spillover impact of policy adjustments in a coordinated way."

thehindu businessline.

TWENTY YEARS AGO TODAY.

October 21, 2006

Tatas to buy Corus for $8 b

Tata Steel will celebrate a century of its existence as well as the largest acquisition by any Indian company ever when it closes the transaction deal for the UK-based Corus Group in January next year. Ninety-nine-year-old Tata Steel's £ 4.3-billion takeover bid for steelmaker Corus was approved by the boards of both companies on Friday.

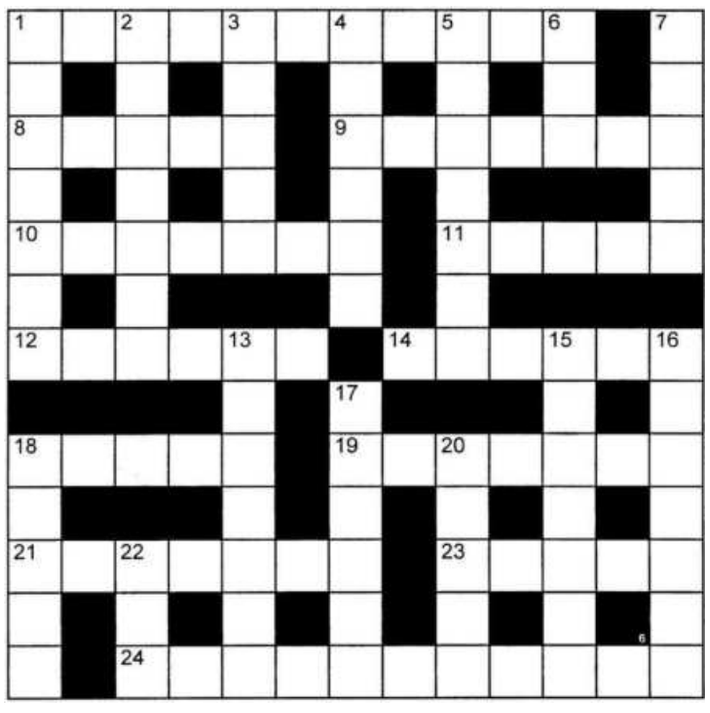
CLB to Bajajs: Settle dispute in a month

The Company Law Board has directed the two Bajaj brothers, Rahul and Shishir, to settle their family dispute within a month. The CLB Chairman, Mr S. Balasubramaniam told the two brothers that in order to maintain the family name, they should resolve the dispute over cross-holdings in the Bajaj Group by adopting a give-and-take policy.

RasGas to supply LNG to Dabhol plant from April

Qatar-based RasGas Company Ltd will supply LNG to the Dabhol power plant of Ratnagiri Gas and Power Private Ltd (RGPPL) from April 2007. RasGas will supply 1.2 million tonnes of gas per annum. Price negotiations for gas supply is currently under way but the contract would be till March 2009, said Mr Chandan Roy, Chairman and Managing Director of RGPPL.

BL TWO-WAY CROSSWORD 2760



EASY

ACROSS

01. A lady of quality (11)
08. Proportion, quotient (5)
09. American legislator (7)
10. Apprehends, by legal authority (7)
11. Roughly (5)
12. 100 cents (6)
14. Skilful, dexterous (6)
18. On the qui vive (5)
19. Show contemptuous scorn (7)
21. Tumult, agitation (7)
23. Living (5)
24. A variation as to facts (11)

DOWN

01. Flower-wreath (7)
02. Having no affectation (7)
03. Leonine animals (5)
04. The most sagacious (6)
05. Roof with lower part steeper than upper (7)
06. Bolt counterpart (3)
07. Measure of gold fineness (5)
13. Female Thespian (7)
15. Outburst of popular applause (7)
16. Leather factory (7)
17. Leading journalist (6)
18. Attach, subjoin (5)
20. Cutting, keen (5)
22. To free one from (3)

NOT SO EASY

ACROSS

01. She was a lady who lent me a gown to change into (11)
08. The proportion of air to the mixture (5)
09. How Nero sat about with one of his legislators (7)
10. Nabs one from the rear, perhaps, on the streets (7)
11. It is, approximately, an attack of 'flu (5)
12. Rod, all that could be made for a buck (6)
14. There's a skilful raid to be carried out (6)
18. Dealer tries to hold it, being watchful (5)
19. There is contempt for India's confusion about start of democracy (7)
21. People could fret about such agitation (7)
23. Is living evil a form of it? (5)
24. Candy prices are altered as being a variance of facts (11)

DOWN

01. A wreath for Gran lad made up (7)
02. Is unaffected by being neither above nor below the note (7)
03. They are British sportsmen in their pride (5)
04. No more sage is to be found in the occident (6)
05. The sort of roof man's put on a road (7)
06. One may take a wrench to it, wanting to get at the kernel (3)
07. A measure of gold is used in sizing stones (5)
13. Crest as given to one in part employment (7)
15. A standing cheer could make one too vain (7)
16. Sixpence, last of money used where hides were treated (7)
17. Journalist who might be tried for including nothing (6)
18. If it turns up in the wrong fax, stick it on (5)
20. It may raise a note that's ready to be cutting (5)
22. Free one from one found in the road (3)

SOLUTION: BL TWO-WAY CROSSWORD 2759

ACROSS 1. Burst 4. Airship 8. A stitch in time 10. Hinge 11. Owns 12. Move 16. Overt 17. Consideration 19. Radical 20. Dread

DOWN 1. Branch-officer 2. Rot 3. Tetchy 4. Aching 5. Runner 6. Heirlooms 7. Predetermined 9. Contained 13. Zodiac 14. Reveal 15. Strand 18. Ice

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DELHI
businessline.
WEDNESDAY - OCTOBER 21 - 2026

QUICKLY.

Paras Healthcare secures ₹652 crore ahead of IPO



New Delhi: Paras Healthcare Ltd, which operates hospitals under the Paras Health brand, has garnered ₹652.5 crore from anchor investors, ahead of its ₹1,450 crore initial public offering (IPO). The company attracted participation from domestic as well as global anchor investors. According to circulars uploaded on exchanges' websites, Paras Healthcare has allotted 94,15,584 equity shares to 39 funds at ₹693 apiece, aggregating to ₹652.5 crore. Paras Healthcare's IPO will open on October 21 and conclude on October 23. The price band has been fixed at ₹660-693 per share. PTI

EAAA India Alternatives to float ₹1,200 crore IPO

New Delhi: EAAA India Alternatives Ltd, an arm of Edelweiss Financial Services, will open its ₹1,200 crore IPO for subscription on October 26. The issue will close on October 28, while anchor investor bidding is scheduled for October 23, according to the company's Red Herring Prospectus. The IPO size has been reduced to ₹1,200 crore from the ₹1,500 crore proposed in the draft red herring prospectus filed with the SEBI in January. The issue is entirely an offer for sale (OFS) by the Edelweiss Group with no fresh issue component. The IPO comprises a fresh issue of equity shares worth up to ₹150 crore and an OFS of up to 1,56,82,750 equity shares, according to the red herring prospectus. ANI

Fresh market borrowings getting pricier amid a tightening cycle

INFLATION PRESSURES. Rising yields push govt borrowing costs higher as 10-year G-Sec issuances near 7.4%

K Ram Kumar
Mumbai

With the secondary market yield of the benchmark 10-year Government Security (G-Sec) (6.94 per cent GS 2036) spiking to 7.4 per cent levels and cut-offs at the weekly G-Secs auctions also rising in tandem since July 2026, fresh market borrowings for the government is getting pricier amid a tightening cycle.

Going by the prevailing secondary market yield (of 7.39 per cent) of the benchmark 10-year G-Sec and taking into account factors such as rising crude oil prices, US sovereign bond yields, geopolitical tensions, and possibility of more rate hikes by RBI's rate-setting panel, it is likely the new 10-year G-Sec issuance will be at a coupon rate of 7.35 per cent to 7.5 per cent against 6.94 per cent on the on-the-run 10-year benchmark G-Sec, say bond market experts. The outstanding size of the existing 6.94 GS 2036 has already reached ₹2.38 lakh crore and it is likely the government may issue a new 10-year G-Sec soon.

Last year (2025), the government issued a 10-year paper (6.33 per cent GS 2035) on May 05, 2025. When the outstanding in this paper reached ₹1,83,374 crore, the goverment issued a new 10-year paper (6.48 per cent GS 2035) on October 06, 2025.

CRUCIAL THRESHOLD

- Weekly auction cut-offs rose 67 bps since July
- Existing benchmark outstanding reached ₹2.38 lakh crore
- Repo hiked to 5.5%
- Further tightening expected soon



WEIGHTED AVERAGE

The RBI's latest monetary policy report noted that the weighted average yield of issuances at 7 per cent in H1 (April-September 2026) was higher than 6.6 per cent in H1 (April-September 2025).

G-Secs yields have been going up since July 2026.

For example, the cut-off on the on-the-run 10-year benchmark G-Sec (6.94 per cent GS 2036) has risen from 6.7275 per cent at the July 03, 2026 weekly G-Sec auction to 7.3955 per cent at the October 16, 2026 auction, a jump of 67 basis points (bps).

Venkatakrishnan Srinivasan, Founder & Managing Partner, Rockfort Fincap LLP, observed that the government bond market remains under pressure, with the cut-off yield on the 6.94 per centGS 2036 rising to 7.3955 per cent on October 16 from 7.145 per cent on September 25, a hardening of 25.05 bps in three weeks.

He emphasised that the 25 bps repo rate hike to 5.5 per cent (on October 7), expectations of further monetary tightening, elevated crude prices, inflation concerns and global bond-market pressures have weighed on the bond market sentiment.

"The rise in yields will increase the cost of fresh government borrowing. The published indicative RBI borrowing calendar provides for around ₹1.73 lakh crore of 10-year issuance between November 2026 and March 2027," he said.

"The outstanding size of the existing 6.94 per cent GS 2036 has reached ₹2.38 lakh crore. So, issuance of a new 10-year benchmark is possible. If a new security is issued in the backdrop of prevailing yields, its indicative coupon could be around 7.35 per cent to 7.50 per cent, depending on market conditions and the government's pricing decision," Srinivasan said.

Axis Mutual Fund, in report, said that the RBI may raise rates by an additional 50-75 bps in the near term, taking the operative rate towards 6-6.25 per cent.

KEY MONITORABLES

Beyond that, the depth and duration of the tightening cycle will become increasingly data dependent, with key monitorables including the developments in the West Asia conflict, the trajectory of crude oil prices, global bond yields, domestic core inflation and the resilience of growth.

Oyo parent to halve IPO fresh issue to ₹3,350 cr

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

Oyo parent Prism is planning to nearly halve the size of the fresh issue in its proposed initial public offering (IPO) to up to ₹3,350 crore from almost ₹6,650 crore, sources said on Tuesday.

The reduction in the issue size follows continued strong cash generation and an improving balance sheet position, which has lowered the amount of capital the company needs to raise compared with what was originally envisaged, sources added.

"The original issue was sized before the company's more recent financial performance came through. With cash generation remaining strong and the balance sheet improving, the funding requirement has come down, allowing the company to reduce the amount of primary capital it raises. The objective is to raise what the business needs while keeping the capital structure efficient. The plan is to repay the residual debt over the next two to three years through cash flows generated by the business," a source said.

Earlier, Oyo planned to raise up to ₹6,650 crore through an IPO, of which around ₹5,000 crore was intended for debt repayment.

REVISED STRUCTURE

The revised issue size comes with Prism continuing to focus on reducing its outstanding debt. Under the revised structure, most of the issue proceeds are proposed to be used towards repayment or prepayment, in part or full, of certain borrowings.

The revised issue comes as PRISM moves towards the next stage of its proposed IPO, following its earlier filing of the UDRHP (updated draft herring prospectus).

Moody's Ratings has revised the outlook on Prism to 'positive' from 'stable', while reaffirming the travel tech unicorn's B2 corporate family rating. Explaining the rationale behind ratings, Moody's said, "We expect Oyo's EBITDA to grow to around ₹3,000 crore ($315 million) over the next 12-18 months as the company continues to scale and add new storefronts to its platform."

For FY26, Oyo's EBITDA more than doubled to ₹2,630 crore from ₹1,080 crore in FY25.

Oyo was founded in 2013 by Ritesh Agarwal, who currently holds a 30.52 per cent stake in the company. SVF India Holdings (Cayman) Ltd, a subsidiary of SoftBank Group Corp is the largest shareholder in the company, with a 40.04 per cent stake.

Rupee recovery faces headwinds despite positive foreign inflows

Akhil Nallamuthu
bl. research bureau



According to NSDL data, net FPI inflows stood at $446 million in the past week, giving support to the rupee

The rupee appreciated 35 paise against the dollar over the past week, supported by a return of foreign portfolio inflows.

However, the continued rise in crude oil prices remains a key concern for the local currency.

WEEKLY RUPEE VIEW.

Foreign flows turned positive over the past week. According to NSDL data, net FPI inflows stood at $446 million, providing some support to the rupee.

Nevertheless, cumulative net outflows in October stand at around $4.3 billion.

Crude oil prices, meanwhile, have been on an upward trajectory since July.

Brent crude, currently trading around $112 per barrel, has gained nearly 14 per cent so far in October.

The sustained rise in oil prices remains a significant headwind for the rupee, given India's dependence on crude imports.

Overall, the return of foreign inflows has provided some relief to the rupee.

However, elevated crude oil prices could limit the scope for further appreciation, keeping the near-term outlook challenging.

CHART

The rupee has been declining over the past few days after facing selling pressure near 94.80. The local currency is currently trading at 94.93.

Although the recent price action indicates some weakness, the rupee has room to recover.

The nearest resistances are at 94.50 and 94.20. Hence, a recovery towards the 94.50-94.20 region is possible. On the other hand, if the rupee extends its decline from the current level of 94.93, it can fall to 95.80. A breach of this support can drag the local currency further down to 96.25.

The dollar index, after hitting a high of 102.95 last week, has moderated to 101.90.

The index has immediate support at 101.80, its 21-day moving average, followed by another support at 101.60. As long as the latter holds, the broader bias will remain positive.

The likelihood of the dollar index resuming its rally is high. A recovery from the current level can lift it to 102.60. This could be followed by a break-out above 103, potentially taking the index to 103.50.

Such a move would put renewed downward pressure on the rupee.

OUTLOOK

The rupee could see a recovery towards 94.50-94.20 in the near term.

However, with the dollar index likely to resume its rally and elevated crude oil prices remaining a headwind, the broader bias remains bearish.

A reversal could drag the rupee towards 95.80-96.25.

TODAY'S PICK.

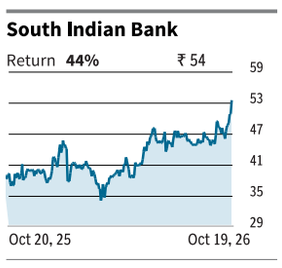
South Indian Bank (54.31): BUY

Gurumurthy K
bl. research bureau

The short-term outlook is bullish for South Indian Bank. The stock surged over 5 per cent on Monday and closed on a strong note. This rise has taken the share price well above a key resistance level of ₹51, which was capping the upside since mid-June.

It has also happened after forming a strong base above ₹45. Support is in the ₹51-₹49 region.

The South Indian Bank share price can rise to ₹62 in the coming weeks. Traders can buy South Indian Bank shares now at ₹54. Accumulate on dips at ₹52. Keep the stop-loss at ₹48.



Trail the stop-loss up to ₹55 as soon as the stock goes up to ₹57. Revise the stop-loss higher to ₹57 and ₹59 when the price touches ₹59 and ₹60 respectively. Exit the long positions at ₹62.

Note: The recommendations are based on technical analysis. There is a risk of loss in trading

Day trading guide

22894 » **Nifty 50 Futures**

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
22700	22650	23050	23200	Go short on a rise at 22990 and 23030 with a stop-loss at 23090

₹712 » **HDFC Bank**

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
708	698	715	720	Go short now and at 714. Keep the stop-loss at 716

₹1128 » **Infosys**

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
1110	1090	1145	1170	Wait for dips. Go long at 1115 with a stop-loss at 1105

₹261 » **ITC**

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
259	255	264	267	Take fresh shorts below 259. Keep the stop-loss at 260

₹224 » **ONGC**

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
222	218	226	228	Can go either way. Avoid trading this stock for now

₹1205 » **Reliance Ind.**

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
1190	1160	1220	1235	Wait for dips. Go long at 1195 with a stop-loss at 1185

₹972 » **SBI**

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
966	960	982	1000	Go long only above 982. Keep the stop-loss at 980

₹2461 » **TCS**

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
2410	2340	2500	2540	Wait for dips. Go long at 2435 and 2420 with a stop-loss at 2405

S1, S2: Support 1 & 2; R1, R2: Resistance 1 & 2.

CAMS eyes 20% share of revenue from non-core businesses in 2-3 years

Sindhu Hariharan
Chennai



Ram Charan Sesharaman, Chief Financial Officer, CAMS

Computer Age Management Services (CAMS), the largest mutual fund registrar and transfer agent with around 68 per cent market share, expects its non-mutual fund RTA businesses to contribute around 20 per cent of total revenue over the next two to three years.

This comes as the company scales up payment services and builds new revenue streams from digital personal data protection (DPDP) compliance, account aggregation, and other businesses.

"Non-mutual fund businesses currently account for 15-16 per cent of the company's revenue, up from less than 10 per cent a few years ago. We will get it up to 20 per cent pretty soon, in the next at least two to three years," Ram Charan Sesharaman, Chief Financial Officer, CAMS, told *businessline* in an interaction.

CAMS is targeting faster growth in non-core businesses even as its core mutual fund business continues to expand at 15-18 per cent annually.

CAMS has been expanding into payments, alternative investment fund services, KYC registration, insurance repositories, analytics and account aggregator technology services.

The latest among these is a product for DPDP compliance.

"Everything is a platform, everything is a non-linear kind of revenue growth," the CFO said.

GROWTH DRIVER

Payments services, currently CAMS' largest non-mutual fund business, are expected to reach ₹100 crore in revenue this year, according to the CFO.

The payments business has expanded from processing systematic investment plan mandates and collections for mutual funds, to offering a range of services. "We plan to focus on financial services and select adjacent segments, while staying away from e-commerce, cryptocurrency and gaming," Sesharaman said.

Account aggregation remains a longer-term opportunity, the CFO said, noting that the business had yet to achieve sustainable economics given the low pricing, limited use cases and uneven participation.

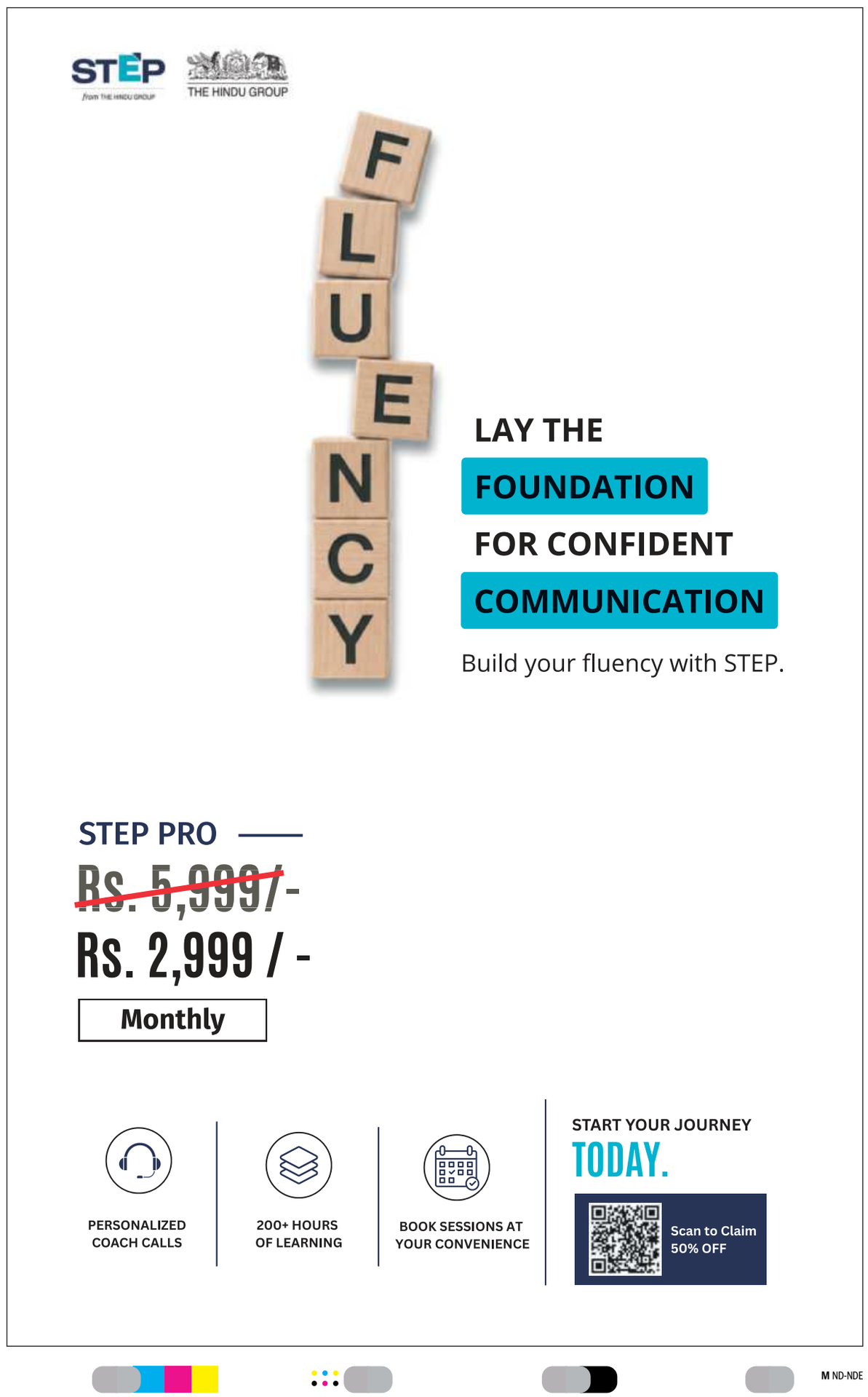
"The business currently generates an estimated ₹5-6 crore in annual revenue, with revenue potentially reaching ₹10 crore at most," he said. "The volumes, once they start coming, will get better, but it is a thing for the future," he added.

PERSONAL DATA

In a natural progression to this, CAMS also launched ConsenPro, a tech product for DPDP compliance. Built entirely in-house, the platform is designed to help companies discover where personal data is stored, map data flows and manage consent, including processes for withdrawing consent and purging data where required.

The CFO said CAMS is treating its newer businesses as a portfolio of opportunities, rather than expecting every segment to become profitable immediately, he said, noting that CAMS was investing ahead of demand to avoid being left behind when adoption picks up.

The broader strategy is to reduce dependence on the mutual fund RTA business without compromising its established profitability, he said.



QUICKLY.

Sharad Mathur appointed MD of IndusInd Insurance



New Delhi: IndusInd General Insurance Company Ltd, part of IndusInd International Holdings Ltd Group, on Tuesday announced the appointment of Sharad Mathur as its Managing Director & CEO, following statutory approvals. Mathur previously served as MD & CEO of Universal Sompo General Insurance for over six years. PTI

Cognizant expands tie-up with Google Cloud

Chennai: IT major Cognizant has expanded its partnership with Google Cloud to accelerate the adoption of agentic AI with a new Gemini Frontier Capability Group. The partnership comes at a time when Cognizant is also applying Gemini internally at scale. OUR BUREAU

China imposes export controls on tunnelling, high-altitude machinery

EQUIPMENT HURDLES. Exports to India likely to be affected as Beijing says measures apply to 'sensitive countries'

Ananth Krishnan
Beijing



CUSTOMS ORDEALS. India has previously raised with China the delays in clearance for tunnel-boring machines, which are used for critical projects including metro rail networks PTI

China on Monday said it would introduce export controls, starting November 18, on tunnel-boring machines and other heavy machinery used in high-altitude terrain "to better safeguard national security and interests".

Announcing measures that will likely impact exports to India, the Ministry of Commerce said "those exporting the aforementioned items to sensitive countries and regions in dispute with China shall apply for a licence", while exports to other countries will require prior registration to obtain certificates.

The announcement listed tunnel-boring machines (TBMs) as well heavy machinery used in construction in high-altitude and mountainous terrain, such as walking excavators and plateau-type wet shotcrete machines "used in altitudes above 3,000 metres".

China's Ministry of Commerce said the items covered by these measures "have clear dual-use (civilian and military) characteristics". "The measures are intended to better safeguard national security and interests, while also enabling China to better fulfil its international obligations, including those related to non-proliferation," the announcement said, adding that China had "notified the relevant countries and regions with which it has established export-control dialogue mechanisms".

AREAS OF USE

India has previously raised with China the delays in customs clearance for imports of TBMs, which are used in India for several critical projects including the construction of metro rail networks in cities, railway corridors and key tunnelling projects including in border areas.

India is dependent on imports for the machines. Difficulties in imports from China started in 2024. In October of that year, Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal had publicly raised the issue with visiting German Vice Chancellor Robert Habeck, pointing out that China was blocking the export of TBMs made by a German company in China.

On Monday, China also announced export control measures related to certain types of drones. The controlled items include "autopilots specially designed for unmanned aerial vehicles (UAVs); UAVs or unmanned airships with a maximum endurance of three hours or more; certain engines specially designed for UAVs or unmanned airships; and UAVs with a range of 300 kilometres or more" among other items.

The latest announcements followed Beijing on October 16 unveiling a sweeping draft plan to restrict exports of more than 40 cutting-edge technologies, including solar manufacturing technologies, some AI models, and certain biotech platforms.

A number of technologies related to the manufacture of solar cells have been listed for either a complete export ban or restricted exports. While the draft plan does not restrict most solar exports, the new controls on next-generation solar manufacturing technologies could impact efforts by countries including India to reduce dependence on China as they look to move up the solar manufacturing chain.

Strait of Hormuz could be 'redundant' in 5 years, says HSBC CEO Elhedery

Reuters
Dubai



Georges Elhedery

Investment in alternative logistics routes in the Gulf to mitigate the impact of the Iran war could make the Strait of Hormuz "redundant" in the next five years, HSBC Group Chief Executive Georges Elhedery said on Tuesday.

The conflict has highlighted the world's heavy reliance on the strategic waterway, through which a fifth of global oil and liquefied natural gas trade previously passed.

It is forcing Gulf nations to channel resources towards the development of energy pipelines to ports, investments that Elhedery said will allow the region to weather the fallout from the conflict.

INVESTMENTS

"We do see this region being able to recover and then continue growing. It will mean a lot of investment," the bank CEO said during the HSBC Future Forum event in Dubai.

"Of course, we do wish and hope to see a resolution to the conflict... But Hormuz, probably in five years' time, may become redundant," he added.

West Asia, North Africa and Turkey are offering $872 billion in individual project packages, part of a wider $1.4 trillion planned and unawarded infrastructure pipeline, HSBC said in a report on Monday citing data from MEED, a Dubai-based construction industry market intelligence platform.

Curefoods pilots MegaBite in Bengaluru to tap budget food delivery market

Jyoti Banthia
Bengaluru



Cloud kitchen operator Curefoods has begun piloting MegaBite, a new delivery service in Bengaluru, as it looks to tap the budget-conscious consumer segment with dishes priced between ₹49 and ₹199.

Currently operational in Bengaluru's HSR Layout, MegaBite offers food from brands across Curefoods' portfolio, including Rolls On Wheels, Olio Pizza, Krispy Kreme, Eatfit and Arambam. The platform is offering zero delivery charges and no platform fee as it seeks to position itself around affordability and value.

The pilot comes amid intensifying competition in the budget food delivery segment, with new and existing players experimenting with lower prices and alternative commission structures to attract consumers and restaurant partners.

Curefoods is positioning MegaBite as a service built for value-conscious, digitally savvy consumers, as food delivery platforms look to widen their reach beyond customers willing to pay a premium for convenience.

The move also comes as competitors explore different models to make food ordering more affordable. Rapido-backed Ownly is seeking to differentiate itself through a zero-commission model for restaurants, while Flipkart has been exploring food delivery with lower commissions. Such offerings could put pressure on established food delivery platforms to reassess their pricing and restaurant-partner economics.

CUSTOMER BASE

For Curefoods, MegaBite offers a way to leverage its existing portfolio of food brands to serve a wider price-conscious customer base. However, the pilot's performance and the company's plans for expansion beyond HSR Layout remain unclear.

Curefoods, which operates a portfolio of cloud kitchen and food brands, has raised around $150 million in funding, with investors including Accel and Three State Ventures.

The company had also secured regulatory approval for an initial public offering (IPO) comprising a fresh issue of around ₹800 crore and an offer for sale (OFS) of 4.85 crore equity shares. However, Curefoods has since put its IPO plans on hold.

The MegaBite pilot marks a fresh consumer-facing initiative for the company as it explores opportunities in a segment where affordability, delivery costs and restaurant commissions are becoming increasingly important to competition.

As demand increases, CloudPhotonix targets revenue of ₹100 crore by FY28

S Ronendra Singh
New Delhi



Tarun Sibal, Co-Founder & CEO, CloudPhotonix

With the rising demand for high-bandwidth, low-latency and power-efficient optical connectivity driven by artificial intelligence (AI), Noida-based CloudPhotonix is targeting revenue of ₹100 crore by financial year 2028 (FY28), a top official has said.

CloudPhotonix is an Indian photonics technology company, developing high-speed optical connectivity solutions for AI infrastructure, hyperscale data centres and telecom networks, with a portfolio spanning 1G-800G optical transceivers.

Started just two-and-a-half years ago, the company has invested around ₹40 crore till now, and is expected to close the current financial year with revenue of ₹25 crore.

ON TRACK

"We are on track this year to do about ₹25 crore in revenue. We are only two-and-a-half years old company and we have achieved operating break-even already. We want to be at least a ₹100 crore company by FY28... The growth has been quite phenomenal," Tarun Sibal, Co-Founder and Chief Executive Officer, CloudPhotonix told *businessline*.

He said photonics are extremely critical tech because it has a chip and is a class one laser product, and there are a very few companies making this component in the country right now. Most of the photonics makers are either based in China or Malaysia or Taiwan or Vietnam, Sibal explained.

"Our customers include companies like Tejas Network, Reliance Jio, CtrlS, and Internet service providers... They don't make the transceivers, they go to original equipment manufacturers like us to get the transceivers made to their specs. But, in India, we are the first to actually put in a physical unit to actually start manufacturing," he noted.

DATA CENTRE DEMAND

The Indian photonics market is expected to grow fourfold to around $10 billion by 2031 from $2.5 billion right now, driven by demand from data centres, cloud, Internet of things and other electronics devices requiring high data speed, the India Photonics Association (IPA) said recently.

According to the IPA, the country can be self-reliant in photonics technology if all efforts from industry and government are made in time.

EU carmakers to get relief from 2035 emissions rules

Bloomberg

Europe's carmakers are moving closer to winning respite from an effective ban on combustion engines from 2035 after key groups in the European Parliament struck a deal to ease emissions rules for the sector.

Lawmakers from the centre-right European People's Party, the centre-left Socialists and the liberal Renew group reached an accord under which carmakers including BMW, Stellantis and Volkswagen would only have to cut emissions by 87.5 per cent by 2035, with a further 7.5 per cent offset through the use of green steel, according to a document seen by *Bloomberg*.

EPP, S&D and Renew groups didn't respond to requests for comment. The deal closely resembles an agreement reached between France and Germany last week, which sought a 90 per cent emissions reduction.

The changes would end a requirement for cars sold from 2035 to be climate neutral, allowing combustion-engine vehicles to remain on the market beyond the cut-off.

Nscale, Anthropic in talks for $45 b AI deal

Bloomberg



Nscale Ltd, the AI cloud computing firm, is in talks to sell computing power to Anthropic PBC in a deal that could be worth about $45 billion, according to sources.

The Nvidia Corp-backed data centre developer is seeking a second major deal with the firm behind Claude for a second facility at its Monarch data centre campus in West Virginia, they said.

Anthropic has agreements in place with Nscale for infrastructure that's worth as much as $44.6 billion, according to a regulatory filing for Nscale's planned initial public offering. The second Monarch building would deliver 460 megawatts of computing power, using Nvidia's advanced Vera Rubin AI chips, some of the people said.

Anthropic also has the right of first refusal on Monarch's expected third building, they said.

A deal could be finalised soon, sources said. Deliberations are ongoing, details of the plan could change and no final decisions have been made, they said. Representatives for Anthropic and Nscale declined to comment.

NSCALE IPO

Nscale is targeting an IPO that would value the company at $30 billion, but its prospects have been undermined recently by delays to building its data centres and Microsoft withdrawing from a UK project.

A cohort of investors urged the firm to lower its IPO valuation target to between $16 billion and $19 billion, *Bloomberg News* has reported. Nscale's challenges have been less about finding customers than executing on its contracts, from lining up power supplies to securing money for equipment purchases. In the latest Anthropic deal, Nscale would still need to secure financing to fund the supply of AI chips.

Anthropic, which is one of Nscale's biggest customers, has emerged as a major client for data centre providers.

Deals it has inked include a $50 billion pact with Fluidstack Ltd, $10 billion with infrastructure startup Volta Infrastructure Holdings Ltd and $45 billion with Elon Musk's SpaceX.

Chinese firms order AI chips worth $35 billion; Nvidia unsure of delivery

Reuters



Nvidia CEO Jensen Huang

ByteDance, Alibaba and Tencent have ordered more than 3 million of Nvidia's new RTX PRO 5500 graphics cards with a collective sticker price of over $35 billion, two people familiar with the matter said, in a rush for a less powerful but export-compliant chip amid US restrictions on trade with China.

US-based chipmaker Nvidia has told customers and partners it cannot guarantee that it can fill the orders because demand from Chinese technology companies far exceeds planned production, the two sources and a third person familiar with the matter said.

The RTX PRO 5500 is a workstation chip, designed for powerful professional computers rather than the large data-centre clusters that use Nvidia's most advanced AI processors. But it is among the most powerful Nvidia chips that are still available to Chinese buyers.

TRADE CONTROLS

Nvidia's Blackwell-based B300 data-centre chip is not allowed to be sold to Chinese buyers under US export controls, while exports of its Hopper-based H200 are reviewed on a case-by-case basis and are subject to licensing conditions.

One source said Nvidia told partners they might receive only 5 per cent to 10 per cent of the quantities requested. Another said the company had indicated it could produce no more than 3 million RTX PRO 5500 cards globally in 2027. Total orders from customers in China have exceeded 6 million, two of the sources said.

The three Chinese tech giants' orders are for cards priced at about $11,400 each, two of the sources said, giving them a potential combined value of more than $35 billion.

The scale of the orders, which have not been previously reported, underscores the ongoing appetite among Chinese companies for Nvidia hardware despite the US curbs.

Nvidia Chief Executive Jensen Huang has said the restrictions reduced Nvidia's share of China's AI data-centre chip market from a near monopoly to effectively nothing.

Huawei, in particular, has gained market share, though Chinese chipmakers have generally struggled to match leading American products, partly due to separate restrictions on foreign equipment to make the most advanced semiconductors.

Chinese companies are seeking to use the cards primarily for AI inference, or running trained models to generate chatbot responses, the three sources said. Inference generally requires less computing power than training models on massive datasets.

Tonbo Imaging takes battlefield technology to civilian applications

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

From countering Pakistan's drone offensive during India's Operation Sindoor to detecting pedestrians and cattle on dark highways and elephants along Assam's railway corridors, military-grade imaging technology is finding potential civilian applications.

Bengaluru-based Tonbo Imaging is looking to adapt its battlefield surveillance and targeting expertise for advanced driver assistance systems (ADAS) and railway safety, opening new opportunities ahead of its ₹852 crore IPO on October 15.

Tonbo's MGS-23 equips conventional anti-aircraft guns with thermal imaging and targeting capabilities, while it develops WaveStrike high-power microwave technology to turn off drone swarms by disrupting their electronics. Asked about Operation Sindoor, a source familiar with Tonbo's defence programmes declined to share operational details, citing strict military non-disclosure agreements, but said its technologies had been deployed across multiple military theatres and demonstrated operational readiness under battlefield conditions.

"We don't make the weapon; we make the eyes and the brains of the weapon," the source said.

MISSILE SEEKERS

India's modernisation of the Su-30MKI fighter aircraft offers a potential market for Tonbo's electro-optical and infrared technologies.

Such systems help aircraft detect, identify and track targets in poor visibility, integrating with targeting pods and missile guidance systems to improve precision strikes.



Tonbo Imaging's thermal vision technology is now being piloted for railway and automotive safety in India

Tonbo has supplied seeker-related technology for missile programmes involving Bharat Dynamics, although it has not disclosed a direct Su-30MKI integration contract.

Tonbo Imaging develops electro-optical sights, driver-vision systems and thermal imaging payloads for precision targeting on military platforms built by partners including Larsen & Toubro (L&T) and DRDO.

The Arjun Mk1A tank features a remote-controlled weapon station for its 12.7-mm machine gun, while Tonbo separately markets compact thermal weapon sights for rifles and sniper systems under its proprietary 'Arjun' brand.

Sources expect missile seekers to become a significant revenue driver around FY29, followed by high-power microwave systems during FY29-30. WaveStrike remains at the prototype stage.

CIVILIAN ROADS

The same ability to identify heat signatures and track moving targets could help vehicles detect hazards beyond headlights.

"An elephant is one big thermal signature," the source said, explaining that thermal imaging could alert locomotive drivers to animals crossing railway tracks, particularly along Assam's wildlife corridors, where Tonbo is in an advanced pilot project with Indian Railways, according to sources familiar with the development.

Tonbo is exploring railway safety systems that combine thermal imaging, electro-optical sensors, and radar, alongside ADAS applications for passenger cars, commercial trucks, and mining equipment.

"The shortest-term opportunity in automotive or transportation in India is in the heavy-vehicle sector," the source said.

"We understood two domains very well. We understood defence and we understood autonomous vehicles," the source added.

REVENUE AND IPO

Tonbo has a signed order book of approximately ₹290 crore, excluding defence programmes undergoing qualification and commercial negotiations, according to people familiar with its operations.

People familiar with its growth plans said revenue could cross ₹550 crore in FY27 and approach ₹1,000 crore in FY28, up from FY26 turnover of ₹362.65 crore. These estimates are not formal company guidance.

The ₹852-crore IPO is entirely an offer for sale, allowing early investors, including Celesta Capital and Edelweiss, to exit without raising fresh capital for Tonbo.

Investors including SBI Mutual Fund, Amansa, ValueQuest, 360 ONE and HDFC Life participated in pre-IPO transactions worth approximately ₹400 crore, according to people familiar with the deals.

"Let us deliver on this business," the source said, suggesting fresh fundraising could follow as revenue scales.

DELHI
businessline.
WEDNESDAY - OCTOBER 21 - 2026

QUICKLY.

Copper range-bound over US tariff uncertainty



London: Copper prices were little changed on Tuesday as uncertainty over potential US import tariffs and concerns about inflation driven by higher oil prices kept risk sentiment subdued. Benchmark three-month copper on the London Metal Exchange was up 0.1 per cent at $14,355 a tonne. Copper has risen 55 per cent since Donald Trump returned to the US presidency in January 2025.
Aluminium fell 0.7 per cent to $2,996 and zinc lost 0.6 per cent to $3,693. Tin gained 0.2 per cent to $50,950. REUTERS

Arabica coffee eases from 1-month high



Paris: Arabica coffee futures on ICE fell as top grower Brazil's currency eased. Sugar edged up after a one-week low, while cocoa ticked down. Arabica coffee was down 0.5 per cent at $3.141 per lb. ICE-certified stocks on Monday were at 239,852 bags, not far off last month's 27-year-low of 217,646 bags. Robusta coffee was down 0.3 per cent at $3,470 a tonne. Top robusta grower Vietnam's coffee output is likely to remain steady in the 2026/27 season. Raw sugar was up 0.3 per cent at 20.63 cents/lb, while white sugar added 0.3 per cent to $548.20 a tonne. London cocoa was down 0.4 per cent at £4,361 a tonne. New York cocoa inched down 0.2 per cent to $5,773. REUTERS

Gold ETF inflows continue to be positive for 13th week in a row

KEY SUPPORT. Investors find the metal's current level below $4,200/oz attractive

Subramani Ra Mancombu
Chennai



THE TOPPERS. Investors in Asia have brought $18.38 b, followed by those in Europe ($17.62 b).

Investments in physically backed gold exchange-traded funds (ETFs) were net positive last week, with investors in the US and China finding value in the yellow metal, data from the World Gold Council (WGC) showed. It was for the 13th consecutive week that inflows were positive.

According to data, inflows into gold ETFs were $2.3 billion, while $479 million were redeemed, leaving investments net positive at $1.91 billion.

Experts said investors see value in the precious metal, with prices hovering below $4,200 an ounce. It seems to have a floor at $4,000, they said.

REMAINS VOLATILE
On Tuesday, gold was quoted at $4,125 an ounce, down over 4 per cent month-on-month and nearly 0.5 per cent in the past week.

Darshan Desai, CEO, Aspect Bullion & Refinery, said that gold remains volatile, with prices recovering some ground. "US inflation, interest-rate expectations, and the dollar and bond yields continue to shape market sentiment, while geopolitical developments add to the uncertainty," he said.

"Gold held in a tight range last week. Hot US inflation data, with CPI at 3.7 per cent and PPI at 6.3 per cent, kept the December Fed hike odds near 90 per cent and 10-year yields above 5.1 per cent, capping gold's upside," said Renisha Chainani, Chief Research Officer at Augmont.

CHINESE INFLOWS
Investors in the US chose to invest nearly $1 billion last week, while Chinese investors brought in $498 million.

Attracting inflows (in $b)

Total/ regions	Inflows/ outflows (-) as Jan 1-Oct 16	Inflows/ outflows (-) as Jan 1-Oct 9
North America	5.13	4.12
Europe	17.62	17.37
Asia	18.38	17.73
Others	0.60	0.60
Total global inflows	**131.90**	**129.52**
Total global outflows	**90.17**	**89.69**

Source: WGC

Inflows in the UK, which have consistently been positive, were $237 million, while they were $141.8 in Japan. On the other hand, French investors chose to exit, encashing $44 million.

Year-to-date, Asian and Chinese investments in ETFs have topped. Investors in Asia have so far brought in $18.38 billion, followed by those in Europe at $17.62 billion).

Country-wise, inflows into ETFs in China have topped $10 billion at $10.41 billion. Investments in the UK were $9.8 billion, followed by those in the US at $5.22.

Indian inflows were the fourth-largest at $4.7 billion, though weekly updates are not available.

Inflows in Switzerland ($3.56 billion), Germany ($2.42 billion), France ($1.77 billion) and Japan ($1.06 billion) were also significant.

KEY SUPPORT
"In the week ahead, volatility is likely to persist as markets track US economic data, Federal Reserve signals and currency movements. A weaker dollar and easing yields could support prices, while concerns over inflation and higher interest rates may trigger further corrections," said Desai.

"Gold's key support sits at $3,950-4,200 (₹1,45,500-₹1,51,000). Festive and central-bank demand should keep dip-buying alive heading into Dhanteras," said Prithviraj Kothari, Managing Director at RiddiSiddhi Bullions Ltd and President of the India Bullion and Jewellers Association Ltd.

Chainani said that this week, US housing data, jobless claims and flash Purchasing Managers' Index, along with Fed commentary ahead of the October 28 decision and crude oil prices, will be the key to the precious metal's fortunes.

DOWN 25% FROM PEAK
Gold rallied between 2024 and January 2026 on hopes of US Fed rate cuts, geopolitical tensions and the trade war between the US and its other global partners.

After soaring to a record high of $5,608 an ounce, the yellow metal has shed over 25 per cent of its gains after the Iran war broke out on February 28.

Fears of inflation, investors switching to crude oil from precious metals, pessimism over global economy and rising bond yields have dragged gold to its current level.

SOPA estimates 2% lower soy output despite 5% rise in area

Vishwanath Kulkarni
Bengaluru

India's soyabean production for the 2026 kharif season is estimated to decline 2.11 per cent to 107.93 lakh tonnes despite a five per cent increase in the area, as drought in Maharashtra and Karnataka offset a strong recovery in Madhya Pradesh and Rajasthan on higher yields.

The Soyabean Processors Association of India (SOPA), which released its first crop estimates at the International Soya Conclave 2026 in Indore on Saturday, pegged production at 107.93 lakh tonnes (lt), down 2.33 lt from 110.25 lt last year.

AREA UP, OUTPUT DIPS
SOPA estimated the sown area at 117.73 lakh hectares, up 5 per cent, while the harvested area is projected at 109.98 lakh hectares. The sown area estimate is lower than the Agriculture Ministry's estimate of 123.16 lakh hectares.

"Production is estimated at 107.93 lt, about 2.33 lakh tonnes (2.11 per cent) below kharif 2025 production, despite a five per cent larger sown area.

The strong gains in Madhya Pradesh and Rajasthan are outweighed by sharp losses in Maharashtra, Karnataka and Telangana," said DN Pathak, Executive Director, SOPA.

MP, RAJASTHAN LEAD
The shortfall stems from crop failure across 7.02 lakh hectares and poor grain filling due to prolonged moisture stress, he said.

The average yield is projected at 981 kg per hectare, marginally lower than 983 kg last year. Madhya Pradesh, which recorded a strong recovery, is estimated to produce 57.2 lt — up 32 per cent from 43.2 lt last year.

The rebound helped the State regain its position as the country's largest soybean producer, SOPA said. Rajasthan's output is projected to rise 48 per cent to 9.5 lt.

Production in Gujarat is estimated to remain unchanged at 2.4 lt, while output in other States is projected to increase marginally to 1.3 lt from 1.1 lt.

Deficient rainfall, prolonged dry spells and moisture stress are expected to drag Maharashtra's production down 33 per cent to 34.9 lt from 52.2 lt last year.

Karnataka's output is projected to fall 44 per cent to 2.1 lt from 3.7 lt, while Telangana is expected to see a 46 per cent decline to 0.7 lt from 1.3 lt, SOPA said.

SOWING AGAINST ODDS



WATER WOES. Farmers spread paddy seeds on a freshly tilled field in Nagapattinam district of Tamil Nadu. 'Samba' cultivation has begun across the Cauvery delta region despite concerns over water availability. The onset of the North-East Monsoon last week has brought good rainfall to the State. However, seven of Tamil Nadu's nine reservoirs have storage levels below 25 per cent of capacity, according to the Central Water Commission, with the Aliyar dam empty VENGADESH R

IMD forecasts isolated very heavy rain in Tamil Nadu, Puducherry for two more days

Vinson Kurian
Thiruvananthapuram



RAIN ALERT. Heavy cloud banks developed off the south Andhra Pradesh coast, south-east Tamil Nadu and southern parts of the Bay of Bengal

Isolated very heavy rainfall is forecast over Tamil Nadu, Puducherry and Karaikal on Wednesday and Thursday, as the India Meteorological Department (IMD) watches the possible formation of two low-pressure areas at opposite ends of the Bay of Bengal, one of which could likely intensify into a tropical cyclone.

The first 'low' is expected to form over the south-west Bay and the adjoining Tamil Nadu coast on Wednesday, as a cyclonic circulation descends to the lower atmospheric levels.

ANDAMAN SEA SYSTEM
The European Centre for Medium-Range Weather Forecasts (ECMWF) earlier suggested that the system could instead form over the south-east Arabian Sea. The second system is expected to emerge from an incoming circulation over the Gulf of Thailand and adjoining parts of Thailand and Myanmar.

Moving into the north Andaman Sea by Wednesday, it is forecast to travel west-north-west and form a 'low' over the south-east and adjoining east-central Bay by Friday. It could then turn north-westwards towards the Andhra Pradesh coast and intensify further.

The IMD's numerical projections indicate the possibility of its rapid intensification over the warm waters into a tropical cyclone, although it is yet to take an official call. Global model forecasts, including those of the ECMWF, broadly support this scenario against the backdrop of an active North-East monsoon, a passing helpful Madden-Julian Oscillation (MJO) wave over the Indian Ocean and a developing positive Indian Ocean Dipole (IOD) phase.

The IMD expects heavy rain to persist across much of the southern peninsula over the coming days. Kerala and Mahe are likely to receive isolated heavy rainfall for six days, Tamil Nadu, Puducherry and Karaikal for four days from Friday, and south interior Karnataka for four days from Wednesday. Lakshadweep is likely to see heavy rain for five days from Thursday, and coastal Karnataka on Saturday. Coastal Andhra Pradesh, Yanam and Rayalaseema are also forecast to receive heavy rain on Wednesday.

'Centre's price correction of ethanol from maize may help balance the distortion'

Prabhudatta Mishra
New Delhi

Grain-based distilleries have criticised the ₹3 a litre cut in the procurement price of maize-based ethanol, while the sugar industry welcomed the government's decision to restrict ethanol made from sugarcane juice/syrup and B-heavy molasses (BHM), but cautioned against preferential treatment for dedicated ethanol plants.

For the first time since the ethanol blending programme was launched, oil marketing companies (OMCs) have cut the procurement price of maize-based ethanol. The price, initially low in the 2022-23 Ethanol Supply Year (ESY), was raised before the latest reduction.

For the 2026-27 ESY, procurement prices for ethanol made from C-heavy molasses and damaged foodgrains (broken rice) have been retained at ₹57.97 and ₹64 a litre, respectively, unchanged from 2025-26.

Ethanol purchase rates on feedstock used (₹/litre)

Feedstock	2025-26	2026-27
Sugarcane juice/syrup	65.61	NA
B-Heavy Molasses	60.73	NA
C-Heavy Molasses	57.97	57.97
FCI Rice	58.50	60.32
Maize	71.86	68.86
Broken rice (DFG)	64.00	64.00

The price of ethanol made from rice supplied by the Food Corporation of India, however, has been raised by ₹1.82.

As in 2023-24, the government has not announced procurement prices for ethanol made from sugarcane juice/syrup and B-heavy molasses (BHM), as the OMCs will not procure ethanol produced from these feedstocks in 2026-27.

The OMCs have floated the first round of tenders for the 2026-27 ESY (November-October), seeking 1,100 crore litres of ethanol from various feedstocks.

MAIZE PRICE CUT
Industry sources said grain-based distilleries had opposed Nafed's assured MSP programme for maize, as they were unwilling to pay the MSP when market prices were lower.

Maize-based ethanol prices are linked to prevailing maize prices, factoring in average recovery rates, making a price cut inevitable when feedstock costs fall, the sources said. Sugar mills, however, must pay farmers at least the fair and remunerative price (FRP), which is revised annually.

"A balanced ethanol policy must support viable production from both maize and rice, with procurement prices reflecting their respective cost structures and allocations, offering producers greater certainty. Cutting the maize incentive while the lower-priced rice-based supplies remain available could undermine the viability of maize-based ethanol production and the market it creates for farmers." CK Jain, President of the Grain Ethanol Manufacturers Association (GEMA), said in a statement.

The Indian Sugar & Bio-Energy Manufacturers Association (ISMA) has sought an increase in the procurement price of C-heavy molasses-based ethanol to ₹62.23 a litre.

Deepak Ballani, Director-General of ISMA, said preferential allocation to dedicated ethanol plants holding long-term offtake agreements could hurt the sugar industry, if continued.

SEA, Solidaridad propose measures to empower women farmers

Our Bureau
Mangaluru

The Solvent Extractors' Association of India (SEA) and Solidaridad have proposed four measures to improve women farmers' access to formal markets, boost price realisation and strengthen financial inclusion across vegetable oil value chains.

The recommendations emerged from a multi-stakeholder consultation in Bhopal on 'Scaling Gender-Inclusive Regenerative Vegetable Oil Value Chains: A Policy Roadmap'.

The discussion highlighted the need to translate women's contributions to agriculture into greater economic recognition, control over income and participation in formal supply chains.



FOUR KEY AREAS
The consultation identified four measures for policymakers and industry stakeholders.

The first calls for defined procurement targets for produce sourced directly from women farmers to improve their access to organised markets, corporate sourcing networks and formal supply chains.

The second proposes preferential pricing or premium for produce supplied by women farmers, recognising their contribution to sustainable farming and encouraging participation in regenerative agriculture programmes.

The third recommends payment mechanisms that strengthen women's financial inclusion and control over agricultural earnings. Where appropriate, joint bank accounts may be encouraged with the informed consent of account holders.

The fourth calls on companies to allocate at least 10 per cent of their corporate social responsibility budgets to integrating women farmers into supply chains through capacity building, regenerative agriculture, market linkages and access to technology.

Dhanuka Agritech launches herbicide for maize, sugarcane crops

Our Bureau
Mangaluru

Dhanuka Agritech Ltd, an agri-input company, has introduced Tembotrax, an early post-emergence herbicide containing 'Tembotrione 34.4% SC', for weed management in maize and sugarcane cultivation across key agricultural regions of the country.

A media statement said Tembotrax is a systemic HPPD-inhibiting herbicide that disrupts carotenoid biosynthesis, causing visible bleaching of susceptible weeds while offering crop selectivity in maize and sugarcane when used as recommended.

Tembotrax offers broad-spectrum weed control against both narrow-leaf and broadleaf weeds through a single spray application, helping farmers manage weed competition in maize and sugarcane cultivation, it said.

KEY CHALLENGE
Quoting Rahul Dhanuka, MD, Dhanuka Agritech Ltd, the statement said: "Early-stage weed competition is a key challenge in maize and sugarcane cultivation as it can affect crop growth and farmers' productivity. Tembotrax helps control weeds during the critical early stages of crop growth, supporting effective weed management and helping farmers protect their crop potential."

'IEA ready to release more oil stocks if needed'

Reuters
London

The International Energy Agency (IEA) is ready to go if a further release of oil from members' emergency oil reserves is needed, the agency's top official said on Tuesday.

The IEA decided last week to accelerate the release of oil remaining from a record emergency reserves release pledged in March, including more than 20 million barrels of diesel as soon as possible to boost supply and cool soaring prices.

"If it is needed ... and if our countries consider it's time to push the button, as the International Energy Agency, we are ready to go," IEA Executive Director Fatih Birol said at a conference in London.

Aluminium futures: Go short on rally to ₹332

Akhil Nallamuthu
bl. research bureau

Aluminium futures (₹327/kg) have been falling over the past month.

While there has been a recovery in price in the last few sessions, the broader downtrend remains intact.

COMMODITY CALL.

The November contract started to decline on the back of the resistance at ₹355 in early September. It slipped to a low of ₹314.6 last week and has now recovered to ₹327.

From the current level, aluminium futures are likely to see an uptick in price, possibly to ₹332. But then, the bears are likely to regain traction, potentially leading to a resumption in downtrend.

The nearest support from the current level is the price band of ₹300-305.

On the other hand, if the contract rises past ₹332, the near-term outlook could turn positive. In this scenario, the contract could rally to ₹344, a resistance. The subsequent barrier is at ₹350.

Overall, the outlook remains bearish, and participants can consider short positions on a rally.

TRADE STRATEGY
Short aluminium (November) futures if the price rises to ₹332. Place the stop-loss at ₹340. When the price slips to ₹314 after the trade is initiated, tighten the stop-loss to ₹322. Book profits at ₹305.

QUICKLY.

3-day aerial show starts tomorrow; PM to attend

Varanasi: The Indian Air Force will conduct a series of aerial displays at the iconic Namo Ghat here on October 22, 24 and 25, showcasing its combat capabilities, technological prowess and flying skills under the 'Wings Over Ganges' theme, officials said. Prime Minister Narendra Modi will attend the programme on October 25, they said. Titled 'Indian Air Force Aerial Display 2026', the event will highlight the force's rich heritage, modern air power and commitment to national security. According to IAF officials, a total of 100 aircraft will participate in the event, including 52 fighter aircraft, 15 transport aircraft and 32 helicopters. The IAF's Suryakiran aerobatic team will be among the major attractions, performing manoeuvres over the Ganga. A formation involving nine Hawk aircraft following a C-17 Globemaster-led flight will precede the Suryakiran team's display, officials said. PTI

'Connectivity must respect nations, territories'

ENDURING TIES. Defence Minister Rajnath Singh said the SCO must be true to the principles of sovereign equality, consensus and mutual respect

Our Bureau
New Delhi

Connectivity projects must rely on mutual consultation and commitment to the sovereignty and territorial integrity of every nation to be sustainable, Defence Minister Rajnath Singh said in his address at the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) meeting in Dushanbe on Tuesday.

Singh stated that India supports consensus led initiatives that link markets, facilitate trade and create new avenues for development. In that context, he cited the International North-South Transport Corridor and Chabahar Port as initiatives that could contribute significantly to connecting Central Asia with broader markets. He was speaking at the 25th Meeting of the Council of Heads of Government (CHG) of SCO in the Tajikistan capital city. The CHG members include China, Russia, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Uzbekistan, India, Pakistan, Iran and Belarus.



DRAWING LINES. Defence Minister Rajnath Singh at the 25th meeting of Council of Heads of Government of SCO in Dushanbe ANI

BUILDING CONSENSUS

The Union Minister also emphasised on the need for the SCO to build consensus and translate it into concrete action to address the uncertain global economic environment marked by geopolitical tensions, disruptions to trade and supply chains, concerns over energy and food security and emerging technological divides.

Underscoring India's belief that economic engagement should be inclusive and mutually beneficial for all SCO member states, he stated, "India believes that the SCO must remain efficient and steadfast in its adherence to the principles of sovereign equality, consensus, and mutual respect. A greater number of institutions does not necessarily translate into greater achievements. New mechanisms should focus on clearly identified needs, avoid duplication and prioritise delivering practical value to Member States," he said.

RESILIENT SUPPLY

There is a need to strengthen resilient supply chains, facilitate trade and investment and leverage technology to drive development, he said. He reaffirmed India's support for the adoption of an Action Plan for the Multilateral Trade and Economic Cooperation Programme for the period 2026-2030.

He also called upon the member states of the SCO to make concerted efforts to dismantle the entire ecosystem of terrorism, describing the menace as one of the gravest threats to peace and development.

'NO SAFE HAVENS'

"Terrorism results in the loss of innocent lives and disrupts investment and commerce. It radicalises societies and deprives youth of the opportunities they rightfully deserve. There can be no justification for terrorism, no double standards in addressing it and no place for those who finance, support, or provide safe havens to terrorists," said the Minister.

Singh recalled the deliberations at the SCO Summit in Bishkek in August-September 2026, when Prime Minister Narendra Modi underlined the need for concrete steps by the Organisation on issues related to security, connectivity, and opportunity.

Industries in Gujarat start curtailing power use between 5-11 pm to help govt manage demand

Avinash Nair
Ahmedabad

Industries in parts of Gujarat are curtailing electricity use during the evening peak hours as the State grapples with record power demand, despite having nearly 79.5 GW of installed generation capacity.

The State recorded an all-time high peak demand of 29.82 GW on October 16, up 36.6 per cent from 21.82 GW a year ago. Daily consumption rose 27 per cent year-on-year to 574 million units.

Ajit Shah, President of the Sanand Industries Association, said industries had been advised to avoid using electricity between 5 pm and 11 pm, when solar generation falls, even though demand from industry and agriculture remains high. The advisory does not apply to companies with continuous manufacturing processes, according to information provided by the industry body.



ON THE RISE. Gujarat recorded an all-time high peak electricity demand of 29.82 GW on October 16, up 36.6 per cent from 21.82 GW a year ago REUTERS

The situation highlights the challenge of matching electricity supply with demand at specific times of the day. Of Gujarat's installed capacity, around 53 GW is renewable energy, including 36 GW of solar and 17 GW of wind power.

DEMAND SURGE

The State government attributed the demand surge to high temperatures despite a weak monsoon, agricultural irrigation requirements, festive-season industrial activity and lower hydropower and wind generation. Agricultural demand alone reached around 12 GW a day, the government said.

Chief Minister Bhupendra Patel on Tuesday chaired a high-level meeting with Energy Minister Rushikesh Patel and senior officials to review Gujarat's rising electricity demand and its power supply preparedness, according to an official statement. Gujarat has arranged short-term purchases of 2,990 MW for October, 1,740 MW for November and 1,335 MW for December. It secured 379 MW from NTPC's Farakka plant for November, 500 MW on a long-term basis from Assam's share of Central generation and an additional 500 MW from the Centre's unallocated power pool, according to the State government's review. The Union Coal Ministry has assured daily coal supplies of 10-11 railway rakes until November, rising to 13-14 rakes a day thereafter.

Another measure is to maximise the use of solar electricity during daylight hours by shifting agricultural consumption to periods when solar generation is available.

Battery storage is being pursued as a longer-term solution to the evening supply challenge. Gujarat currently has 192 MW of battery energy storage capacity in operation, while contracts have been finalised for 2,742 MW/5,517 MWh.

A further 500 MW/1,000 MWh is expected to become operational by March 2027, and a tender for another 1,000 MW/4,000 MWh is under process.

ATCs are key to India's goal of growing aviation sector: Rammohan Naidu

Our Bureau
Chennai

As India prepares for an unprecedented expansion in aviation, there is a growing need for air traffic controllers (ATC) and demands on these professionals are coming into sharper focus, Civil Aviation Minister K Rammohan Naidu said on Tuesday.

Naidu was addressing virtually ATCs in Chennai on the occasion of the International Day of Air Traffic Controllers.

The country recorded its highest-ever monthly domestic passenger traffic in May 2026, with more than 1.5 crore passengers in a single month, the Minister said. Every day, India handles more than 5,000 domestic and over 1,000 international air traffic movements, he added.



Civil Aviation Minister K Rammohan Naidu

"India's ambition to grow passenger traffic to 130 crore by 2047 from about 24 crore will place greater responsibility on those managing the skies," he added, emphasising the responsibility of ATCs.

MODERNISATION PUSH

The Airports Authority of India (AAI) has earmarked ₹3,490 crore for modernising infrastructure, including ₹1,532 crore for automation of the air traffic management system.

However, technology alone cannot guarantee safety. Technology can assist, but judgment, composure and responsibility will always be human, he said.

Recognising these pressures, Naidu said the government was committed to the welfare of ATCs. Over 840 additional controller posts had been created in recent years, he said.

Alongside investments in infrastructure and manpower, better airspace management is also helping improve operational efficiency and reduce aviation's environmental footprint.

Flexible use of airspace had generated estimated savings of ₹895 crore and helped reduce carbon dioxide emissions by nearly 1.95 lakh tonnes since August 2020, the Minister said.

TVK govt slashing capex, delaying payments to cut borrowings, says former TN FM

Our Bureau
Chennai

The TVK government, which seeks to project lower borrowings in the first half of this fiscal as an achievement, must explain how the need for such borrowing decreased, Tamil Nadu's former Finance Minister and DMK leader Thangam Thennarasu said on Tuesday.

"How much of the total allocation for capital expenditure in the current financial year has the TVK government actually spent during the April-September period? How much has been invested in new infrastructure projects? Additionally, what is the total amount currently outstanding — payments yet to be released — for projects that were initiated and implemented under the DMK administration? Will the government release these details?" Thennarasu asked in a post on X.



Former TN Finance Minister Thangam Thennarasu

BORROWINGS DOWN

His comments come in response to reports that under the TVK government, Tamil Nadu's borrowings through government bonds had fallen by 21 per cent in the first half of the current fiscal year, compared to the corresponding period last year.

This has been hailed by TVK and its supporters as evidence of improved financial management.

The former Finance Minister said the new State government's borrowing requirement had decreased mainly because of slowing capital expenditure.

"Tenders worth tens of thousands of crores have been cancelled. Due to the failure to carry out development works, roads are in a poor condition and construction projects remain incomplete," he said.

FULL DISCLOSURE

The TVK government must provide full transparency and disclose to the people the details of the capital expenditure actually incurred, as well as the outstanding payments owed for completed works, he said.

Thennarasu also pointed to the rear-loaded nature of the borrowings.

"While the TVK government claims a reduction in borrowing for the first half of the year, it now plans to borrow ₹48,000 crore in the October–December quarter alone," he said.

"Isn't this more than double the ₹23,500 crore raised in the previous quarter?" he asked.

More start-ups moving into AI, deeptech in Jammu & Kashmir as ecosystem diversifies

Gulzar Bhat
Srinagar

Jammu and Kashmir's start-up ecosystem is gradually expanding beyond traditional businesses, with entrepreneurs venturing into artificial intelligence (AI), deeptech, software-as-a-service (SaaS), fintech and health technology.

The emerging areas also include aerospace and defence, renewable energy, green technology and the Internet of Things (IoT).

"It reflects a shift towards technology-driven enterprises in a start-up ecosystem that was earlier dominated by agriculture-related and non-technology ventures," said an official.

The number of start-ups registered on the Startup JK Portal rose from 69 in 2020-21 to 1,414 as of October 15, 2026. More than 200 of the registered ventures are women-led.

Officials also said start-ups from Jammu and Kashmir had secured equity investments from external institutional investors for the first time, marking a new development for the region's entrepreneurial ecosystem. They did not provide details of the investments.

POLICY SUPPORT

The expansion is being supported by the Jammu and Kashmir Startup Policy 2024-27, notified in February 2024, which provides for seed funding, mentoring, incubation and links with industry and national start-up networks. The Jammu and Kashmir Entrepreneurship Development Institute (JKEDI) is the nodal agency for implementing the policy.



Under the scheme, 27 start-ups have been sanctioned seed assistance totalling ₹5.4 crore, with each receiving the first instalment of ₹5 lakh, officials said. Eligible ventures can receive up to ₹20 lakh in four instalments for prototype development, product introduction, market validation and scaling. Another 86 complete applications for 2026-27 are to be considered by the Start-up Screening Committee.

To strengthen the support available to early-stage businesses, grants of ₹50 lakh each have been sanctioned to four incubators at the SKUAST-Kashmir, IIT Jammu, the Islamic University of Science and Technology and the Shri Mata Vaishno Devi University. The centres provide access to technical expertise, laboratories and professional networks. The officials said efforts to identify new entrepreneurs had extended to colleges and districts.

Pay disparity: Why doctors are protesting in Lucknow

Ankita Upadhyay
New Delhi

Young doctors serving under Uttar Pradesh's compulsory government service bond have been protesting in Lucknow for nearly a week, demanding equal pay for those posted at government medical colleges and rural primary and community health centres.

After repeated demonstrations and assurances from the government failed to resolve the issue, the doctors have escalated their agitation to hunger strikes.

The doctors say they have the same medical qualifications and are bound by the same two-year government service obligation, but their monthly remuneration varies significantly depending on their place of posting. They are seeking a government order to ensure salary parity. Simran, an MBBS graduate posted at a primary health centre in Sahaswan in Budaun district, said the latest round of protests began on October 12, following three earlier rounds of demonstrations in Lucknow since August.

Doctors posted at government medical colleges receive around ₹1 lakh to ₹1.25 lakh a month, while those posted at rural PHCs and CHCs earn between ₹50,000 and ₹55,000, according to Simran.

Both groups are subject to a bond penalty of ₹10 lakh if they opt out of the compulsory service.

The agitation began after doctors approached the Directorate General of Medical Education (DGME) and the Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS), seeking an explanation for the disparity. Dr Simran said the two departments initially directed the doctors to approach the other, leaving them uncertain about which authority was responsible for resolving the issue.



AILING SYSTEM. While all doctors go through the two-year government service obligation, their monthly pay varies significantly depending on the place of posting

The doctors subsequently began protesting at the General Post Office (GPO) in Lucknow's Hazratganj.

Dr Simran said Deputy Chief Minister and Health Minister Brajesh Pathak met the protesting doctors on September 2 and assured them that a government order addressing their demand would be issued within 24 hours. However, the communication they received from the Health Department the following day did not constitute the order they were seeking.

According to Dr Raj Kumar, one of the doctors participating in the ongoing protest in Lucknow, they continued to approach officials and stage demonstrations. The protests also led to confrontations with the police. Dr Kumar said doctors were detained repeatedly, including when they attempted to meet the Chief Minister. He said around 70–80 protesters had been detained at one point.

HUNGER STRIKES

Dr Kumar said four doctors had participated in an earlier hunger strike, and one had been hospitalised. At the time of the interview, the group was planning a mass hunger strike at Lucknow's Eco Garden.

Dr Simran said if the demands were not met, 50 more doctors would go on hunger strike. She estimated that around 1,800 doctors posted at PHCs and CHCs were affected by the pay disparity, while around 500 people had participated in one of the demonstrations.

IAF buys indigenously made firefighting robots from Swadeshi Empresa

Our Bureau
New Delhi

With long distance precision guided weapons making installations vulnerable as demonstrated in recent ongoing conflicts, the Indian Air Force (IAF) has equipped itself with firefighting robots (FFRs) for strengthening operational preparedness.

The IAF has procured 80 FF bots from Swadeshi Empresa Pvt Ltd under emergency procurement (EP) and deployed them across establishments.

The bot was tested at "Vayu Shakti 2026" in Pokhran in February, said company officials, adding that the operators were able to control the system from outside the hazard radius.

AMMUNITION SAFETY

The system has successfully undergone DGQA evaluation and certification, they said. The bots can also be used in the case of fire at depots storing arms and ammunition.

At a time when global defence supply chains are facing significant disruptions, the company successfully delivered these 'Made in India' firefighting robots in just 11 months, ahead of the stipulated 12-month timeline, said Ashishek Modi, CMD, Swadeshi Empresa Pvt Ltd.

Developed under the Ministry of Defence's iDEX initiative, the robots were independently procured, inducted and operationally deployed by all the three armed forces, said Modi.

"With growing export inquiries from international markets, this innovation stands as a testament to Atmanirbhar Bharat and India's emerging strength as a global defence technology and manufacturing powerhouse," he remarked.

According to the product profile, the bots have integrated thermal and high-definition optical cameras that enable real-time fire detection, hotspot identification and enhanced situational awareness in smoke-filled environments.

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QUICKLY.

Child safety: Australia to sue Facebook, TikTok

Australia's government is set to sue Facebook, TikTok and other major digital platforms for alleged non-compliance with a nationwide social media ban for under-16s, Communications Minister Anika Wells said. The country's online safety regulator, eSafety Commissioner, said in March it was investigating Facebook, Instagram, TikTok, Snapchat and YouTube for potentially failing to adhere to the law. BLOOMBERG

Qualcomm to cut jobs worldwide from Nov

Qualcomm will cut jobs globally in a "performance-focused reduction" following its annual employee reviews, CEO Cristiano Amon told staff in a memo on Monday reviewed by *Reuters*, with notifications set to begin in November. The cuts are part of an effort to build "a stronger performance culture" and address situations where the company "has consistently fallen short of expectations," Amon said. REUTERS

FSSAI warns nutraceutical makers over labelling violations

CRACKING DOWN. Regulator says manufacturers must declare plant parts used and carry prescribed warnings

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani
New Delhi

The Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) has directed manufacturers of nutraceuticals and health supplements to comply with mandatory labelling requirements and warning statements for products containing plant and botanical extracts.

It has asked manufacturers to review their product labels, warning that violations will attract stringent action, including suspension or cancellation of licences and penalties.

For instance, products containing neem fruit or Gandiva extracts must carry the warning statement, "Not recommended for children below 5 years".

Similarly, products containing papaya leaf or juice must carry the warning, "Not recommended during pregnancy".



STRICT GUIDELINES. The food safety regulator has cautioned that violations could lead to licence suspension/cancellation and penalties

In a recent advisory, the FSSAI said it had observed that several food business operators (FBOs) manufacturing and selling nutraceuticals, health supplements and foods for special dietary use were not complying with mandatory labelling requirements and warning statements prescribed for products containing plant and botanical ingredients.

The Food Safety and Standards (Health Supplements, Nutraceuticals, Food for Special Dietary Use, Food for Special Medical Purpose, Functional Food and Novel Food) Regulations, 2016, specify the permissible limits for plant and botanical ingredients and their extracts, whether used individually or in combination with other ingredients, the regulator said.

The regulations also prescribe stringent labelling requirements and prohibit medicinal claims or suggestions that a product can cure diseases.

TIGHTENING NORMS

The FSSAI said warning statements must be prominent, legible and clear to prevent misuse, particularly among vulnerable groups. The regulations specify warnings for certain plants and extracts based on their known side effects or contraindications. "Considering consumer safety and the prevention of misleading claims, manufacturers of health supplements, nutraceuticals, are hereby directed to ensure mandatory labelling indicating plant part used and immediate compliance with the specific disclaimer or cautionary statement or warnings based on the nature of the ingredient," the advisory said.

It asked health supplements and nutraceutical manufacturers to review their labels and formulations to ensure that their products are in compliance with the regulations. "Failure to comply with these labelling mandates shall render the FBO liable for regulatory action, including suspension or cancellation of licenses and imposition of penalties under the provisions of the Food Safety and Standards Act, 2006," it added.

Cybersecurity talent gap widens as demand outpaces supply

Rohan Das
Chennai

As concerns mount over poor cyber hygiene in Indian organisations, particularly in view of the emerging threat from rogue AI agents, companies are struggling to find skilled cybersecurity professionals to plug vulnerabilities.

Data from staffing firms and job portals point to a widening gap between demand and supply. Despite rising job postings and active recruitment, only a fraction of cybersecurity vacancies are being filled.

Xpheno, a specialist staffing firm that tracks monthly active technology job openings, estimates that fewer than a third of the 6,000-7,000 new cybersecurity openings each month are filled.

"The freshness of the current active cybersecurity openings is under 30%, denoting a fill rate of one-third demand being met every month. A one-third fill rate points at a lower supply of readily available talent for this skillset," said Kamal Karanth, Co-founder of Xpheno. He added that demand was driven by both business expansion and replacement hiring.

TeamLease Digital data show that only 5-6 per cent of companies hiring for cybersecurity roles are able to fill vacancies within a month, even as openings for cybersecurity analysts have grown 10-11 per cent year-on-year.

Neeti Sharma, CEO of TeamLease Digital, said the talent gap was pronounced across sectors, including manufacturing, healthcare, banking, financial services and insurance (BFSI), retail and logistics, as companies invest in cybersecurity while digitising operations.

DEMAND FOR SPECIALISED SKILLS

The challenge is not necessarily a lack of applicants. Job platforms Indeed and Apna have reported an increase of more than 200 per cent in applications.

However, experts said that recruitment had become more selective than during the lockdown and extended work-from-home period, when cybersecurity hiring and talent absorption were at their peak.

"The strongest requirement today is for people who can demonstrate practical knowledge and identify vulnerabilities," said Kartik Narayan, CEO of Apna.

Certifications and familiarity with specialised tools, such as Splunk and Microsoft Sentinel, could help, but recruitment remained challenging because employers increasingly require deeper specialisation, he said.

SECURITY RISKS

The talent gap comes amid warnings from India's cybersecurity nodal agency, CERT-In, about risks posed by autonomous AI agents accessing live systems within Indian organisations.

According to the advisory, such agents accessed business records, including personal and confidential data, by exploiting conventional vulnerabilities.

Rising airfares steering travellers towards road trips

Aishwarya Kumar
Bengaluru

A holiday that once began with a flight search is increasingly starting with a road trip. With airfares rising, travellers are opting for buses and destinations closer home rather than dropping their plans. For the travel and hospitality industry, the shift is creating opportunities in places accessible by road.

Travel platform Cleartrip's data point to the trend. During the summer, bus trips on routes under 300 km rose over 80 per cent, while flights on these routes declined. Buses accounted for more than 34 per cent of combined bus and air trips in this distance band. Bus journeys on routes spanning 300-500 km grew over 68 per cent, while those in the 500-1,000 km band rose 89 per cent.

The shift is not just about cheaper travel. An expanding highway network is making more destinations accessible, turning places once considered too far for a short break into viable options for family holidays and weekend getaways.

DRIVE-TO DESTINATIONS

"Destinations that were once considered difficult to reach are becoming practical options for family holidays and weekend breaks," said Anupam Dutta, Chief Marketing Officer of Sterling Holiday Resorts. For Bengaluru travellers, this could mean swapping airport queues for drives to Coorg or Sakleshpur or venturing further into the Nilgiris. Hospitality players are tracking the trend. Rosetta, which operates a property in Sakleshpur, is exploring other destinations within driving distance of Bengaluru.



LOW-COST OPTION. From hill retreats to religious centres, road-accessible destinations are gaining traction as travellers seek affordable weekend getaways

"There are a couple of opportunities being presented to us in other drive-distance locations from Bengaluru, the Nilgiris, for example," said Jai Sreedhar, Joint MD and CEO of Rosetta. The appeal extends beyond hill retreats.

Cleartrip said bus travel to destinations grew 78 per cent overall during the summer, with Haridwar, Rishikesh, Tirupati, Ujjain, Goa, Udaipur and Nashik recording triple-digit growth. These destinations remained popular during the festive season, when overall bus travel growth reached 141 per cent.

For hotels, the shift could influence not just where people travel but also how they spend. Savings on transport may allow some travellers to maintain or upgrade their accommodation, while others may opt for budget stays to keep overall holiday costs in check.

TRAVEL SAVINGS

"Across the industry, we expect road-based leisure demand to gain share, particularly during long weekends and holiday periods," said Sarbendra Sarkar, Founder and MD, Cygnett Hotels & Resorts.

The company expects a mid single digit percentage point shift towards road travel in relevant drive-to markets, though the extent will vary by property and season.

The bigger opportunity may lie in travel frequency. Two- and three-night breaks are becoming an important part of domestic leisure travel, particularly for urban professionals and families seeking a getaway without extensive planning or taking too much time off work.

US moves to bar China's DeepSeek from federal agency systems

Bloomberg

The Trump administration barred civilian US government agencies from using products or services from Chinese artificial intelligence startup DeepSeek, citing a potential threat to national security from the company's operations in China.

Federal agencies must remove any DeepSeek products from their systems, according to a notice posted Monday by the Department of Homeland Security on the Federal Register website. An accompanying order, dated July 24 and signed by Homeland Security Secretary Markwayne Mullin, also barred the firm from participating in federal government contracts. Chinese Foreign Ministry spokesperson Mao Ning said her country "has consistently objected to the overextension of national security concerns and the politicization of technology and trade." Since DeepSeek's breakthrough R1 model rattled global markets last year, the company has faced scrutiny from policy makers in Washington.

AstraZeneca Pharma shifts base to Maharashtra from Karnataka

PT Jyothi Datta
Mumbai

Multinational drugmaker AstraZeneca Pharma India is set to move its registered office from Karnataka to Maharashtra. Just last week, it unveiled its new corporate office in Mumbai, inaugurated by the Maharashtra Chief Minister.

In May, AZ had told the stock exchanges that shareholders of the company had "approved the shifting of the company's registered office from the State of Karnataka to the State of Maharashtra".

The relocation of its corporate office and employees, which has just taken place, marked the next phase of growth for the company by expanding access to innovation and deepening partnerships, it said.

Explaining the move, a company spokesperson told *businessline*, "Proximity to key healthcare institutions, partners, policy and financial ecosystems will help us address the country's most pressing healthcare needs".



STRATEGIC FOOTPRINT

The new corporate office, spread across 25,600 sq ft, will be home to nearly 300 employees across medical affairs, strategy, marketing and business management, human resources and corporate affairs, among others, the representative said.

"Our commercial sales organisation continues to be spread across the country. Bengaluru remains an important hub for AstraZeneca and will continue to be a strategic footprint with key global operations being supported from the city," the representative added.

Last September, AZ surrendered its manufacturing licence, two years ahead of the expiry date. It was the drugmaker's only plant in India. "We announced plans to exit our Bengaluru manufacturing facility in 2023 as part of a strategic review of global manufacturing and supply network. Since then, we have successfully transitioned our manufacturing activities while maintaining the supply of medicines to patients," the spokesperson said.

AstraZeneca introduced more than 25 medicines and indications in India over the past three years and is running about 80 global clinical trials in the country to help develop new treatments, besides strengthening India's contribution to global research and getting medicines to patients faster, it said.

MOVE TO MUMBAI

Praveen Rao Akkinepally, AstraZeneca Pharma India's Country President and Managing Director, said a stronger Mumbai presence strengthened the company's ability to work with partners across the healthcare ecosystem and advance solutions for local patients. The company has a 5,000-odd workforce across the country.

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LOAN DISBURSEMENTS* ₹10,579 crore Up by 31%
LOAN BOOK* ₹97,411 crore Up by 15%
REVENUE FROM OPERATIONS* ₹2,345 crore Up by 14%
NET WORTH* ₹14,337 crore Up by 11%
NET NPAs* 1.08% Improved by 45%

Extract of Audited Financial Results for the Quarter and Half Year Ended September 30, 2026

(₹ in crores)

Sr. No.	Particulars	Standalone						Consolidated					
		Quarter ended			Half Year ended		Year ended	Quarter ended			Half Year ended		Year ended
		30-Sep-26	30-Jun-26	30-Sep-25	30-Sep-26	30-Sep-25	31-Mar-26	30-Sep-26	30-Jun-26	30-Sep-25	30-Sep-26	30-Sep-25	31-Mar-26
		(Audited)	(Unaudited)	(Audited)	(Audited)	(Audited)	(Audited)	(Audited)	(Unaudited)	(Audited)	(Audited)	(Audited)	(Audited)
1.	Total Income from Operations	2,344.75	2,249.54	2,057.45	4,594.29	4,016.98	8,337.48	2,346.88	2,250.60	2,057.85	4,597.48	4,017.69	8,338.89
2.	Net Profit/(Loss) for the period (before Tax, Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	706.57	412.72	696.07	1,119.28	1,000.70	2,336.92	704.45	413.75	696.39	1,118.20	1,001.23	2,337.58
3.	Net Profit/(Loss) for the period before Tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	706.57	412.72	696.07	1,119.28	1,000.70	2,336.92	704.45	413.75	696.39	1,118.20	1,001.23	2,337.58
4.	Net Profit/(Loss) for the period after Tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	554.26	337.50	549.00	891.75	795.68	1,873.34	552.14	338.53	549.33	890.67	796.21	1,874.00
5.	Total Comprehensive Income for the period [Comprising Profit/(Loss) for the period (after Tax) and Other Comprehensive Income (after Tax)]	427.65	277.65	614.00	705.30	879.38	1,993.46	425.99	278.30	614.76	704.29	880.97	1,997.15
6.	Paid-up Equity Share Capital (Face Value of ₹10/- each)	2,809.23	2,809.23	2,809.23	2,809.23	2,809.23	2,809.23	2,809.23	2,809.23	2,809.23	2,809.23	2,809.23	2,809.23
7.	Other Equity	11,528.17	11,323.27	10,110.95	11,528.17	10,110.95	10,972.12	11,531.21	11,327.96	10,112.92	11,531.21	10,112.92	10,976.19
8.	Securities Premium Account (net)	2,737.56	2,737.56	2,737.56	2,737.56	2,737.56	2,737.56						
9.	Net Worth	14,337.40	14,132.50	12,920.18	14,337.40	12,920.18	13,781.35						
10.	Paid-up Debt Capital/Outstanding Debt	80,882.38	79,002.01	69,939.39	80,882.38	69,939.39	77,845.63						
11.	Debt Equity Ratio	5.64	5.59	5.41	5.64	5.41	5.65						
12.	Earnings Per Share (of ₹10/- each) (for continuing and discontinued operations)												
	A. Basic:	1.97	1.20	1.97	3.17	2.88	6.73	1.97	1.21	1.97	3.17	2.88	6.73
	B. Diluted:	1.97	1.20	1.97	3.17	2.88	6.73	1.97	1.21	1.97	3.17	2.88	6.73
13.	Debenture Redemption Reserve	-	-	439.01	-	439.01	-	-	-	439.01	-	439.01	-

Notes:

a) The above results have been recommended by the Audit Committee of Directors and approved by the Board of Directors in their respective meetings held on 19.10.2026 and have been audited by the Joint Statutory Auditors of the Company.

b) The above is an extract of the detailed format of quarterly & half yearly financial results filed with Stock Exchanges under Regulation 33 & 52 of the SEBI LODR Regulations. The full format of the said financial results are available on the website of the Company, www.ireda.in/financial-results, and on the websites of the Stock Exchanges, www.bseindia.com & www.nseindia.com.

c) For the other line items referred in Regulation 52(4) of the SEBI LODR Regulations, pertinent disclosures have been made to the Stock Exchanges and can be accessed at www.bseindia.com & www.nseindia.com, respectively.

For and on Behalf of the Board of Directors
Sd/-
Dr. Bijay Kumar Mohanty
Chairman & Managing Director (Addl. Charge);
Director (Finance)
DIN No.: 08816532

Date: 19.10.2026
Place: New Delhi

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